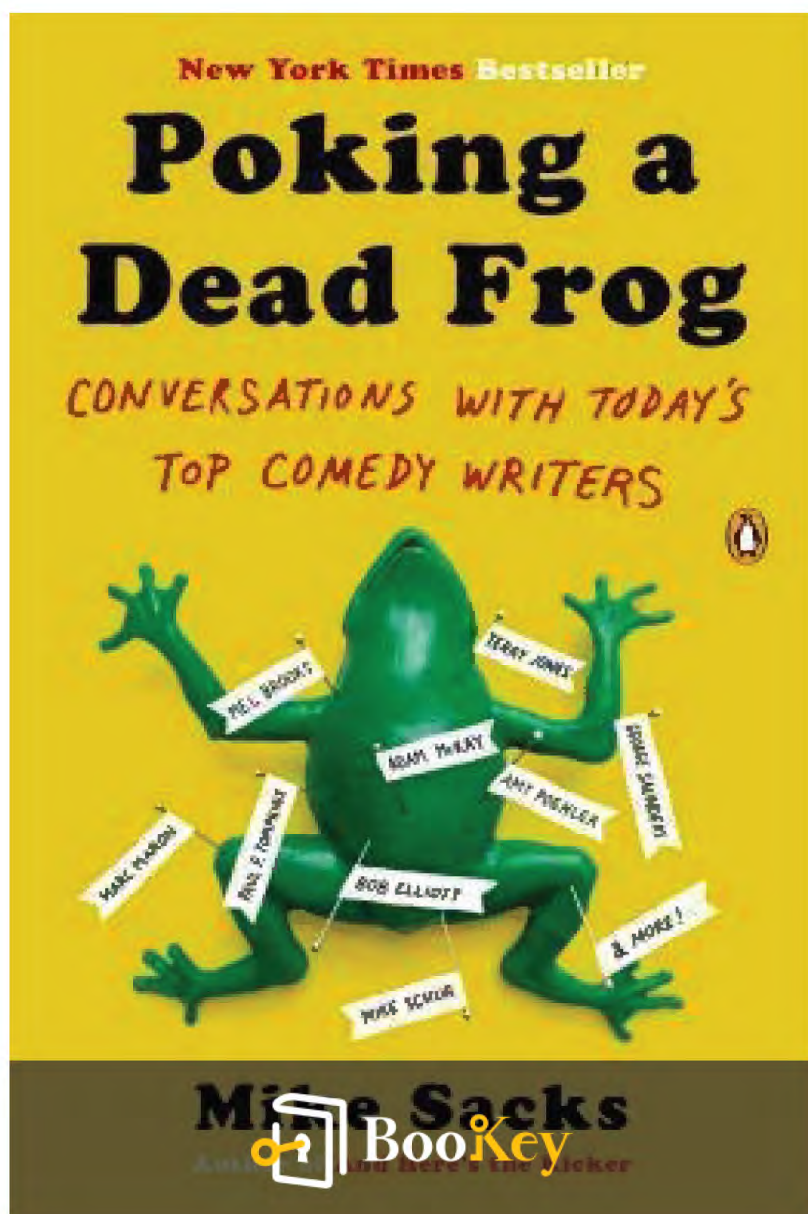


Poking A Dead Frog PDF

Mike Sacks



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Poking A Dead Frog

Unveiling the Secrets Behind Comedy's Greatest Moments and Minds.

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About the book

In "Poking a Dead Frog," acclaimed author Mike Sacks invites readers on an engaging journey into the intricate and often hilarious world of comedy. This captivating collection features insightful interviews with iconic figures such as Amy Poehler, Mel Brooks, Adam McKay, and many others, revealing astonishing behind-the-scenes tales—from the inner workings of The Onion's writers' room to the challenges of getting sketches featured on Saturday Night Live. With a perfect blend of humor and depth, this book is essential reading for comedy enthusiasts, aspiring writers, and anyone with a love for pop culture. As celebrated figures in the comedy world highlight, "Poking a Dead Frog" is not just a collection of stories; it's a masterclass in the art of laughter.

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About the author

Mike Sacks is a celebrated author and humorist known for his sharp wit and insightful commentary on comedy and culture. With a background in writing for prestigious publications such as *The New Yorker*, *Vanity Fair*, and *The Atlantic*, Sacks has established himself as a distinctive voice in the literary world. His book "Poking a Dead Frog," which explores the creative processes of various comedians and writers, reflects his keen understanding of humor and storytelling. Sacks's work often delves into the intricacies of the comedy industry, offering readers a blend of interviews, anecdotes, and personal reflections that reveal the artistry behind laughter. Through his unique perspective, he not only entertains but also enriches the landscape of contemporary humor writing.

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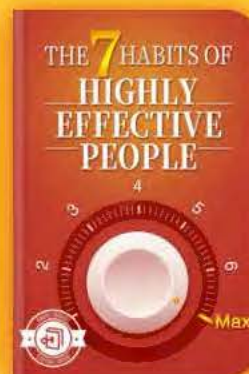
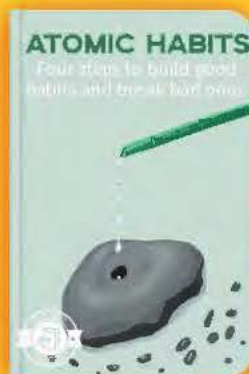
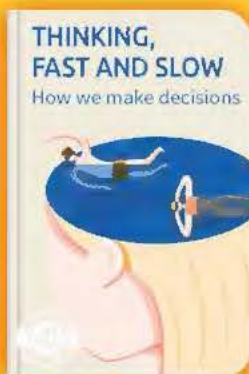


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Chapter 1 Summary : Interview: JAMES DOWNEY (Saturday Night Live)



Section	Summary
Introduction to James Downey	James Downey, an influential comedy writer for SNL, started at Harvard's Lampoon and was recruited by Lorne Michaels after catching the attention of prominent writers.
Career Highlights and Contributions	Known as "Patient Zero" for SNL comedy, Downey shaped humor and political satire, collaborating with notable figures and making a significant impact over four decades.
Retirement and Reflection	Downey retired in 2013, expressing disdain for lazy political comedy and celebrity walk-ons, which he believed undermined genuine humor.
Thoughts on Hosting and Performers	He emphasized the importance of hosts connecting with the writers' vision, praising successful hosts like Nicolas Cage while criticizing poor engagement from others.
Experiences with Censors and Controversial Sketches	Downey discussed challenges with network censors that limit creative expression, particularly with sensitive topics, while maintaining comedic integrity.
Views on Originality and Audience Connection	He noted the tension between original writing and familiar scenarios, valuing SNL's live format for timely comedy over filmed content.
Final Thoughts on Comedy Writing	Encouraging aspiring writers, Downey stressed developing a unique voice, collaboration, and vulnerability in creative work for success in comedy.

Summary of Chapter 1: James Downey and Saturday Night Live



Introduction to James Downey

James Downey, a significant comedy writer for "Saturday Night Live" (SNL), began his journey at Harvard as president of the Harvard Lampoon. He caught the attention of prominent writers Michael O'Donoghue and Doug Kenney, leading him to New York. After a brief fellowship touring Eastern Europe, he was recruited by Lorne Michaels to SNL, making an indelible mark on the show.

Career Highlights and Contributions

Downey, recognized as "Patient Zero" for SNL's comedic writing, became influential in shaping the show's humor, especially in political satire. His collaborations encompassed notable figures like Bill Murray, Dan Aykroyd, and Gilda Radner, among others. His work extended over four decades, co-writing sketches for various key political figures, which earned praise for their impact beyond mere entertainment.

Retirement and Reflection

After serving at SNL for thirty-three seasons, Downey retired



in 2013, yearning for a simpler life. Reflecting on his experiences, he expressed a disdain for lazy political comedy that prioritizes agreement over genuine humor, labeling it "claptrap." He highlighted his profound aversion to celebrity walk-ons during sketches, which he felt diluted the essence of comedy.

Thoughts on Hosting and Performers

Downey shared insights regarding successful hosts on SNL, emphasizing their ability to connect and surrender to the writers' vision. He praised notable hosts like Nicolas Cage and Justin Timberlake for their comedic instincts, while mentioning poor hosts like Steven Seagal, who failed to engage with the show's format.

Experiences with Censors and Controversial Sketches

Downey discussed the challenges posed by network censors that occasionally stifled creative sketches, particularly those addressing sensitive topics, showing a desire to push boundaries without losing comedic integrity.



Views on Originality and Audience Connection

He believed that writers often obsess over originality while performers capitalize on familiar scenarios, noting the balance between inventive writing and audience engagement. Downey regarded the live format of SNL as ideal for timely comedy compared to film.

Final Thoughts on Comedy Writing

Addressing aspiring writers, Downey encouraged developing a unique comedic sensibility, collaborating with peers, and venturing into vulnerable creative spaces. He emphasized the importance of producing work that reflects individual perspectives, fostering success and innovation in comedy writing.

This summary encapsulates Downey's influential role in SNL while illustrating his perspectives as a seasoned writer and mentor in the comedy landscape.



Example

Key Point: The Essence of Successful Comedy Writing

Example: Embrace creativity while daring to connect deeply with the audience, providing insights into the power of vulnerability.



Chapter 2 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Monty Python: TERRY JONES



Chapter 2 Summary: Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge

Terry Jones on Comedy and Writing

Terry Jones reflects on his early experiences with comedy, recalling a childhood incident where he attempted to get attention but ended up causing confusion among his family. This taught him that comedy can provoke strong reactions, unlike tragedy, which tends to elicit less anger if done



poorly. Since the age of seven, Jones had a passion for writing, particularly poetry, and found support from a teacher who encouraged him. However, societal pressures made him doubt the feasibility of a career in writing.

Connection Between Poetry and Comedy

Jones believes there is a strong link between poetry and comedy, suggesting that both require the distillation of ideas into a concise form. He cites Robert Browning's notion of combining separate ideas to create something new, relating it to how comedy can generate laughs from disparate concepts. An example from Monty Python is discussed, highlighting a sketch that merged unexpected elements to achieve humor.

Challenges in Monty Python Writing

Jones emphasizes that creating quality sketches for Monty Python was a serious endeavor, and the group's collaborative effort resulted in a unique comedic voice that could not be replicated. Over time, their audience's response evolved, as initial viewers struggled to understand the show's humor. There were concerns about censorship from the BBC, particularly involving sketches that included controversial



topics.

Creative Process and Edits

He shares insights into their writing process, noting that they would often create extensive content that underwent significant cuts before the final product. This included iconic scenes that were refined to maintain focus and comedic impact. A notorious example is the "Mr. Creosote" scene from **The Meaning of Life**, which pushed boundaries of taste and took considerable effort to produce.

Preservation of Python's Work

The chapter also reveals the precarious nature of preserving Monty Python's original material, as the BBC almost wiped early tapes to make room for other programming. Thankfully, the team managed to save their work, which has become an integral part of comedy history.

Advice for Young Comedians

Jones advises aspiring comedy writers to prioritize making people laugh, suggesting that if their work fails to provoke



laughter, they should reevaluate their approach. Overall, the chapter highlights the intricate balance of creativity, collaboration, and the unpredictability of comedy as an art form.

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Chapter 3 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DIABLO CODY (Juno, Young Adult, Sweet Valley High)

Section	Key Points
Diablo Cody – Screenwriter/Director	Grew up in a conservative Polish-Catholic community in Chicago. Parents viewed writing as a hobby, influencing her perception of the industry. Identifies as lazy but enjoys writing; emphasizes continuous improvement. Advocates for prioritizing personal resonance in writing and the importance of spec scripts. Encourages originality and personal storytelling.
Carol Kolb – Writer for The Onion	Unconventional path to writing, sparked by a quirky toilet paper museum. Background of shyness and dysfunctional family; humor as a coping mechanism. Learned to approach taboo subjects humorously from working in a psychiatric home. Early struggles shaped her comedic sensibilities at The Onion.
Advice for Aspiring Comedy Writers – Gabe Delahaye	Accept initial inadequacies; embrace the journey to improve. Write what you find funny, not what you think others will like. Be willing to work for free initially for experience. Avoid pointless online arguments. Appreciate your audience when you get one. Understand quitting is an option if it isn't fulfilling. Surround yourself with more talented individuals to foster growth.
Overall Emphasis	Authenticity, personal resonance, and the importance of persistent creative development in comedy writing.



Summary of Chapter 3: Poking a Dead Frog

PURE, HARD-CORE ADVICE

Diablo Cody – Screenwriter/Director

- Diablo Cody reflects on her upbringing in a conservative Polish-Catholic community in Chicago, which was disconnected from Hollywood. She describes her parents as practical and risk-averse, believing writing was just a hobby, thus shaping her view of the entertainment industry filled with dreamers.
- Cody identifies as lazy but enjoys writing, which keeps her engaged. She notes that many comedy writers are often ambitious types unlike her defiant nature. She encourages aspiring writers to work on their material constantly and prioritize what resonates personally, emphasizing spec scripts' importance.
- The tone and depth of stories, particularly those about suburban misfits, influence her writing style. She advocates for originality and personal storytelling in creative work.

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Chapter 4 Summary : Interview: MIKE SCHUR (Saturday Night Live, The Office, Parks and Recreation

Section	Summary
Introduction to Mike Schur	Mike Schur is a renowned writer known for his work on NBC comedies including "Saturday Night Live," "The Office," and "Parks and Recreation," with significant influence from David Foster Wallace's "Infinite Jest."
Early Life and Career	Born in 1975 in Michigan and raised in Connecticut, Schur developed a passion for comedy, starting his career with "Saturday Night Live" before moving on to "The Office" and co-creating "Parks and Recreation."
Writing Philosophy	Schur emphasizes collaboration in television writing, prioritizing strong storytelling and character development over individual jokes for a lasting impact on audiences.
Influences and Inspirations	Schur's comedic influences include Woody Allen and Monty Python, as well as thematic inspirations from Thomas Hardy and the honesty found in Wallace's work.
Television Writing Challenges	He discusses the challenges of audience expectations and the tight schedules of television writing that require maintaining quality while fostering creativity.
Character Development and Growth	Schur believes in creating relatable, three-dimensional characters to ensure comedic moments and emotional arcs, aiming for satisfying character conclusions.
The Role of the Writers' Room	The writers' room atmosphere influences show tone, with Schur advocating for a supportive environment to enhance collaboration and creativity.
Advice for Aspiring Writers	He encourages aspiring comedy writers to develop their unique voices, focus on improvement, and recognize the importance of both good writing and audience engagement.
Conclusion	Schur's approach is characterized by collaboration, sincere storytelling, and humor, reflecting his dedication to producing impactful television.

Summary of Chapter 4: Mike Schur

Introduction to Mike Schur

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Mike Schur, a prominent writer known for his work on NBC comedies like "Saturday Night Live," "The Office," and "Parks and Recreation," draws significant inspiration from David Foster Wallace's "Infinite Jest." His deep connection with the novel includes writing his thesis on it at Harvard and creatively referencing it in various projects.

Early Life and Career

Born in 1975 in Ann Arbor, Michigan, Schur was raised in West Hartford, Connecticut, where he developed an early interest in comedy, aided by his involvement with the Harvard Lampoon. He began his professional writing career with "Saturday Night Live," eventually moving on to "The Office" and co-creating "Parks and Recreation."

Writing Philosophy

Schur emphasizes the collaborative nature of television writing, noting that credit can be elusive in this field due to constant revisions and teamwork. He values strong storytelling over individual jokes, explaining that characters and their emotional journeys create a more lasting impact on



audiences than isolated humor.

Influences and Inspirations

Schur's comedic influences include Woody Allen and Monty Python, as well as important films like "Midnight Run." He also acknowledges nontraditional influences, such as Thomas Hardy's "The Mayor of Casterbridge," for its themes of chance and character depth, and expresses appreciation for the profound honesty in Wallace's work.

Television Writing Challenges

Schur discusses the pressure of keeping up with high audience expectations in today's television landscape, where viewers have countless entertainment options. He recognizes that maintaining quality while working within tight schedules can be challenging, yet it also fosters creativity and rigor among writers.

Character Development and Growth

Effective character development is essential to Schur. He believes that creating relatable, three-dimensional characters



leads to natural comedic moments and emotional arcs. The goal at the end of each season is to achieve narratively satisfying yet surprising conclusions for the characters.

The Role of the Writers' Room

The atmosphere in a writers' room greatly affects the tone of a show. Schur prefers a supportive and joyful environment where collaboration thrives, as it contributes to generating creative and humorous content.

Advice for Aspiring Writers

Schur advises aspiring comedy writers to cultivate their unique voices and maintain a mindset of continuous improvement, avoiding complacency. He stresses that both good writing and audience engagement are vital, and writers should not take their success for granted.

Conclusion

Overall, Mike Schur's approach to writing and character development—rooted in collaboration, sincere storytelling, and a unique sense of humor—illustrates his commitment to producing high-quality, impactful television.



Example

Key Point: The importance of collaborative writing in achieving profound storytelling.

Example: As you sit in a vibrant writers' room filled with laughter and camaraderie, you realize that each character you develop is not solely your creation; rather, it's a manifestation of collective ideas and support from your peers, making the emotional journeys of these characters resonate deeply with the audience.



inspiration

Key Point: Collaboration is key to creativity.

Life inspiration: Imagine stepping into a vibrant workspace filled with passionate individuals, each bringing their unique talents to the table. This collaborative environment is not only a breeding ground for innovative ideas but also a reminder that sharing perspectives and working together can elevate any project beyond individual contributions. In your own life, whether you're drafting a report, launching a new project, or even pursuing personal growth, remember the power of teamwork. Engage with others, listen, and allow their insights to shape your journey. Embracing collaboration can lead to richer, more fulfilling experiences and open up pathways you might never have explored alone.



Chapter 5 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a Submission Packet for Late-Night TV:

TODD LEVIN

Section	Details
Chapter Title	Submission Packet for Late-Night TV by Todd Levin
Overview	Todd Levin's submission packet reflecting on his creative process, merits, pitfalls of ideas in late-night comedy.
Key Submissions and Commentary	"Riff," the Late Night Bully Concept: Conan confronts his high school bully, Riff. Current Thoughts: Fits classic late-night but has audience sympathy dilemma. Prognosis: Highly unlikely to air. Bootleg Round-Up Segment Concept: Conan showcases dubious-quality bootleg DVDs with absurd commentary. Current Thoughts: Comedic potential as a recurring desk piece. Prognosis: Pretty good chance of making it to air. Recession Survival Tips Concept: Conan suggests ridiculous ways to cope with economic hardships. Current Thoughts: Enjoyable blend of comedic elements. Prognosis: Extremely likely to air. DVD Commentary Spoofs Concept: Humorous mock commentary tracks for films. Current Thoughts: Effective but may be common. Prognosis: Decent chance of airing, but may face originality dismissals. New Character Parade Concept: Includes humorous yet flawed characters. Current Thoughts: Shows creativity but some lack originality. Prognosis: Questionable for air; needs strong performances.



Section	Details
Final Insights	Importance of understanding a show's comedic voice and balancing familiar with unexpected for success in the writers' room.

Chapter 5 Summary: Submission Packet for Late-Night TV by Todd Levin

Overview

This chapter presents Todd Levin's submission packet for *Late Night with Conan O'Brien*. Levin reflects on his creative process, the merits and pitfalls of his ideas, and provides insights into producing late-night comedy.

Key Submissions and Commentary

1.

"Riff," the Late Night Bully

- Concept: Conan confronts his high school bully, Riff, whose unfortunate condition leaves Conan feeling guilty about mocking him. The skit reveals themes of discomfort and humor.



- Current Thoughts: This fits the classic late-night formula but has flaws such as the potential audience sympathy dilemma with Riff.

- Prognosis: Highly unlikely to air.

2.

Bootleg Round-Up Segment

- Concept: Conan showcases dubious-quality bootleg DVDs and deliberately creates absurd commentary.

- Current Thoughts: This has comedic potential as a recurring desk piece due to its simplicity and visual appeal.

- Prognosis: Pretty good chance of making it to air.

3.

Recession Survival Tips

- Concept: Conan suggests ridiculous ways to cope with economic hardships via humorously depicted DIY theme parks and meal enhancers.

- Current Thoughts: This "thrasher" format blends various comedic elements and remained enjoyable over time.

- Prognosis: Extremely likely to air.

4.

DVD Commentary Spoofs



- Concept: Humorous mock commentary tracks for popular films.

- Current Thoughts: Simple yet effective, although common; relies on specificity to stand out.

- Prognosis: Decent possibility of airing, but may be dismissed for lack of originality.

5.

New Character Parade

- Characters included humorous yet flawed personalities, such as a jihadist with beautiful legs and a human sound effects machine with a tragic story.

- Current Thoughts: While the characters show creativity, some lack originality and may not resonate well with audiences.

- Prognosis: Questionable for air; requires strong performances to enhance comedy.

Final Insights

Levin emphasizes the importance of understanding a show's comedic voice while creatively embedding one's personal style into ideas. Balancing the familiar with the unexpected is crucial for success in securing a position in the writers' room.



Example

Key Point: Understanding the show's comedic voice is crucial for securing a writer's role.

Example: Imagine you are a writer, pitching ideas for a popular late-night show, feeling the pressure to fit the established style while wanting your unique flair to shine through. You realize that to succeed, you need to merge your personal comedic approach with the show's tone seamlessly. If your skit about absurd DIY solutions for economic hardship resonates with the show's existing humor while feeling fresh, you significantly increase your chances of making it onto the air. Recognize that the right balance of familiarity and innovation is essential, ensuring your work not only entertains but also aligns with the show's identity.



Chapter 6 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANDRÉS DU BOUCHET (Best Week Ever, Conan)

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE FROM ANDRÉS DU BOUCHET

Introduction to Comedy Today

Andrés Du Bouchet, a comedian and writer, reflects on the current landscape of comedy, noting significant changes since his early days in the field. There are notably more individuals now pursuing careers in stand-up, writing, and acting, alongside a plethora of tools and institutions that support these endeavors.

Current Opportunities for Aspiring Comedians

Today, aspiring comedians can take classes at various institutions like the Upright Citizens Brigade, utilize social media for networking, and share their performances on



platforms such as YouTube and Funny or Die. These advancements have made comedy a legitimate career option post-college, attracting a diverse range of individuals.

Essential Questions for Aspiring Comedians

Du Bouchet emphasizes the importance of self-reflection by posing two critical questions for aspiring comedians:

1. "Is this really what I want to do?"
2. "Do I need to be doing this?"

He explains that many comedians, including himself, felt an intrinsic need to pursue comedy—not merely as a career choice but as a means of self-discovery.

Path to Success in Comedy

The path to success requires relentless commitment to writing and performing comedy. Du Bouchet advises aspiring comedians to engage continuously in their craft over many years, building relationships within the comedy community. As these connections deepen, opportunities may arise, particularly through friends who break into the entertainment industry.

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great concept !!!highly recommended!

Rahul Malviya

Beautiful App



This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with
busy schedules. The summaries are spot
on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh
I've learned. Highly recommend!

Alex Walk

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Chapter 7 Summary : Interview: HENRY BEARD (National Lampoon, Bored of the Rings, Latin for All Occasions)

Section	Summary
Introduction to Henry Beard and Bored of the Rings	Henry Beard co-authored "Bored of the Rings," a parody that influenced comedy writers and has been in print for over 45 years.
Early Life and Education	Born June 7, 1945, Beard found his writing talent at the Harvard Lampoon and co-founded the National Lampoon in 1970 after a law school rejection.
National Lampoon's Impact	As executive editor, Beard helped National Lampoon gain over a million readers, producing satirical content on politics and history.
Transition Away from National Lampoon	Beard retired from the magazine in 1975, opting for a quieter life and avoiding the television and film industries.
Personal Reflections and Legacy	Having authored over thirty-five books, Beard reflects on his education's rigor and its lack of creative inspiration, citing Ernie Kovacs as influential.
Thoughts on Comedy and the Industry	Beard notes a shift towards television for new comedians and finds modern publishing challenging, recognizing the luck behind National Lampoon's success.
Collaboration with Doug Kenney	Beard collaborated with Kenney on multiple works and reflects on Kenney's tragic death, hinting at personal struggles and potential external factors.
Advising Young Writers	Beard advises aspiring humor writers to write consistently and acknowledges the creative toll of Hollywood, while expressing gratitude for his career.
Final Thoughts	The chapter captures Beard's views on humor writing's evolution and the unpredictable role of luck in achieving success.

Summary of Chapter 7: Henry Beard

Introduction to Henry Beard and Bored of the Rings



Henry Beard co-authored "Bored of the Rings," a parody of J.R.R. Tolkien's works published in 1969, which has remained in print for over 45 years. The book and Beard's comedic style significantly influenced generations of comedy writers, including those for "Saturday Night Live" and "The Onion."

Early Life and Education

Beard was born on June 7, 1945, and spent his early years at the Westbury Hotel in Manhattan. He discovered his writing talent at the Harvard Lampoon. Despite his initial intentions to attend law school, Beard's rejection led him to partner with Doug Kenney and co-found the National Lampoon in 1970.

National Lampoon's Impact

Under Beard's leadership as executive editor and later editor-in-chief, the National Lampoon quickly rose to popularity, boasting over a million readers. Its satirical content tackled various topics, including political figures and historic events. Beard wrote several memorable sections for the magazine, demonstrating his talent for humor.



Transition Away from National Lampoon

Unlike his peers, Beard did not transition to television or film and retired from the magazine in 1975, preferring a quieter life. He has since been reclusive regarding his time at National Lampoon and has largely avoided interviews.

Personal Reflections and Legacy

Beard has authored over thirty-five books, including humor guides and translations, but reflects on his early education as both a rigorous training ground and a period devoid of creative inspiration from television. He cites Ernie Kovacs as an influential comedic figure during his formative years.

Thoughts on Comedy and the Industry

Beard observes a significant shift in the comedic landscape, as new generations increasingly migrate toward television and screenwriting rather than print. He finds current publishing challenges daunting and is astonished by the luck and timing that defined the success of the National Lampoon.



Collaboration with Doug Kenney

Beard and Kenney collaborated closely on their works, including "Bored of the Rings." However, Beard reflects on Kenney's tragic death and speculates on the circumstances, hinting at a complex mix of personal struggles and potential external factors involved in Kenney's life.

Advising Young Writers

Concluding his reflections, Beard advises aspiring humor writers to write consistently and acknowledges the toll that Hollywood can take on creativity. While he expresses gratitude for his career, he recognizes the unpredictable nature of success in the field of comedy.

Final Thoughts

Ultimately, the chapter captures Beard's nuanced perspectives on humor writing, the evolution of comedic styles, and the unpredictable role of luck in achieving success in both print and digital media.



Chapter 8 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Getting the Details Right: JAMES L. BROOKS

Section	Summary
Influence of Paddy Chayefsky	James L. Brooks regards Paddy Chayefsky as a major influence, appreciating his creative control and ability to foresee societal issues in his films, despite some criticisms of his polished dialogue.
Research in Writing	Brooks highlights the significance of research in enriching scripts and characters, sharing how his research for <i>*Broadcast News*</i> resulted in authentic character traits drawing from real journalist experiences.
The Writing Process and Personal Struggles	Brooks discusses the difficulties of writing, including obsession and insecurity, comparing it to a contact sport, and acknowledges the intimidation many writers experience, regardless of their experience.
The Essence of Being a Writer	Brooks reflects on his evolution in identifying as a writer, advising new writers to engage freely with their craft without external pressures for greater fulfillment and creativity.

Chapter 8 Summary: James L. Brooks on Comedy and Writing

Influence of Paddy Chayefsky

James L. Brooks cites Paddy Chayefsky as a significant influence on his writing, highlighting Chayefsky's unique position as a screenwriter who retained creative control over his films. Brooks admires Chayefsky's ability to predict future societal issues through his work, exemplified by films



like **Network** and **The Hospital**. While some criticized Chayefsky's dialogue as overly polished or "written," Brooks defends it as emotionally impactful and relatable.

Research in Writing

Brooks emphasizes the importance of research in writing, noting that it enriches scripts and characters. He recounts his extensive research for **Broadcast News**, which helped shape his characters, leading to authentic traits based on real experiences from journalists.

The Writing Process and Personal Struggles

Brooks reflects on the challenges of the writing process, describing moments of obsession and insecurity. He believes that successful writing requires intense focus and integrity, comparing it to a contact sport. Even after years of experience, he admits that writing can be difficult and examines the intimidation many writers feel about their profession.

The Essence of Being a Writer



Brooks shares his journey towards identifying as a writer, underscoring the importance of losing oneself in the creative process. He encourages emerging writers to write freely and embrace their passion, suggesting that genuine engagement with writing can lead to unexpected success. By focusing on the work rather than external pressures, writers can find fulfillment and creativity in their craft.

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inspiration

Key Point: Embrace the creative process without fear of judgment.

Life inspiration: Imagine yourself sitting down with a blank page, the weight of expectation looming over you. As you recall James L. Brooks' words, you feel a surge of courage. You realize that the essence of being a writer isn't about perfection or meeting others' standards; it's about surrendering to your passion and the messy, beautiful exploration of your thoughts. In that moment, you choose to let go of self-doubt and the fear of imperfection, allowing your words to flow freely. Inspired by Brooks' emphasis on authentic engagement, you begin to see your writing not as a daunting task, but as a profound journey of self-discovery. This chapter reminds you that when you immerse yourself wholeheartedly in your craft, unshackled by external judgment, you open the door to true creativity and fulfillment in your life.



Chapter 9 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MEGAN AMRAM (Parks and Recreation)

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE

Megan Amram

Writing comedy requires both playfulness and discipline. It's essential to practice regularly and consume a variety of comedic material to understand what works. Enjoying the process of writing is crucial; if you don't, it may not be the right path for you.

Megan shares her journey into comedy and Twitter. Initially inspired by a friend to start tweeting jokes as a form of practice, she unexpectedly gained traction, largely due to follows from industry insiders and fellow comedians. Her big break came when Jordan Rubin offered her a job writing for the Oscars, leading to her later role on *Parks and Recreation*, where she was recognized for her unique voice and comedic talent.



Despite the validation she finds on Twitter, Megan emphasizes that her primary focus is her writing job, underscoring the importance of prioritizing work over social media.

Her closing advice centers on enjoying what you do, engaging with your work, and remaining kind and approachable in a competitive environment.

Sampling of Tweets from Megan Amram

1. "I'm giving up spell check for Lent."
2. "This is a pretty shitty flash mob. It's in my living room, only my family showed up, and they're just telling me to stop drinking."
3. "Such a double standard that when a guy sleeps with a ton of people he's 'cool,' but when I do, I'm 'lying'."
4. "Face down, ass up, that's the way I want my open casket funeral."
5. "They call me the Titanic because I once went down on a bunch of Irish peasants."
6. "After my ex and I broke up, I was in a really bad place (Florida)."





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Chapter 10 Summary : Interview: PEG LYNCH (Ethel and Albert)

Chapter 10 Summary: Peg Lynch and "Ethel and Albert"

Overview of "Ethel and Albert"

- "Ethel and Albert" was a popular radio and television series created by Peg Lynch in the 1940s and 1950s, focusing on the mundane yet humorous daily lives of a young married couple.
- The series was known for its exploration of life's minutiae rather than relying on typical gag humor, a style that was innovative for its time.

Peg Lynch's Background

- Peg Lynch, a University of Minnesota graduate, began her career as a copywriter before creating "Ethel and Albert."
- The show started as brief filler segments, eventually



gaining enough popularity to air longer episodes and transitioned to television.

Comedic Style and Themes

- Lynch's writing was characterized by its focus on character-driven humor rather than punchlines, capturing the essence of domestic life.
- Lynch's personal experiences often inspired storylines in the show, highlighting relatable domestic conflicts.

Transition to Television

- The show successfully transitioned from radio to television, maintaining its core comedic style.
- Lynch remained the sole writer, noted for her ability to produce numerous scripts without repetition.

Legacy and Influence

- "Ethel and Albert" is often credited as one of the first sitcoms, influencing later shows like "Seinfeld."
- Lynch emphasized that life presents ample material for comedy, leading her to create over twenty thousand scripts



throughout her career.

Enduring Impact and Character Continuation

- At ninety-six years old, Lynch expressed interest in revisiting the characters of "Ethel and Albert," considering how they might navigate life in their advanced years.
- Her reflections reveal the often-overlooked nuances of aging and the ongoing relevance of humor in daily life.



Example

Key Point: Humor in the Mundane

Example: Imagine a couple bickering gently over whose turn it is to take out the trash; that simple exchange becomes a relatable, laugh-out-loud moment celebrating everyday life.



inspiration

Key Point: Find humor in the mundane.

Life inspiration: The brilliance of Peg Lynch's work in 'Ethel and Albert' teaches us that humor can be found even in the most ordinary aspects of daily life. As you go about your routine, remember to look for the little quirks and idiosyncrasies in your relationships and tasks. Embracing this perspective can not only lighten the weight of life's responsibilities but also inspire creativity and connection in your own storytelling and interactions. Just as Lynch transformed her domestic experiences into comedic gold, you too can uncover the hilarity in your everyday moments, allowing laughter to enrich your life.



Chapter 11 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Seinfeld: PETER MEHLMAN

ULTRASPECIFIC COMEDIC KNOWLEDGE: PETER MEHLMAN

Writing for Seinfeld

- Peter Mehlman wrote twenty-two episodes of *Seinfeld*, contributing notable lines to popular culture, such as "yada yada yada" and "double-dip."
- He didn't anticipate which lines would resonate with the public; they were always written to be funny and advance the plot.

Famous Lines and Their Origins

- Mehlman initially believed the "antidentite" line would become popular but was surprised when "yada yada yada"



took off instead.

- The term "double-dipping" came from a real-life incident at a party, where the concept was humorous enough to fit into the script.
- The "shrinkage" concept was co-created with Larry David, with the latter suggesting to use the word frequently.

Writer Submissions and Ideas

- Mehlman and other *Seinfeld* writers received countless submissions, mostly terrible, often filled with irrelevant dialogue.
- A significant challenge was maintaining tight scripts, typically ending up longer than the allotted time for episodes.

Creativity and Inspiration

- Writing for *Seinfeld* was all-consuming; Mehlman found inspiration from everyday experiences and stories, even while on vacation.
- Friends and family frequently suggested ideas, but most did not translate well into scripts, with only a couple making it into episodes.



Financial Success of Residuals

- Mehlman indicates he could still live well off residuals from *Seinfeld*, although the financial outcome varies for writers.

Modern Context of Writing

- If *Seinfeld* were written today, cell phones would change the dynamics of character interactions, making the storytelling simpler and perhaps less comedic.
- The creative process involved individual contributions from writers rather than a collaborative room, which Mehlman found more productive.

Script Writing Process

- Scripts took varying amounts of time to complete, with "The Yada Yada" being particularly quick. The challenge lay in intertwining multiple storylines.
- Larry and Jerry often rewrote submitted scripts to inject their humor and perspective.

Differences in Writing Styles



- Mehlman noted differences in their styles: Jerry focused on analogies while Larry emphasized situational humor, with each contributing uniquely to character dialogue.

Transition from Magazine to TV Writing

- Peter Mehlman transitioned from freelance magazine writing to *Seinfeld* after presenting a comedic article to Larry David.
- His episode, "The Apartment," was shaped collectively, leading to a successful collaboration.

Conclusion

- Mehlman's journey reflects a unique path from magazine writing to a beloved TV show, breaking the mold for comic writers and impacting the television landscape.



Example

Key Point: The unpredictable nature of comedic writing and its impact on popular culture.

Example: Imagine you're drafting a script and link a somewhat obscure joke only to find that it becomes the catchphrase everyone quotes. You're shocked as friends pepper your conversations with 'yada yada yada' at every family dinner, losing track of its humble roots. This illustrates how comedic writing can evolve beyond the writer's intentions, shaping culture in ways you never expected.



Chapter 12 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: PAUL F. TOMPKINS (Mr. Show, Best Week Ever, Bob's Burger)

Contributor	Advice/Insight	Key Points
Paul F. Tompkins	Advice	Collaboration in the Arts: Teamwork is essential across all roles. Networking and Relationships: Genuine relationships lead to opportunities. Selling Out: Working for money in pursuit of creativity is acceptable. Art and Personal Growth: Evolving as an artist is important.
Bruce Jay Friedman	Insight	Career Path: His writing journey blends humor and dark themes. Black Humor: Dark comedy opens avenues for exploration. Humor and Seriousness: Great writing combines humor with serious themes.
Kay Cannon	Advice	Self-Awareness in Writers' Rooms: Understanding one's role is key. Learning from Experience: Listen to experienced individuals to enhance creativity.
Bruce Vilanch	Guidance	Writing for Awards Shows: Extensive preparation is crucial. Adapting to the Moment: Improvisation is necessary in live scenarios.
Tom Scharpling	Insight	Creating Without Pressure: Writing freely yields better comedy. Building a Career: Persistence and connections are vital.
Dave Hill	Perspective	Writing for Fun: Focus on what entertains you. Facing Rejection: Resilience is important for continued creation.



Chapter 12 Summary: Pure, Hard-Core Advice

Advice from Paul F. Tompkins

1.

Collaboration in the Arts

: Emphasizes the importance of teamwork in creative mediums like film and television. All roles, from writers to grips, are vital in the completion of a project.

2.

Networking and Relationships

: Redefines networking as forming genuine relationships rather than merely seeking jobs. Genuine engagement leads to work opportunities.

3.

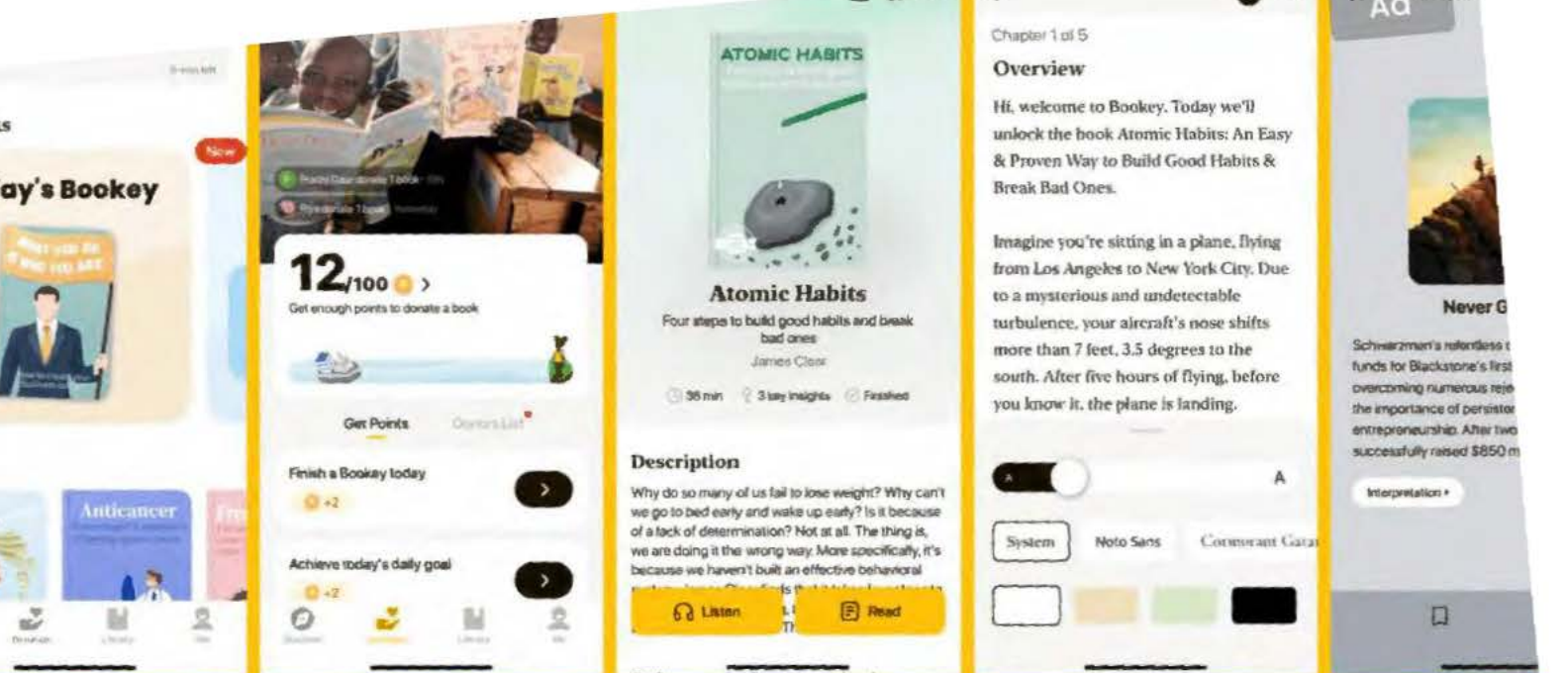
Selling Out

: Discusses what it means to sell out, asserting that working for money while pursuing creativity is acceptable and often necessary in life.

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Chapter 13 Summary : Interview: ADAM McKAY (Saturday Night Live, Anchorman, Talladega Nights, Step Brothers)

Section	Summary
Introduction	Will Ferrell labels Adam McKay as a "dangerous individual" with a unique sense of humor and a criminal edge, stemming from their successful collaboration.
Early Career	McKay began his comedy career in Chicago at Second City, gaining fame through bold political satire in shows like "Piñata Full of Bees."
Saturday Night Live	As a writer and head writer for SNL, McKay infused the show with dark, parodic comedy, setting the stage for his future in filmmaking.
Transition to Film	McKay's big break came with "Anchorman," leading to influential collaborations with Ferrell on films like "Step Brothers" and "The Other Guys."
Evolution as a Filmmaker	Despite mainstream success, McKay retains his rebellious nature and social critique, influenced by comedies like "Airplane!" in his work.
Comedy as a Medium for Truth	McKay views comedy as a "truth detector," gaining popularity due to political extremism and advancements in technology.
The Role of Passion in Success	He advocates for passion over fame in comedy, stressing that perseverance and authenticity are crucial for success in the field.
Conclusion	McKay's evolution from a comedian in Chicago to a Hollywood figure highlights humor's transformative power and the importance of creativity for new writers.

Adam McKay: The Dangerous Comedian

Introduction

Will Ferrell describes Adam McKay, his long-time friend



and collaborator, as a "dangerous individual" who possesses an extraordinary sense of humor paired with a criminal tendency. Their successful working relationship developed from McKay's early days of innovative and boundary-pushing comedy.

Early Career

McKay's comedy journey began in Chicago, where he was involved in legendary performances at Second City, particularly in the seminal revue "Piñata Full of Bees," which bravely tackled political and social satire. Coming from an admiration for mainstream comedians, McKay shifted to improv, quickly gaining notoriety for his provocative performances.

Saturday Night Live

After joining "Saturday Night Live" (SNL) as a writer and later head writer, McKay tried to enhance the show's edge with parodic and often dark comedy, creating memorable short films for the show's final minutes. His time there laid the foundation for a career in filmmaking.



Transition to Film

Hollywood wasn't instantly welcoming, but with the release of "Anchorman," McKay's career took off. He collaborated with Ferrell on several popular films, including "Step Brothers" and "The Other Guys," solidifying their partnership both on screen and in other ventures like "Funny or Die."

Evolution as a Filmmaker

Despite achieving mainstream success, McKay's early themes of exacting social critique remain present in modern projects. Filmmaker David O. Russell notes that McKay retains his rebellious spirit. McKay himself frequently cites how Comedic influences from films like "Airplane!" inform his own works, blending parody, satire, and absurdism.

Comedy as a Medium for Truth

McKay believes that comedy can serve as a "truth detector," resonating with various audiences across the political spectrum. He attributes the rise in comedy's popularity over the years to political extremism and advances in editing



technology.

The Role of Passion in Success

McKay emphasizes passion over fame, asserting that those who enter comedy for the right reasons tend to succeed. The key is perseverance and a genuine love for one's craft, making it essential for budding comedy writers to craft their unique voices while adhering to their comedic instincts rather than rigid rules.

Conclusion

In summary, Adam McKay's journey from an imaginative comedian in Chicago to a major figure in Hollywood underscores the transformative power of humor. He encourages new writers to embrace creativity over conformity, aiming to leave a lasting impact that inspires future generations.



Chapter 14 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Two Hundred Essential Movies Every Comedy Writer Should See: A List by BILL HADER

ULTRASPECIFIC COMEDIC KNOWLEDGE

A List by BILL HADER

Two Hundred Essential Movies Every Comedy Writer Should See

Bill Hader presents a personal list of two hundred essential movies that he believes every comedy writer ought to watch. The list includes both obvious choices, like "Airplane!", and more curious selections, such as "Eyes Wide Shut." Hader emphasizes the importance of these films in shaping his understanding of writing and acting. He aimed to include movies that are easily accessible on platforms like Netflix. Enjoy the discovery of influential films!



Key Movies Included

- 9 to 5 (1980)
- Airplane! (1980)
- Annie Hall (1977)
- The Big Lebowski (1998)
- Dr. Strangelove (1964)
- Groundhog Day (1993)
- Monty Python and the Holy Grail (1975)
- This Is Spinal Tap (1984)
- Toy Story (1995)
- Young Frankenstein (1974)

This compilation serves both as a guide for aspiring comedy writers and as a reflection of Hader's comedic influences.



inspiration

Key Point: The significance of cinematic knowledge in shaping creativity

Life inspiration: Imagine immersing yourself in a treasure trove of films, where each viewing opens a window to a unique perspective of humor and storytelling. Bill Hader's emphasis on the movies he's curated for aspiring writers is a rallying call to explore the world of comedy—an invitation for you to embrace the intricacies of comedic timing and character development. As you delve into remarkable works like 'Airplane!' and 'Groundhog Day', consider how these narratives spark inspiration within you, igniting your own creative journey. Each film can become a stepping stone, guiding you to discover your distinctive voice, reminding you that the pursuit of knowledge—be it through laughter or drama—can profoundly influence your path. So pick a film, watch, and let its lessons enrich your understanding of storytelling in life, coaxing out the humor and wisdom that could define your own narrative.



Chapter 15 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: SCOTT JACOBSON (The Daily Show, Bob's Burgers)

Topic	Summary
Hierarchy in Comedy Writing	Television comedy writing has a clear and often brutal hierarchy, with late-night shows viewed as stepping stones and multi-camera sitcoms being highly sought after.
Job Aspirations	Many comedy writers aspire to work on sitcoms due to better professional growth and potential financial benefits, despite the glamour associated with late-night shows like "SNL."
Workload Differences	There is a significant difference in the workload and pace between late-night comedy and sitcom writing, with late-night requiring fast-paced, high-stress writing and sitcoms appearing more leisurely but demanding deep story development.
Jacobson's Reflection	Scott Jacobson transitioned from late-night to sitcom writing, realizing that the slower pace is vital for narrative depth, while the fast-paced nature of joke-writing is more mechanical than it seems.
Challenges and Rewards	Both late-night and sitcom writing offer unique challenges and rewards, ultimately providing valuable compensation compared to earlier jobs like substitute teaching.

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE

SCOTT JACOBSON, Writer, The Daily Show, Bob's Burgers

In the realm of television comedy writing, a clear hierarchy exists that can be both brutal and ridiculous. Positions on smart, boundary-pushing late-night shows are often seen as stepping stones, while multi-camera sitcoms with attractive



casts are much coveted. Although jobs like writing for "Saturday Night Live" are deemed more glamorous, many comedy writers aspire to sitcoms due to better professional growth and potential financial benefits.

The transition from late-night comedy writing to sitcom writing can be arduous, as sitcom writers often protect their territory fiercely. For new entrants, the workload and pace between the two contexts vary greatly. Late-night shows demand fast-paced, high-stress writing, while sitcoms can seem leisurely during story-breaking sessions, despite requiring significant mental effort.

Jacobson, who started in late-night and transitioned to sitcoms, reflects on his initial misconceptions about writing for sitcoms. He found that slow-paced days are essential for deep story development, while the fast-paced nature of joke-writing can appear easier yet is often more mechanical. Ultimately, both realms possess unique challenges and rewards, with each offering valuable compensation compared to previous jobs like substitute teaching.



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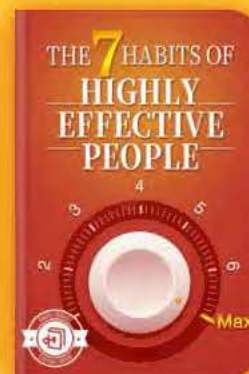
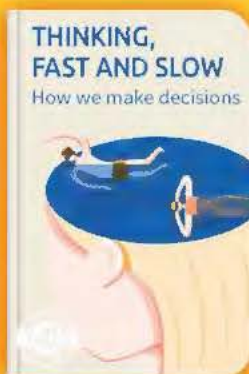


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Chapter 16 Summary : Interview: BRUCE JAY FRIEDMAN (Stern, The Heartbreak Kid, Stir Crazy, Splash)

Summary of Chapter 16: Bruce Jay Friedman

Background and Career

Bruce Jay Friedman has had a prolific writing career spanning over fifty years, during which he has published eight novels, four story collections, numerous plays, and well-known screenplays such as "Stir Crazy" and "Splash". Although not a household name, he garnered respect from peers, including Mario Puzo and Neil Simon, the latter adapting Friedman's story into "The Heartbreak Kid".

Early Life and Education

Friedman was born in the Bronx in 1930, aiming initially to become a doctor. However, he pursued journalism instead and served in the U.S. Air Force, where he was introduced to



significant literature that inspired him to write fiction. His novel "Stern", regarded as a masterpiece, illustrated a man's struggles moving from city life to the suburbs, highlighting themes of anxiety and anti-Semitism.

Humor and Writing Style

Friedman is credited as a pioneer of "dark comedy", finding humor in bleak situations. He distinguishes himself from traditional humorists, expressing that his intention is not necessarily to induce laughter but to convey serious narratives often with comedic undercurrents. He was influential in popularizing the term "black humor", which described works that explored dark themes with a satirical lens.

Writing Experiences and Influences

Friedman discusses his experiences working in the publishing industry, particularly with men's magazines, where he and contemporaries produced stories for a largely blue-collar audience. Notable figures from these circles included Mario Puzo, with whom Friedman had a personal encounter regarding screenwriting in Hollywood.



Reflections on Characters and Themes

Friedman's characters often reflect his personal experiences and internal struggles. Despite his characters' flaws, they retain a level of likability. He derived significant inspiration from his life and challenges, resulting in richly developed personas like Harry Towns, a drug addict grappling with his failures.

View on Modern Writing

Even after decades of writing, Friedman acknowledges the difficulty in the process, emphasizing the importance of honesty and focus. He offers practical advice for aspiring writers, discouraging overt attempts at humor while encouraging the exploration of truth in their narratives. His guiding principle remains to let stories develop naturally, suggesting simpler story prompts as potential starting points.

Final Thoughts

Friedman's interview offers insights into his literary journey, his approach to writing, and the evolution of his craft within



the context of an ever-changing literary landscape.

Throughout his career, he managed to maintain a tone of sincerity and respect for storytelling amidst the chaos of the entertainment industry.

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Chapter 17 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Jokes for Awards Shows: BRUCE VILANCH

Chapter 17: Writing Jokes for Awards Shows

Preparation for Televised Awards Shows

Writing jokes for prestigious events like the Oscars involves extensive preparation. Writers often create a substantial playbook—similar to a sports team's game plan—containing around 300 pages of material. This script is prepared months in advance, undergoing research on nominees, films, and potential scenarios that could occur during the broadcast.

Research and Joke Selection

Despite writing hundreds of potential jokes, only a few typically make it to the stage. This involves categorizing the material in anticipation of the event while leaving room for improvisation due to unpredictable moments, like



unexpected actions by award winners.

Impacts of Unscripted Moments

Unscripted occurrences during the ceremony can lead to spontaneous and memorable jokes. A notable example is Jack Palance's one-armed push-ups at the 1992 Oscars, which allowed writers to immediately pivot and craft humorous responses, showcasing the adaptability required in live comedy.

Censorship and Audience Sensitivity

Writing for a diverse global audience presents challenges in humor and appropriateness. Writers must navigate what is acceptable, often avoiding sensitive topics, while considering the host's career and legacy.

The Chaos of Live Joke Writing

Backstage during the Oscars, the writing process becomes frantic. Writers rapidly generate jokes in reaction to events happening during the broadcast. The atmosphere can shift depending on the audience's mood as the evening progresses,



making it crucial for hosts to engage both the live and home audiences effectively.

Host Dynamics and Audience Engagement

The choice of host greatly affects the show's tone. Successful hosts often bring a unique style, while performances that feel forced or are attempts to recreate prior routines may not resonate with audiences. For example, David Letterman's approach during the 1994 Oscars drew mixed reviews despite the live audience enjoying parts of it.

Challenges with Celebrity Presenters

Writing for celebrities who are not accustomed to comedic timing involves negotiation and consideration of their comfort levels. Many arrive with personal entourages, complicating the writing process. The fear of offending or making mistakes can hinder the effectiveness of comedic moments, showing the thin line between humor and caution. In conclusion, writing for awards shows is a complex, high-stakes process that combines extensive preparation, real-time adaptability, audience awareness, and an understanding of the unique dynamics of celebrity.



inspiration

Key Point: The Importance of Preparation and Adaptability in Life

Life inspiration: Just like the writers preparing for the Oscars, you can draw inspiration from their meticulous planning and need for adaptability in the face of unpredictable events. In your life, whether you're preparing for a big presentation, a family event, or navigating a career change, taking the time to prepare thoroughly can equip you with the knowledge and confidence to handle the situation effectively. But remember, much like live comedy, life often throws curveballs your way. Embracing flexibility and the ability to pivot when circumstances change will not only enhance your resilience but also allow your creativity to shine through, just as it does in the spontaneous moments of an awards show.



Chapter 18 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: KAY CANNON (30 Rock, New Girl, Pitch Perfect)

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE FROM KAY CANNON

Self-Awareness in Writing

Kay Cannon emphasizes the critical role of self-awareness in a writer's success, particularly in collaborative environments like a writers' room. Understanding one's role each day—be it a leader or a support figure—is vital for effective teamwork.

Listening and Learning

Cannon advocates for the importance of listening and learning from experienced peers. Speaking up only when necessary is essential; it's crucial to recognize one's place within the group's dynamics that can shift over time.



Balancing Thoughtfulness and Laziness

When receiving feedback, writers must discern between being lazy and being thoughtful. Cannon encourages introspection to decide whether to accept changes or trust one's creative instincts.

Commitment to the Craft

To succeed in television or film writing, immersion in the medium is key. Writers should watch a lot of TV or movies, and be well-acquainted with the shows they seek to write for.

Passion for Writing

Cannon describes her love-hate relationship with writing, underscoring the necessity of passion and commitment. She urges writers to push through exhaustion and prioritize their creative projects.

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Chapter 19 Summary : Interview: CAROL KOLB (The Onion, Community)

Carol Kolb: A Unique Comedy Journey

Background and Career

Carol Kolb, though not widely recognized outside niche circles, is a significant figure among comedy enthusiasts, especially for her work at *The Onion*, a satirical news source. Raised in a small Wisconsin town, Kolb's path to comedy began with her quirky project, the Madison Museum of Bathroom Tissue, which garnered media attention and led to her joining *The Onion* in 1997. Over time, she worked her way up to editor in chief and contributed significantly to the *Onion News Network*, earning a Peabody Award in 2009.

Childhood and Home Life



Kolb describes her childhood as mostly sad and lonely, shaped by parental conflicts and her own shyness. With a mother who grappled with anxiety and a father whose occupational life was unfulfilling, she found solace in her creativity. Her experiences at the psychiatric institution, where she worked as a nurse's aide, helped her develop a unique comedic perspective on taboo subjects.

Education and Early Adult Life

Kolb found some relief in her college experience at the University of Wisconsin, a stark contrast to her high school years. There, she became involved in the local comedy scene, leading to her eventual connection with *The Onion*. Her freelance contributions flourished after the publication transitioned onto the Internet, amplifying its reach.

Writing Style and Themes

Kolb's writing often touches on bleak aspects of life with a dark sense of humor. She explores themes of sadness, absurdity, and resilience, finding comedy in the mundane realities of life. Her ability to laugh amidst challenging circumstances is an essential aspect of her storytelling.



The Onion's Evolution

Kolb reflects on *The Onion*'s transformation from an underground publication to a well-known satire outlet. Its success changed its content focus from silliness to cleverness, adapting to current events while maintaining its core humor.

Response to 9/11

Following the tragic events of 9/11, Kolb and her team crafted a special issue addressing the chaos with sensitivity and humor, which resonated positively with readers. This experience exemplified the powerful role of comedy in coping with grief and uncertainty.

Current Perspective and Advice for Aspiring Writers

Kolb highlights that many successful comedy writers share a background of feeling like outsiders. She encourages aspiring writers to cultivate their voices and produce work through free or low-paying projects, rather than merely imitating



popular comedians or established formats. Kolb emphasizes the importance of authentic expression in developing one's comedic style.

In sum, Carol Kolb represents the complex interplay of personal experience and professional evolution within comedy, illustrating how humor can emerge from adversity.

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Example

Key Point:Authenticity in Comedy Writing

Example:Consider how your unique experiences shape your comedic voice. Embrace your individuality to create content that resonates deeply, like Kolb did through her dark humor and perspectives shaped by personal challenges. Tap into your own moments of adversity to find humor, enriching your storytelling in ways that feel authentic and engaging.

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Chapter 20 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge:: Choosing Headlines at The Onion: WILL TRACY

Summary of Chapter 20: "Choosing Headlines at The Onion"

Overview

In Chapter 20, Will Tracy, Editor-in-Chief of The Onion, discusses the editorial process of selecting headlines from a large pool of submitted jokes. He shares insights into the challenges of comedy writing, the repetition of themes, and the reasoning behind rejecting or accepting certain jokes.

Headline Selection Process

The Onion receives about 1,500 headlines weekly, creating a significant influx of comedic material. Only a small fraction of these jokes are deemed exceptional enough to be published, while others are discarded for various reasons.



Tracy analyzes nine rejected headlines, explaining the rationale behind their rejection, which often involves originality and thematic repetition.

Reasons for Rejecting Jokes

1.

Obvious or Clichéd Jokes

: Some jokes, like those about Quentin Tarantino, feel overly familiar and predictable.

2.

Previously Published Jokes

: If a joke has been made by another comedy outlet, such as McSweeney's or even The Simpsons, it is often discarded.

3.

Excessive Similarity

: Jokes that belong to a specific genre but have been overused are also often halted in their tracks.

4.

Lack of Escalation or Complexity

: Some jokes fail to provide sufficient comedic elevation or depth.

5.

Oversaturation of a Topic



: Jokes relating to certain popular themes may be set aside due to previous overexposure.

6.

Logical Inconsistencies

: Jokes that do not hold up under scrutiny may be dismissed as they lack coherence.

Examples of Accepted Jokes

Tracy also provides five examples of jokes that were accepted and explains their appeal:

1. *Ten-Year-Old Wishes Unemployed Father Couldn't Make It to Just One of His Little League Games*: This joke cleverly subverts expectations about parental involvement.
2. *Film Character Moves into Beautiful Brooklyn Brownstone after Getting Dream Publishing Job*: A satirical commentary on unrealistic portrayals in media.
3. *Report: Chinese Third Graders Falling Behind U.S. High School Students in Science, Math*: A cleverly worded joke that touches on serious educational themes while remaining humorous.
4. *Torrent of Soap Issues from Wildly Unexpected Part of Dispenser*: A comedic take on mundane events treated as major news.



5. *Robert Mapplethorpe Children's Museum Celebrates Grand Opening*: The thought of such a whimsical title prompts curiosity and humor.

Conclusion

Through this chapter, Tracy illustrates the meticulous process behind comedy writing and headline selection at The Onion, reinforcing the notion that humor often thrives on originality, clever execution, and the ability to resonate with audiences while avoiding repetition and predictability.



Chapter 21 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: GABE DELAHAYE (Videogum, This American Life, Funny or Die)

Summary of Chapter 21 from "Poking a Dead Frog" by Mike Sacks

Gabe Delahaye's Humorous Insights on Writing

Gabe Delahaye shares pragmatic advice for aspiring humor writers, emphasizing that aspiring writers should accept their initial inadequacies in order to improve. He lists key lessons including the importance of writing what one finds funny, being willing to work for free initially, and maintaining a friendly attitude towards audiences. Delahaye highlights the reality of the writing journey, asserting that it takes time and effort to progress.

Mike Schur's Background and Creative Process

Mike Schur recounts his journey from Harvard graduate and

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member of the Harvard Lampoon to a prominent writer and producer of acclaimed shows like *The Office* and *Parks and Recreation*. He discusses his early influences, the collaborative nature of television writing, and the pressures of maintaining quality while meeting deadlines. Schur also reflects on the significance of sincere storytelling without over-relying on irony.

Todd Levin's Submission Experience for Late Night TV

Todd Levin provides a peek into the rigorous writing process for late-night shows, discussing his submission packet for *Conan*. Levin shares insights on crafting sketches and the pressures of pitching ideas that land on air, underscoring the importance of originality and humor in submissions.

Andrés Du Bouchet's Advice for Comedy Writers

Andrés Du Bouchet discusses how the landscape of comedy writing has evolved, emphasizing the importance of self-awareness and unique voice in a competitive field. He encourages aspiring comedians to evaluate their genuine desire to write and perform comedy, all while actively

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Rahul Malviya

Beautiful App



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busy schedules. The summaries are spot
on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh
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Alex Walk

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Chapter 22 Summary : Interview: GLEN CHARLES (Taxi, Cheers)

Summary of Chapter 22 from "Poking a Dead Frog" by Mike Sacks

Introduction of James Burrows and "Taxi"

James Burrows, a renowned TV director, recalls a comedic moment from "Taxi" during a 2012 NPR interview, emphasizing its memorable laughter. The comedic scene involved Reverend Jim attempting to understand traffic lights.

Background of Glen and Les Charles

The Charles brothers, Glen and Les, were pivotal in creating the humor in "Taxi." Growing up in a Mormon family, they pursued creative writing and eventually sold their first scripts, leading to a significant career in television.



The Success of "Cheers"

The brothers worked with Burrows on "Cheers," which, despite a slow start, became a landmark sitcom, popularizing character-driven narratives and winning numerous awards.

Comedic Influences and Early Experiences

Les shares insights about their upbringing, their father's influence, and their experiences in comedy. Influential figures included Jackie Gleason and Bob Newhart, with an appreciation for how early radio shaped their writing style.

Navigating Comedy Writing and Collaborations

The Charles brothers discuss their partnership dynamics and the challenges of maintaining humor through the years. They highlight the importance of character service and collaborative writing.

Impact of "Cheers"

"Cheers" broke barriers by tackling serious topics while remaining funny. Unlike "Taxi," it developed a rich character



environment that resonated with audiences.

Ending and Cultural Legacy

The final episode of "Cheers" was significant and held much anticipation, elaborating on the closure needed for characters and the challenging dynamics of concluding a beloved show. The show's influence on future sitcoms is acknowledged, showcasing its legacy within the comedy genre.

Advice for Aspiring Writers

The chapter concludes with reflections on the nature of comedy writing, emphasizing life experiences and interpersonal dynamics as vital to developing scripts, alongside practical writing techniques. The importance of supporting fellow writers and maintaining humility within the industry is also underscored.



Chapter 23 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding an Agent for a TV-Writing Job: JOEL BEGLEITER

Finding an Agent for a TV-Writing Job

Young writers aspiring to write comedy for television can secure an agent through various means. The most effective routes are:

1.

Graduate from Internal Writing Programs

: Studios like Warner Brothers, Fox, and CBS offer programs that groom writers. Successful graduates receive endorsements from studio heads to agents.

2.

Referrals from Established Writers

: Connections with writers who are already signed can lead to recommendations that assure agents of the new writer's potential.

3.



Blind Submissions

: This method is the hardest and requires exceptional material due to the competitive nature of the industry.

Differences in Writing for Sitcoms vs. Late Night

The process varies significantly for sitcoms and late-night writing jobs:

-

Late Night Hiring

: It mainly relies on referrals and submissions, with head writers recruiting joke writers through their networks.

Submission packets are standard, containing specific writing samples.

-

Agent Necessity

: While not essential for late-night gigs, having an agent can inform writers of job opportunities and aid in the process.

Common Mistakes in Submissions

Writers often make basic errors such as:

- Typos in scripts, suggesting a lack of effort.



- Submitting unpolished material without adequate feedback from peers.

Importance of Cover Letters

Cover letters are largely irrelevant in the submission process, especially when referential connections exist.

Preference for Original Material

Agents prefer original works over scripts based on existing shows. The shift towards valuing original material emerged due to increased competition and the rise of reality television.

Differentiate Yourself

Writers must prove their unique voice amidst hundreds of submissions. A great sample script is crucial, but continued writing is essential for future opportunities.

Submissions for Other Comedy Forms

Writers can submit various formats of comedy writing, but this largely depends on the preferences of the showrunner.



Role of an Agent vs. a Manager

Agents secure jobs and negotiate contracts, while managers focus on a writer's long-term career development and material refinement.

Breaking into Television Writing

While it's difficult to get hired as a television writer without an agent, moving to Los Angeles and gaining experience as a production assistant or writer's assistant can lead to job opportunities and ultimately secure representation.



Chapter 24 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MARC MARON (WTF with Marc Maron, Maron, Conan, Late Show with David Letterman)

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE - MARC MARON

Understanding the Journey

Marc Maron reflects on his journey as a comedian, sharing the fears and uncertainties he faced when he encountered a creative wall. He emphasizes the absence of a structured plan in his career, admitting to impulsiveness, anxiety, and a lack of confidence that often made progress exhausting.

Navigating Limitations and Ego

Maron points out that awareness of one's talent and limitations can lead to a more fulfilling career in comedy. He notes that while many begin with the aspiration to be a big name, as they age, they recognize the challenges and the



improbability of reaching that level.

Building Relationships

He stresses the importance of building relationships within the comedy community during the struggle, asserting that these connections can support a lasting career. Maron mentions that many successful comedians transitioned into writing or production, adapting their skills to new opportunities.

The Inevitability of Choosing Comedy

Maron believes that pursuing a career in comedy isn't merely a choice; it often feels like a compulsion shaped by various influences, including rebellion or a need for self-expression. He acknowledges the harsh reality that many may fade away or struggle despite their efforts.

Hard Work and Resilience

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Maron concludes that while success in show business is unpredictable and not purely based on merit, those who put in the work and find their rhythm will ultimately find





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Chapter 25 Summary : Interview: GEORGE SAUNDERS (Pastoralia, In Persuasion Nation, Tenth of December)

Summary of Chapter 25: George Saunders

Introduction to George Saunders

George Saunders, a prominent contemporary writer and humorist, challenges the idea that humor is exclusive to comedians. Born in 1958 in Texas and raised in Chicago, Saunders transitioned from engineering to writing. His unconventional career path includes various jobs, such as a guitarist, doorman, and mover, before he found success in literature.

Literary Career

Saunders' debut collection, **CivilWarLand in Bad Decline**, was published in 1996, earning him immediate acclaim from notable figures like David Foster Wallace. Over the years, he



has published numerous bestselling works, receiving prestigious awards, including the MacArthur “Genius” Award in 2006.

Influence of Chicago

Growing up in South Chicago provided Saunders with a unique perspective on humor, intertwining high-serious topics with the funny. His education and upbringing emphasized the importance of language and guilt, shaping his approach to writing.

Family Impact and Personal Anecdotes

Saunders reflects on the influence of his parents and family values on his humor and writing. He fondly recounts anecdotes from his childhood, illustrating how humor was a coping mechanism for his family amidst life's challenges.

Compassion in Writing

He emphasizes the importance of compassion in writing, arguing that humor can coexist with deep truth. For Saunders, humor and serious content are intertwined,



creating a rich tapestry in storytelling.

Critique of Satire and Humor

Saunders differentiates between compassion-driven satire and mere harshness. He suggests that effective satire requires a deep understanding and connection to its subject matter, which stems from love for one's culture.

Literary Influences

Saunders discusses various literary influences, including Steve Martin and Monty Python, highlighting how their unique perspectives encouraged him to embrace humor in his writing.

Writing Process and Style

He describes his writing process as intuitive, pointing out the importance of sound and rhythm in prose. His breakthrough occurred during a mundane work meeting where humor emerged unexpectedly, leading him to incorporate it into his writing.



Characters and Themes

The characters in his stories are often complex, reflecting realism in their struggles. Unlike typical portrayals of eternal youth in modern media, his characters confront their adult responsibilities and challenges.

Magic in Writing

Saunders posits that creating magical moments in writing isn't an intellectual endeavor but rather a gut instinct to entertain and engage the reader deeply.

Ending Stories

He describes the ambiguity of concluding stories, where the critical gauge of success is ensuring that the reader remains engaged and charmed throughout the narrative.

Concluding Thoughts

In essence, George Saunders' reflections convey the intricacies of blending humor with serious themes, emphasizing the significance of compassion, personal



experiences, and an intuitive writing process that keeps both the writer and reader engaged.

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Chapter 26 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding a Literary Agent for Your Humor Book: BYRD LEAVELL

ULTRASPECIFIC COMEDIC KNOWLEDGE BYRD LEAVELL

Finding a Literary Agent for Your Humor Book

Literary agents often struggle with submissions they receive, and Byrd Leavell candidly admits this. Reflecting on advice from a respected editor, Leavell emphasizes that agents should actively seek out talent rather than waiting for submissions. Most promising comedians are leveraging the internet to showcase their talent and build an audience. He cites Justin Halpern, whose Twitter feed "Shitmydadsays" led to a successful book deal after years of dedication to humor writing.

Leavell argues that submitting ideas for humor books is largely ineffective, as publishers prioritize an author's



platform and viral content over the idea itself. To be taken seriously, authors must demonstrate not only writing skills but also an existing readership to generate interest in their book.

One crucial takeaway is that the majority of humor books fall short in delivering laughs, with Leavell estimating around 97% of them fail. Therefore, aspiring humor writers should focus on being part of the small percentage that does succeed in being genuinely funny to drive book sales.

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Chapter 27 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DAVE HILL (The New York Times, This American Life, Tasteful Nudes)

Chapter 27 Summary: Pure, Hard-Core Advice by Dave Hill

Purpose of Writing

Dave Hill emphasizes that the primary aim of writing and comedy is to entertain oneself. He views his creative output as a natural excretion, encouraging quick and pressure-free creation as a way to foster authenticity and enjoyment in the process.

Success Through Authenticity

Hill shares an anecdote about submitting a writing packet for a comedy show, highlighting how his relaxed approach led to unexpected success. By focusing on entertaining his friends



rather than seeking validation, he produced work that resonated with others.

Overcoming Initial Rejection

Reflecting on his early struggles in comedy, Hill recounts feeling crushed by rejection from industry figures but ultimately learned to embrace independence and focus on his unique style. This shift in mindset allowed him to eventually attract attention and build his career.

Embracing Failure

Hill advocates for a willingness to be foolish and fail, suggesting that reducing the fear of failure can liberate creativity. He shares his experience with his book proposal, where the fear of rejection initially delayed his process, but ultimately he came to terms with the idea that not being published wouldn't be the end of the world.

Simplifying Life and Relationships

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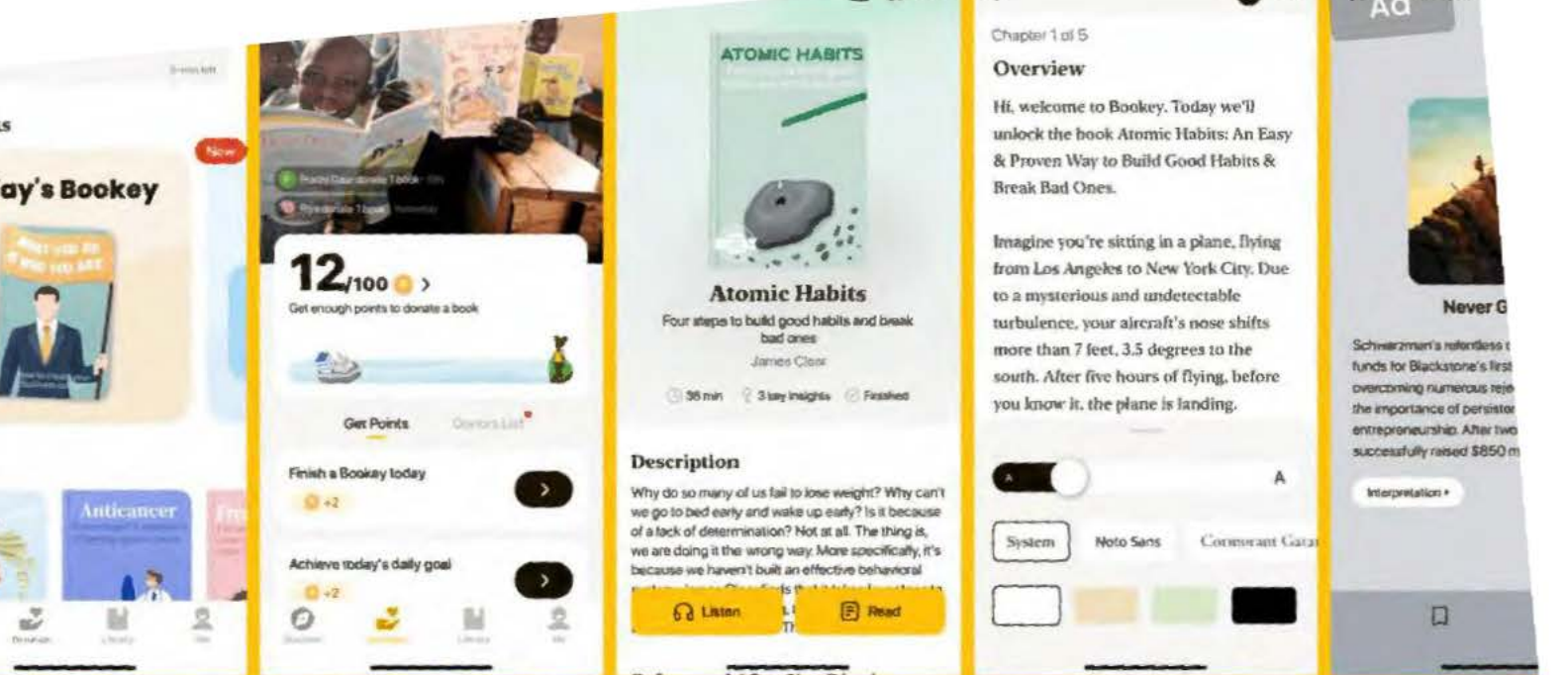
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He simplifies life's complexities by equating it to simple pleasures, like making and sharing spaghetti. Hill reflects on

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makes me feel, it's like
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Chapter 28 Summary : Interview: TOM SCHARPLING (The Best Show on WFMU, Monk)

Summary of Chapter 28: Tom Scharpling in "Poking a Dead Frog"

Overview of Tom Scharpling and Jon Wurster's Comedy

Rob Sheffield, in Rolling Stone, highlights Tom Scharpling and Jon Wurster as today's leading comedy duo for rock musicians, following the legacy of Derek and Clive. Their influential 1997 piece, "Rock, Rot & Rule," showcased their inventive long-form improv style, leading to a dedicated fan base.

Early Career and Best Show Development

Scharpling transitioned from music to comedy, initially creating a fanzine and running a radio music show. After the



acclaim of “Rock, Rot & Rule,” he launched

The Best Show

in 2000 on WFMU, mixing music and comedy while building a unique fictional universe centered around Newbridge, New Jersey.

Personal Background and Inspirations

Growing up in New Jersey, Scharpling worked various jobs from a young age, fostering his passion for music and comedy. Watching shows like David Letterman and later incorporating his love of horror into his creativity, he found success in comedy writing, notably on

Monk

.

Creativity and Comedy Structure

Scharpling emphasizes the connection between comedy and other genres, advocating for the necessity of real-world experiences in comedy writing. He reflects on the creative freedom of radio comedy, where longer narratives allow for deeper character development.



Creative Process and Character Development

Working closely with Wurster, Scharpling crafts tightly scripted sketches balanced with improvisation. They created over 200 characters in their Newbridge universe, noted for their absurdity and rich backstories, contributing significantly to the show's humor.

Philosophy on Success and Legacy

Scharpling expresses indifference towards fame and recognition, prioritizing personal fulfillment and connection with his audience. He emphasizes the importance of making work that resonates with the moment, rather than seeking eternal validation for their creations.

Conclusion

Overall, Scharpling's journey reflects a blend of hard work, a passion for storytelling, and the need for creative autonomy, showcasing how these elements contribute significantly to the evolution of modern comedy.



Chapter 29 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Radio: BOB ELLIOTT

ULTRASPECIFIC COMEDIC KNOWLEDGE

Bob Elliott: Influence and Legacy

Bob Elliott reflects on his journey as half of the iconic radio comedy duo Bob & Ray, discussing their deep-seated love for radio and the comedic influences from their childhood. Growing up in the 1920s and 1930s, Elliott and his partner Ray Goulding admired the groundbreaking comedy team Stoopnagle and Budd, noting their clever satire and character-driven humor.

The Evolution of Radio Comedy

Elliott emphasizes the unique appeal of radio, where imagination plays a crucial role, contrasting it with modern comedy that often lacks mystery. He recalls the popularity of



radio shows like "Vic and Sade" and how they shaped their comedic style, which was characterized by a surreal and understated approach.

Performance and Style

The duo's comedy, which often featured absurd situations and eccentric characters, received acclaim and drew inspiration from many sources, yet they perceived themselves as part of a continuum of comedic tradition rather than as innovators. Elliott laments the change in comedy today, where the immediacy of television diminishes subtlety and imagination.

Influence on Modern Comedians

Elliott expresses pride in being an inspiration for contemporary comedians like Paul Rudd and David Letterman, acknowledging the character-based nature of their humor compared to joke-driven styles. He highlights how they tackled political subjects, such as Senator McCarthy, ahead of their time.

Creative Process and Partnerships

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The writing process between Elliott and Goulding involved collaborative improvisation, producing distinctive sketches without relying on preapproved scripts. They maintained confidence in their characters and humor, despite recognizing that their style might struggle to fit within today's faster-paced media environment.

Enduring Legacy and Challenges

As Elliott reflects on their impact, he recognizes that though their work was revolutionary, it might not align with the preferences or expectations of current television executives. Ultimately, Elliott finds satisfaction in the freedom and creativity they enjoyed during their career, valuing the fun they had in their craft.



Chapter 30 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: AMY POEHLER (Saturday Night Live, Parks and Recreation)

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE FROM AMY POEHLER

Amy Poehler shares essential advice for comedy writers, emphasizing the importance of reading aloud to recognize how material sounds and being open to changes in one's work. Collaboration is vital, as talented individuals who embrace flexibility often find more opportunities. She encourages artists to persist despite challenges, suggesting that initial failures lead to growth and that embracing imperfections can lead to unexpected successes. Working with friends can be rewarding, and having a genuine passion rather than pursuing money is crucial for longevity in comedy.

ADAM McKAY'S COMEDY JOURNEY

Adam McKay is described as a dangerous individual with a



unique comedic vision, stemming from his grassroots experience at Chicago's Second City. He gained recognition for his work in political satire, aiming to provoke thought while entertaining audiences. His rise to fame began with SNL, where he honed his craft, although he faced challenges in trying to introduce a sharper, more subversive tone. Movies like **Anchorman** and **Step Brothers** showcase his approach of mixing satire with absurd comedy, driven by a fascination with characters who embody a misplaced confidence reflective of societal attitudes.

BILL HADER ON COMEDY WRITING

Bill Hader discusses the hierarchy within comedy writing, where working for respected projects can elevate status. Hader describes the contrasting environments of late-night shows and sitcoms, noting how both demand different skill sets. Writing for late-night requires quick turnarounds, while sitcom writing involves meticulous story crafting. Ultimately, success in comedy depends on one's passion for the craft over the pursuit of fame or monetary reward.

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Chapter 31 Summary : Interview: ROZ CHAST (The New Yorker)

Summary of Chapter 31: Roz Chast

Interview Insights

In a 2006 interview at the New Yorker Festival, comedian Steve Martin highlighted the intricacies of Roz Chast's cartoons, recognizing her work as a blend of visual and literary humor. Chast's unique ability allows her cartoons to stand alone without relying solely on visual elements.

Chast's Humor and Themes

Chast's cartoons feature intricate details that capture the mundane and often ignored aspects of life. With a career starting in the late 1970s, her distinctive style includes personifying inanimate objects and exploring familial themes. Her upbringing in a Brooklyn household influenced her perspective, and her fascination with the bizarre and dark



humor is apparent in her choices of subjects.

Artistic Journey

From a young age, Chast was drawn to art but did not initially envision a career in cartooning. After studying at the Rhode Island School of Design, she quickly made her mark by publishing in influential magazines, eventually joining the New Yorker, where she continues to work today.

Cultural Influences

Chast's childhood exposure to various forms of literature and humor, particularly the work of cartoonists like Charles Addams, shaped her artistic voice. She reflects on how her parents' serious approach to culture and art impacted her relationship with popular media.

Cartooning Process and Challenges

Her approach to creating cartoons remains consistent, as she continues to submit her work weekly to the New Yorker. Chast speaks candidly about the rejection inherent in the creative process, likening it to a psychological experiment



with rats. Despite the cyclical nature of acceptance and rejection, she finds value in her backlog of rejected work.

Reflections on Success

Chast's success in the industry, particularly as a female cartoonist during a time of limited representation, has been significant. She remains aware of the broader context of gender dynamics within humor, acknowledging the challenges and shifts in societal attitudes towards women's perspectives in cartooning.

Future of Cartooning

Chast expresses uncertainty about the future viability of cartooning in print form, indicating that while opportunities may dwindle, the spirit of creativity endures. She advises aspiring cartoonists to embrace foundational skills like life drawing and to cultivate their unique styles.

Concluding Thoughts

In reflecting on life and creativity, Chast recognizes the importance of humor in confronting the absurdities of



existence. Her perspective melds a blend of dark humor and introspective reflection, ultimately celebrating the complexities of life through her art.

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Chapter 32 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: How to Be Funny as a Journalist: HENRY ALFORD

Summary of Chapter 32: Ultra-specific Comedic Knowledge

Contributor Background

Henry Alford, a seasoned writer, has spent over thirty years producing humorous, first-person journalistic accounts. He identifies as both a journalist and a humorist, describing his style as a blend of investigative humor, often likening himself to George Plimpton with a humorous twist.

Importance of Labels

Alford discusses the significance of labels in the publishing industry, emphasizing the necessity for factual reporting in comedic writing. He notes that humor can often be a component of journalism, but successful humorists must



incorporate factual elements to secure assignments and book deals.

Navigating Humor and Sensitivity

Alford expresses his view on the fine line between humor and meanness. He prefers to avoid overly critical humor and strives for kindness in his writing, especially when covering individuals who may not realize they are being written about. Self-deprecation is a key tool in his writing that helps mitigate potential offense.

Experiences with Condescension

Reflecting on past experiences, Alford acknowledges moments when he might have crossed into unintentional meanness. He emphasizes self-awareness and careful consideration of identifiable subjects in his work, ensuring he doesn't alienate individuals or communities he explores.

Reporting on Diverse Worlds

As a journalist, Alford emphasizes the importance of sensitivity and generosity when reporting on unfamiliar



subjects. He acknowledges his position as an outsider and the responsibility that comes with it.

Preparation vs. Spontaneity in Humor

Alford notes that a small portion of his jokes are pre-written. This approach serves to calm his nerves and focus his efforts as he prepares for reporting, likening it to an actor understanding the broader context of a script.

Influence of Spy Magazine

Alford recognizes Spy magazine's impact on blending humor with journalism, particularly in its legacy of witty charticles and cultural commentary. He observes that while some aspects of Spy may not resonate today, the essence of wit remains timeless.

Advice for Aspiring Humorists in Journalism

For those wishing to combine humor and journalism, Alford advises starting with targeted submissions tailored to specific magazine sections, rather than creating content without a clear outlet in mind. He cautions against common pitfalls in



comedic writing, urging writers to avoid overdone tropes and focus on original contributions.

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Chapter 33 Summary : Interview: DANIEL CLOWES (Ghost World, David Boring, Eightball, Wilson)

Daniel Clowes: A Unique Voice in Comics

Introduction to Clowes' Work

Daniel Clowes challenges traditional comic narratives, opting for characters and stories that reflect a bleak, often nihilistic view of life rather than idealized heroes or adventures. His works often explore themes of disconnection and societal decay, drawing comparisons to contemporaries like Robert Crumb.

Background and Early Career

Born in Chicago in 1961, Clowes' journey as an artist began with a fascination for comic book covers, leading him to study illustration at the Pratt Institute. Early works like "Lloyd Llewellyn" laid the groundwork for his more lasting



series, "Eightball," which showcased his signature mix of dark comedy and unique characterization.

Breakthrough with "Ghost World"

Clowes gained significant recognition with "Ghost World," which delves into the lives of two teenage girls grappling with the realities of adulthood. The comic's adaptation into a film by Terry Zwigoff further cemented Clowes' status in both the comic and film worlds, earning him an Oscar nomination for Best Adapted Screenplay.

Later Works and Evolution

His 2010 publication "Wilson" features a cantankerous middle-aged protagonist, exploring themes of loneliness and social disconnection. Clowes' style has evolved but retains a focus on flawed characters navigating a complex world.

Views on Comic Literature

Clowes often rejects labels like "graphic novelist," preferring the term "cartoonist." He criticizes the commercialization of comics and the misconceptions that surround the medium,

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Chapter 34 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Humor for Children: DANIEL HANDLER, aka “Lemony Snicket”

ULTRASPECIFIC COMEDIC KNOWLEDGE: DANIEL HANDLER, aka “Lemony Snicket”

Background and Transition to Children's Literature

Daniel Handler, known for his best-selling series "A Series of Unfortunate Events," initially wrote novels for adults. His transition to children's literature was prompted by an editor's belief that he could write more suitable content for younger audiences, despite his initial skepticism.

Changes in Children's Literature

Handler reflects on whether children's literature has evolved since 1999. He notes a persistent presence of syrupy books but believes the quality works are now receiving greater



recognition.

Influences and Homage to Roald Dahl

Handler expresses admiration for Roald Dahl's dark yet humorous stories and highlights the chaotic essence and unstructured narrative arcs in Dahl's works. He believes these qualities resonate with readers and contribute to a more genuine experience.

Controversies and Cultural Sensitivity

Handler addresses the anti-Semitism in Dahl's work, suggesting that while it may affect personal opinions about the author, it shouldn't necessarily dictate what children read. He calls out inconsistencies in how children's literature is perceived compared to adult literature.

Depiction of Reality in Children's Books

Handler argues that children are already aware of life's chaos and sadness, thereby questioning the "tyranny of nice" seen in many children's stories. He emphasizes the importance of honesty in storytelling, particularly through humor.



Creative Process and Publishing Concerns

When creating "A Series of Unfortunate Events," Handler faced initial skepticism from publishers regarding the darker themes, which he saw as a continuation of traditional storytelling about children in peril. He believes that combining humor with tragedy reflects the true nature of reality.

Connection with Children and Misconceptions

Handler critiques broad stereotypes about children, remarking that such generalizations lack nuance and understanding. He believes authors should tap into the authentic childhood experience rather than project adult misconceptions.

Advice for Aspiring Writers

Handler offers practical advice for budding children's writers, emphasizing the importance of revising and trimming their work. He also recounts his past struggles and resourceful practices, such as using workplace supplies to facilitate his



writing, underscoring the necessity of dedication and cleverness in the writing journey.

Final Thoughts

He cautions against relying on writer interviews for guidance, suggesting that true learning occurs through reading and writing, dismissing the notion that authors possess all the answers regarding their craft.



Chapter 35 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANTHONY JESELNİK (Late Night with Jimmy Fallon, The Jeselnik Offensive)

Chapter 35: Pure, Hard-Core Advice by Anthony Jeselnik

Background and Aspirations

- Anthony Jeselnik expresses a lifelong desire to be a writer, initially aspiring to write books.
- He reconsidered this path after realizing the solitary lifestyle it entailed and transitioned to screenwriting, which he found tedious and challenging without connections.

Visit to a Comedian

- Jeselnik had only one connection in Los Angeles through his father's college friend, Jimmy Brogan, a respected comedian and writer.



- After watching Brogan perform live, Jeselnik expressed his desire to be a joke writer, receiving advice to pursue stand-up comedy instead.

Benefits of Stand-Up Comedy

- Jeselnik emphasizes that stand-up is essential for honing writing skills and joke development, as it requires live audience engagement.
- He compares studying stand-up to earning a degree, which opens multiple career opportunities within and beyond comedy.

Career Progression

- Jeselnik reflects on his experience working on "Late Night with Jimmy Fallon," highlighting the competitive nature of writing jobs in the industry.
- He shares that he managed to secure a position by actively promoting himself and his ability to write monologue jokes.

Advice for Aspiring Writers

- Jeselnik recounts how young aspiring writers sought his



guidance, stressing that hard work and unique paths are crucial to success.

- He encourages starting a blog focused on writing jokes as a practical way of demonstrating talent and commitment.

Quality Over Quantity in Submissions

- Jeselnik warns against submitting low-quality jokes, advising that thorough preparation is vital to making a strong impression.

- He underscores the need for aspiring comedians to treat their submissions seriously, as a poor submission could hinder future opportunities.

Conclusion

- Jeselnik addresses the frustrating lack of structure in the comedy world, urging aspiring writers to maintain focus and determination.

- He encourages them to persistently work on their craft, likening themselves to a train continually moving towards success.



Example

Key Point: The Importance of Stand-Up Comedy for Writers

Example: If you imagine yourself nervously awaiting your turn on stage, remember that every joke you tell is an opportunity to refine your craft. Engaging with a live audience not only sharpens your comedic timing but also helps you understand what resonates, turning critique into fuel for growth. It's through these performances that you'll discover your unique voice and style, essential elements in the competitive world of writing. Embracing stand-up comedy means dedicating yourself to honing your skills and connecting with others, much like a student immersing themselves in their field of study to unlock new avenues for success.



inspiration

Key Point: Embrace the Journey of Your Craft

Life inspiration: Anthony Jeselnik's journey illustrates that success in any creative field is not a straight path but rather a winding road filled with challenges and detours. Just as Jeselnik transitioned from writing books to stand-up comedy, you too can find that your initial aspirations may lead to unexpected yet rewarding opportunities. By embracing the experience of honing your skills through live engagement, you can discover the richness of your craft. Instead of fearing the solitary aspects of pursuit, view them as chances for growth, learning, and genuine connection with your audience, much like the laughter and interactions that shape a great comedy set. This chapter serves as a reminder to be open to transformation and to keep pushing forward, treating every setback as a stepping stone on your path to achieving your unique aspirations.



Chapter 36 Summary : Interview: ADAM RESNICK (Late Night with David Letterman, Get a Life, Cabin Boy)

**Summary of Chapter 36 from "Poking a Dead
Frog" by Mike Sacks**

Introduction to Adam Resnick

Adam Resnick is introduced through the eyes of his long-time friend Chris Elliott, who portrays him humorously as an enormous Russian figure with a supposedly tragic backstory involving radiation from a nuclear power plant. Resnick and Elliott became renowned comedy partners, contributing to significant shows like *Late Night with David Letterman* and the cult classic *Cabin Boy*.

Early Life and Career Beginnings

Born in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania, Resnick left college at NYU to join *Late Night*, which he considers a defining



moment in his life. His collaboration with Elliott reflects a deep affinity for comedy and shared sensibilities, resulting in a series of notable yet underappreciated projects.

Themes and Comedy Style

Resnick's work often did not resonate with mainstream audiences initially, despite its forward-thinking approach. Collaborations like **Cabin Boy** exemplify this, featuring absurdity and surreal humor that are now appreciated retrospectively. His comedic style sets the groundwork for modern classics and resonates through contemporary shows.

Reflections on Comedy Influences

Resnick expresses admiration for older comedic influences, favoring genuine, character-driven humor over formulaic, youth-targeted comedies. His views on male bonding in comedy reflect a personal disconnect from the ubiquitous bromance tropes.

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Thoughts on Writing and Collaboration

Despite having a successful tenure at **Late Night**, Resnick

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Chapter 37 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a TV-Series Bible: PAUL FEIG

Summary of Chapter 37: Paul Feig on "Freaks and Geeks"

Background on the Series Bible

- Paul Feig wrote the series bible for *Freaks and Geeks* in 1999 to organize his thoughts about the show.
- The bible acts as a reference guide, detailing characters, settings, and plot points, primarily for the creator's clarity but also for the show's writers and production teams.

Purpose and Importance of the Series Bible

- Feig emphasizes the importance of writing honest work and defining character authenticity.
- The series bible helped him combat Hollywood's misconceptions about the 1970s and depict a more realistic



picture of teen life.

- It was a tool for organization and assurance during the pitching process to executives.

Character and Situation Development

- Feig mentions a preference for developing strong characters rather than relying solely on situational context, which often leads to more sustained interest in a show.

- He believes a writer should initially focus on creating original ideas rather than mimicking existing styles.

Hiring Writers

- When hiring writers for *Freaks and Geeks*, Feig looked for original works instead of spec scripts, indicating the value of creative uniqueness.

- He acknowledges the challenge writers face in developing characters and situations that resonate with audiences.

Script and Improvisation

- Feig allows room for improvisation in comedy writing, arguing that strict adherence to written scripts can stifle the



naturalness and freshness of performances.

- He describes the need to adapt scripts based on actors' styles to capture the spontaneous and organic essence of comedy.

The Reality of High School Life

- The bible outlines the authentic teenage vernacular and behaviors, steering clear of overly clever dialogues that don't reflect real teenage life.
- Feig's vision for the show includes elements typical of high school life, like friendships, rivalries, and social dynamics, represented in the background action.

Music and Fashion Influence

- The show's characters have distinct musical tastes reflective of the time and class divide, informing viewers about their personalities.
- The characters' clothing choices aim to realistically represent a working-class Midwestern high school demographic.

Conclusion



- Paul Feig's insights into *Freaks and Geeks* emphasize authenticity in character development, the utility of a series bible in shaping a cohesive narrative world, and the balance between scripted writing and improvisational dynamics.

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Chapter 38 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: STEPHEN MERCHANT (The Office, Extras, An Idiot Abroad, Hello Ladies)

Pure, Hard-Core Advice from Stephen Merchant

Introduction to Passion for Comedy

- Stephen Merchant shares his deep-rooted love for comedy, emphasizing his nerdy fascination with dissecting humor and understanding its mechanics.

Work Ethic and Inspiration

- He acknowledges his laziness but feels compelled to remain productive through stand-up and writing, inspired by figures like Woody Allen, who highlight the importance of honing skills to succeed.

Differentiating Skills in Comedy



- Merchant explains that writing sitcoms requires a distinct skill set compared to stand-up, urging writers to craft character-driven narratives rather than simply recycling stand-up material.

The Necessity of Originality

- He argues that all comedic material is essentially a variation on familiar themes. True innovation lies in personal expression rather than chasing market trends, which often result in lifeless humor.

Navigating Success and Personal Satisfaction

- While acknowledging the allure of fame and monetary success, Merchant warns against losing touch with one's genuine passion, stressing the importance of creating work that feels satisfying and unique.

Conclusion: Embracing Every Experience

- He reflects on the value of all creative attempts, asserting that even failures are beneficial as they contribute to personal growth and creative evolution.



Chapter 39 Summary : Interview: DAN GUTERMAN (The Onion, The Colbert Report, Community)

Summary of Chapter 39 from "Poking a Dead Frog" by Mike Sacks

Dan Guterma n: A Comedic Force

Dan Guterma n is introduced as an exceptionally talented comedian known for his work in various esteemed comedy outlets like *The Onion*, *The Colbert Report*, and *Community*. Starting his career young, Guterma n quickly gained recognition and became a leading writer for *The Onion*, contributing memorable satirical pieces and a unique horoscope section.

Early Influences and Discoveries

Guterma n reflects on his comedic influences, tracing his introduction to comedy back to the National Lampoon,



which showcased the power of satire. He expresses admiration for the way comedy can expose truths rather than just serve as jokes, a realization that profoundly impacted his creative direction.

Challenges of Writing Comedy

Guterman shares insights into the pressures of comedy writing, emphasizing how essential it is to balance creativity with productivity amidst the demands of a fast-paced environment. He discusses how writing for television, especially on **Colbert**, requires adapting to a performance-oriented style compared to the more understated humor of **The Onion**.

Comedy and Personal Struggles

The chapter delves into Guterman's personal struggles with mood and fear, drawing parallels between his life experiences and his comedic output. He recognizes the complexities of linking self-worth to professional success, acknowledging a need to shift this mindset for healthier living and writing.

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Chapter 40 Summary : Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Working as a Hollywood Script Doctor: ALAN SPENCER

Chapter 40 Summary: Alan Spencer on Script Doctoring

Role as a Script Doctor

Alan Spencer shares his experience as a Hollywood script doctor, highlighting the confidentiality and lack of credit he receives for his contributions to major films. He emphasizes that many script doctors choose this path to avoid the emotional investment and potential rejection associated with writing original screenplays.

Working Methodology

Spencer likens his role to that of a medical diagnostician, where he assesses scripts and proposes changes without the



emotional baggage of the original work. He discusses how his involvement typically leads to a stronger script, thus affirming his value to the project while minimizing personal risk.

Audience and Executive Influence

The influence of executives and their perceptions of comedy significantly affect the final product. Spencer discusses the essential need for audience validation, noting that comedic success often hinges on test screenings. He observes the industry's trend towards safer, formulaic projects to maximize box office success.

Challenges in Script Quality

Spencer identifies a common gap in scripts—strong third acts or satisfying endings—citing how modern films often prioritize upbeat conclusions to ensure audience satisfaction. He also criticizes the lack of originality in marketing, where projects are reduced to simplistic comparisons, neglecting their unique qualities.

Hollywood's Dynamic



Interestingly, Spencer recounts a past incident involving a writer who successfully conned a network into believing they had rights to a popular show, showcasing the sometimes absurd lengths to which individuals go to navigate the industry.

Personal Satisfaction and Authenticity

Despite the industry's flaws, Spencer expresses contentment in being able to produce original work that reflects his voice. He underscores the importance of personal experience in writing, asserting that only material that genuinely makes him laugh should be shared.

Conclusion

Spencer concludes by stressing the necessity of maintaining an authentic creative voice in script doctoring. Asserting that compromise leads to failure, he advocates for writers to infuse their unique perspectives into their work for true comedic value.



Chapter 41 Summary : Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MIKE DICENZO (The Onion, The Tonight SHow Starring Jimmy Fallon)

Key Concept	Description
Importance of Passion	Genuine interest in topics leads to the best humor.
Unique Sensibilities	Writers should maintain their individual styles and enthusiasm.
Passion Projects	Finding and pursuing passion projects keeps creativity alive.
Continuous Practice	Regular production through various mediums enhances skill and visibility.
Peer Support	Successful comedians should help friends find opportunities to foster a supportive community.

PURE HARD-CORE ADVICE

Mike DiCenzo on Writing Comedy

Mike DiCenzo, supervising writer for "The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon" and senior writer for "The Onion," emphasizes the importance of passion in comedy writing. He believes that the best humor arises from topics you're genuinely interested in. An example he shares is his memorable bit where Jimmy Fallon impersonates Neil



Young, showcasing his love for both the musician and 90s television.

DiCenzo encourages writers to maintain their unique sensibilities and excitement about their work, stating that losing enthusiasm leads to trouble. While acknowledging the obligatory nature of some jokes in a professional setting, he advocates for finding passion projects to keep creativity alive.

For aspiring comedy writers, he advises continuous practice in any form—whether through Twitter jokes, web series, or humorous blogs—as regular production improves skill and visibility. He highlights the significance of peer support, stressing that successful comedians should assist their friends in finding opportunities, creating a community where everyone can thrive.



Chapter 42 Summary : Interview: MEL BROOKS (The Producers, Blazing Saddles, Young Frankenstein)

Mel Brooks: An Icon in Comedy

Career Highlights

In April 1969, Mel Brooks took to the stage at the Academy Awards intending to follow Frank Sinatra and Don Rickles, an iconic duo known for their comedy. Despite this daunting challenge, Brooks managed to upstage them while accepting his Best Original Screenplay award for *The Producers*.

With a solid comedy background, including work on *Your Show of Shows* and the series *Get Smart*, Brooks quickly rose to fame as a legendary filmmaker and writer.

Early Life and Influences

Born in Brooklyn in 1926, Brooks faced early adversity with the loss of his father. His passion for entertainment ignited at



age nine during a Broadway show. After beginning his career as a writer for Sid Caesar and collaborating with comedy legends, Brooks developed a unique comedic voice that influenced generations of writers and performers.

Comedy Philosophy

Brooks believes deeply in the importance of character-driven comedy, stating that characters are the essence of a story. He emphasizes that comedy should blend high and low humor, making it accessible while still thought-provoking. Drawing on his own life experiences rather than theoretical study, he views comedy as a craft honed through trial and error—often through “flops” that teach valuable lessons.

Cultural Commentary

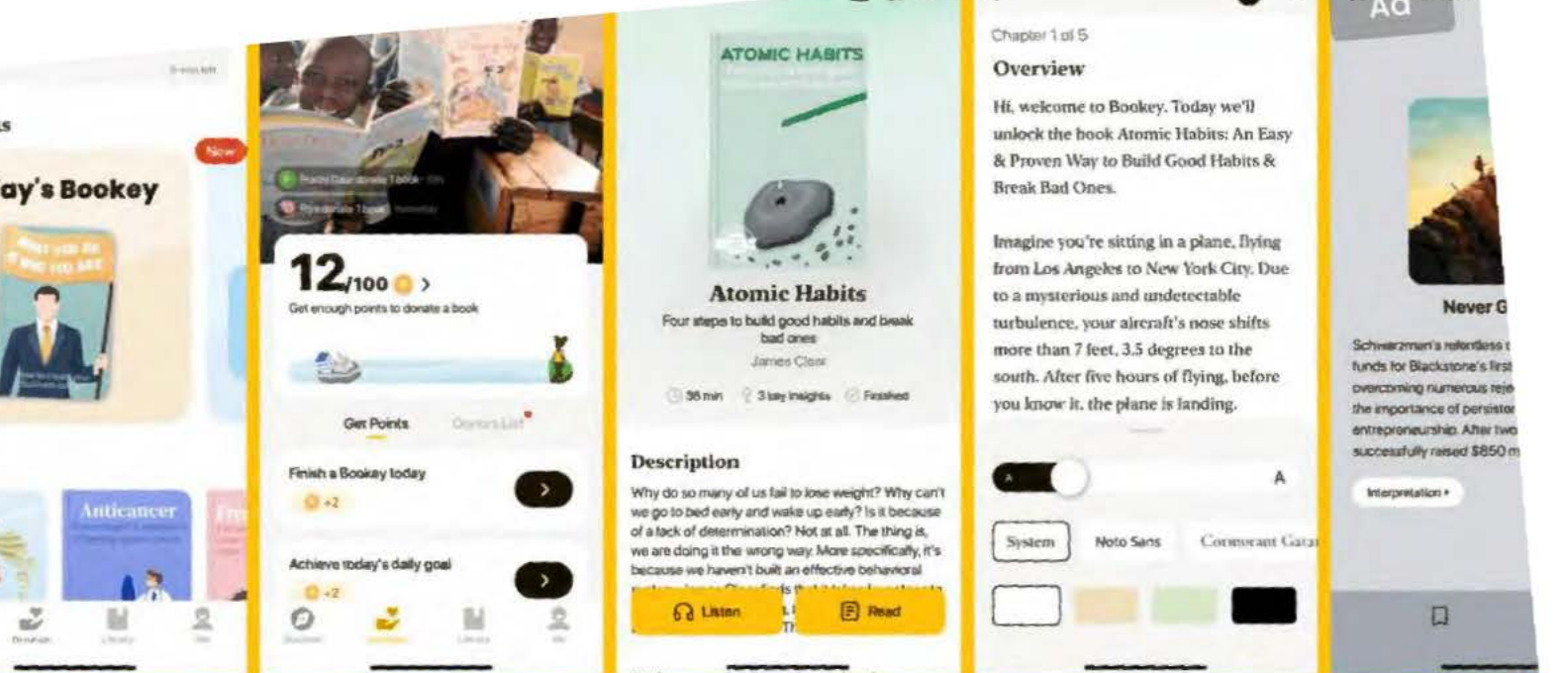
His films, like **Blazing Saddles** and **Young Frankenstein**, tackle serious themes with humor. Brooks insists that humor can serve as social commentary and that the underlying truth about human experiences should resonate throughout comedic narratives. He recalls funny moments stemming from real experiences, including inspirations drawn from Russian literature, particularly Gogol's work.

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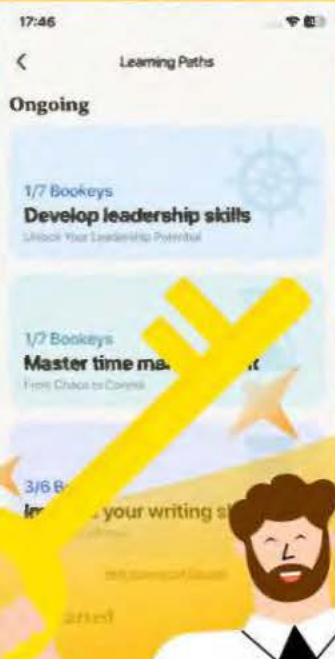
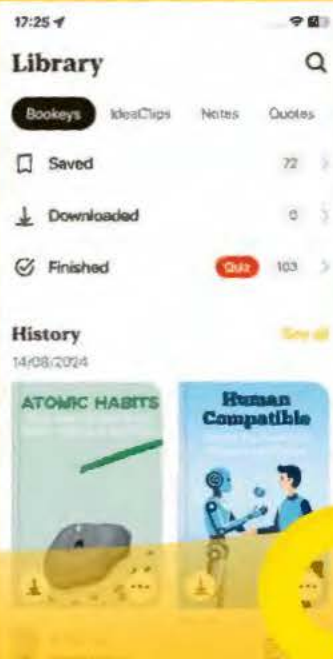
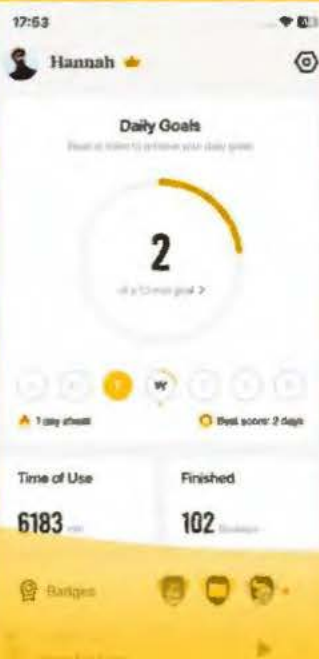


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makes me feel, it's like
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. That's where it comes
from.

- Boots Riley



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Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 31-70

- 1.I would love to be a part of that.
- 2.Jim Downey is Patient Zero.
- 3.The power of Downey’s political comedy extends beyond laughs; more impressively, his work has influenced the actual political landscape.
- 4.It’s so easy to coast by, just hitting the same familiar notes you know are popular
- 5.What you must have is a funny sensibility.
- 6.A good writing staff is one where you can look around the room and say, 'This guy does this thing better than anyone else.'
- 7.You have to figure out how to clear that height each and every time.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 71-82

- 1.It taught me at a very young age that comedy is

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dangerous business. If you try to make people laugh and they don't, they can become very, very angry.

2. But the difference is that with comedy, you take different ideas and put them together, and you produce not a star, but a laugh. There's a magical element to it.
3. It was tremendously difficult to keep up that level of quality with Python. Writing was very serious business; we took it very seriously.
4. If you want to create comedy, try to make people laugh. If you can make people laugh, head in that direction. If nobody laughs... well, that's not good news.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 83-122

1. I've always been straight-up lazy and defiant. I wouldn't last a week at Harvard, or at SNL for that matter.
2. Always be working on your own material. Write specs!
3. Just keep writing. If you really love it, you'll keep doing it even if you're not successful. If you don't love it, you don't



belong here.

4.You aren't good at writing, but if you can get over that, then one day maybe you will be okay at writing.

5.If you aren't willing to do something for free at first, no one is going to pay for it later.

6.Writing is boring and solitary and lonely and awful.

Comedy is even worse. You're not living in ancient Sparta, Greece. Stop fighting.





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Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 123-152

1. Good stories beat good jokes every day of the week and twice on Sundays.
2. If you ever feel complacent with yourself, then you're basically saying you don't need the other part of the equation.
3. Writing isn't a thing you figure out—ever.
4. Television used to be a quantity business... It's very much about quality—and specificity now.
5. I just like that kind of show better—where the characters are generally positive and the comedy comes from goofiness and satire instead of cattiness and negativity.

Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 153-165

1. For that, never underestimate the importance of carefully weaving your own voice into your submission well enough that it cannot easily be separated from your ideas.
2. I still think it would be a delightful thing to see on television.



- 3.This premise has two immediately obvious red flags.
- 4.The simplicity of this format is deceptively hard to crack.
- 5.Good luck!

Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 166-169

- 1.Is this really what I want to do?
- 2.Do I need to be doing this?
- 3.Write and perform comedy constantly and relentlessly for years and years until you're awesome at it.
- 4.If you can do anything else with your life and still be happy, do it, for crying out loud.





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Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 170-198

1. A space alien in the sense that he was disconnected from the rest of us? Yes. But he was also connected—I suppose a space alien who fit in on Earth—and that's the only way to produce resonant humor. If you're too connected, it becomes tedious. If you're too disconnected, it doesn't work. You have to be separate, but still secured.
2. It takes a profound sort of focus and determination to get anything done in the movie world, and he had both.
3. If you don't buy this magazine, we'll kill this dog.
4. So much of this type of humor depends on the audience's knowledge of what's being parodied, and a lot of the print formats you dealt with aren't as popular as they used to be. That's absolutely right. It was a moment of shared experience.

Chapter 8 | Quotes From Pages 199-208

1. Chayefsky stone-cold saw the future—and he did



that a few times. That's a tough trick for a writer to pull off, especially when it comes to comedy: to be prescient while also not confusing audiences with anything too new and too unrecognizable.

2.I believe great writing should make you aware of it. I think it's a fun thing.

3.Writing dignifies any turmoil it puts you through.

4.If you're in a genuine process, there are no mistakes. If nothing gets down that day, it's supposed to be that way.

5.I'd recommend that to all young writers. Just write. Lose yourself. And when you look up, maybe you'll be somewhere you always wanted to be.

Chapter 9 | Quotes From Pages 209-214

1.Even though comedy writing is inherently goofing around with really funny people for ten to seventeen hours a day, it's also very disciplined.

2.You also need to consume a lot of comedy so that you can figure out what makes something good.

3.But if you don't enjoy the act of actually sitting down and



writing for hours a day, it's probably not the correct choice for you.

4.I was really working hard at the idea of writing jokes.

5.My number-one responsibility is my job, and my number-two responsibility is my Twitter.

6.Also, just be a human being. Be nice to people and don't be crazy, which sounds very general, but that's appreciated professionally.





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Chapter 10 | Quotes From Pages 215-242

- 1.Maybe she doesn't like the food.
- 2.Margaret, doors are going to open for you when you grow up. Be sure that you walk through them.
- 3.It's the little things in life that've always interested me.
- 4.Life is funny!
- 5.I realized when I first started that there were a lot of ideas all around me. I didn't have to knock myself out trying to come up with funny situations.

Chapter 11 | Quotes From Pages 243-255

- 1.Every line was written just to be funny and to further the plot.
- 2.It became addicting. Every news story, every anecdote I heard at a party, every idea became a potential plot or piece of dialogue for the show.
- 3.Most of the ideas were un-witting parodies of the show.
- 4.It would then be up to Jerry and Larry to rewrite the script that I'd turn in to them, and for them to inject their own magic into the scripts.



5.How long would it typically take for you to write a Seinfeld script? Some faster than others.

Chapter 12 | Quotes From Pages 256-462

- 1.Respect for people who do the things you don't do is very important.
- 2.It doesn't have to be about, "Hey, you got a show. Are you going to put me in the show?" If you approach everything from a pure creative angle, the work and employment will take care of itself.
- 3.It's just that simple. I'm forty-three, so I kind of feel like that's just life. That's fucking life.
- 4.What it really comes down to is that life is short and these things should be fun. That's why we get into this business and the arts. It's because it's fun; it's like nothing else.
- 5.The truth is, if you're trying to make things that will last forever, I can almost guarantee you that you won't.
- 6.The best things are the things that were made because they were powerful in the moment, and they were immediate, and they resonated with people.





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Chapter 13 | Quotes From Pages 463-503

1. It was the first time I ever saw anything like that.

That joke was just so out of left field, and yet it still made sense. It was one of the first times I ever saw something where I felt, Oh, my God, you can do whatever you want with this form!

2. The trick is that if you love it enough, you'll keep going.

For people who don't truly like it, those are the people who usually fade away.

3. The only reason I accept it now is that there was real satire there: entertainment and silly pop culture trumping real information. But we probably should have popped it. There probably should have been some reveal at the end.

4. If you treat the audience like poets and geniuses, that's what they will become. Del never—ever—believed in playing down to the audience, in making cheap jokes.

5. Comedy is the one genre that I think has just really benefited from this more than any other.

6. What's great about comedy is that it's like pornography



and horror. In the sense that if you're not feeling the tingle that's promised by the genre, you know it's bullshit.

7.You just have to start doing it—even if you're not getting paid.

8.Part of success is just starting something, working toward a goal, and then living long enough to achieve it.

9.The second you start believing that, you are fucked. They say, 'This is the way it is.' But these are just general guidelines. The whole basis of comedy is surprise and shock. It has to be.

10.I think America has changed so radically from the mid-seventies. [...] There's a ridiculous, foolish confidence that America seems to have.

Chapter 14 | Quotes From Pages 504-510

1.I've learned a lot from watching movies over the years—when it comes to both writing and acting—and I've found that these films, in particular, were the most influential.

2.I tried to keep the list to movies that can easily be found on



Netflix and the like.

3.Enjoy!

Chapter 15 | Quotes From Pages 511-515

1. There's a hierarchy of television comedy writing jobs, and like most hierarchies, it's brutal, and a little ridiculous.
2. Some of the smartest, most charismatic and talented writers I've known have been late-night comedy lifers.
3. What I now realize is that those slow-paced story days, as numbing as they can be, are really when all the mental heavy lifting happens.
4. So, let's just say the system works and leave it at that.





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Chapter 16 | Quotes From Pages 516-554

1. I am not jealous.
2. The hope is that it's unforced and doesn't seem worked on, which, of course, it is.
3. All writing is autobiographical, in my view, including scientific papers.
4. The wastebasket is a writer's best friend.
5. If you're going through hell, keep going.

Chapter 17 | Quotes From Pages 555-564

1. The choice you have to make is, 'Do I, as a comedian, want to be remembered for this joke or not?'
2. For every winner, there are at least four or five who won't win. It gets chilly.
3. You can't be funny by saying, 'I'm not going to get anybody into trouble.'
4. But, we always give ourselves room for on-the-spot improvisation.
5. It's better if the hosts are comedians. They have to have a



bit of an attitude.

Chapter 18 | Quotes From Pages 565-569

1. The biggest thing that I learned as a writer at 30

Rock was the importance of self-awareness.

2. If you're not fun to hang out with, and you don't have that self-awareness, you're not going to do as well.

3. If you want to write for television, I strongly suggest that you watch a lot of television. Like, a lot.

4. I actually have such a love-hate relationship with writing. I kind of hate it. But, you have to tell yourself, 'I get to do this.' More importantly, 'I just have to do this.'

5. I do a thing where, when I'm writing, I put my television on Bravo, and I pause it on whatever show. Then, I write until it unpauses itself, about forty-five minutes in, and then I get to watch for however long it's been paused.





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Chapter 19 | Quotes From Pages 570-596

1. 'For me, writing comedy is about being unhappy. It's about being unhappy with the way things are and wanting to write something that is critical of those things, but in a way that isn't so self-serious.'
2. 'Things got a bit more clever and less silly. I think 'Secondhand Smoke Linked to Secondhand Coolness' is an example of that.'
3. 'There was a really strong group dynamic. We were like a band. There was no system like there is now.'
4. 'Writing for free will make you write a lot, which is the only way to become a better writer.'
5. 'If you are happy and fit in, you have little reason to develop a sense of humor.'

Chapter 20 | Quotes From Pages 597-605

1. Only a handful of jokes are truly funny and exceptional enough to break through the benumbed haze of our writers' room and see the light of day.



2. We are constantly repeating the same death sentences about how a joke is 'too this' or 'too that.' This is how you develop consistency as a joke writer, but this is also how—slowly but surely—you begin to lose your mind.
3. The chances of doing a joke we haven't done before grows a little slimmer with each passing day.
4. The reality presented in movies and television is just utter, lying horseshit.
5. We've opted to take a break from writing about overeating Americans for a bit, although, I'm sure, not for too long.
6. Here is something that happens to us, depressingly, quite often... we've already done this joke.

Chapter 21 | Quotes From Pages 606-783

1. You aren't good at writing, but if you can get over that, then one day maybe you will be okay at writing.
2. Writing is boring and solitary and lonely and awful. Comedy is even worse. You're not living in ancient Sparta, Greece. Stop fighting. You can do whatever you want in



life.

3. Make friends with smart, funny, highly motivated, encouraging, wonderful people who are more talented than you.
4. All stories need conflict, but conflict can come from anywhere. It seems counterintuitive, but when you have well-drawn, three-dimensional characters, chances are that one of the writers can always pitch a good joke at any given point in a script.
5. Good stories beat good jokes every day of the week and twice on Sundays.





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Chapter 22 | Quotes From Pages 784-825

1. You're always learning when it comes to comedy.

It's the nature of the game. There just simply aren't any hard-and-fast rules.

2. The common fault I see is that a lot of writers don't hear the show. Every show has a voice.

3. One of the problems is that the network always wants to make the last episode longer than it would normally be. In our case, it was ninety minutes, three normal programs in length. Way too long.

4. With really good comedy writing, you can hear the characters say the lines on paper.

5. There's a quality that's missing, almost apart from the comedy. Maybe it's our radio background rearing its head.

Chapter 23 | Quotes From Pages 826-835

1. You need at least one great sample script. But if you are an aspiring writer, you should always be writing.

2. The idea of having an original voice has become something



of a premium.

3.It's not just about staffing people, securing people's jobs.

It's also about when writers are selling their development deals.

4.The most organic way is to move out to Los Angeles immediately after college.

5.If you are an aspiring writer, you should always be writing.

Chapter 24 | Quotes From Pages 836-840

1.I didn't have any idea how I was going to continue to make a living. There was real fucking fear there.

2.The ability to get away from your ego enough to recognize your limitations, and to take action toward becoming a writer or working for a sketch group—that's a big moment.

3.You're going to have to find your consistency and your groove—somehow. You just have to do it.

4.There's always this weird thing in show business where you never know when success is going to happen. It's not a meritocracy; so much of it is about some weird shit



aligning that's usually out of your control, and you catch your break.

5. You might bomb, you might do great, but you're not always going to do great. You're not always going to bomb. You have to figure out once you do it whether or not you're infected with the bug that makes you keep wanting to do it.





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Chapter 25 | Quotes From Pages 841-881

1. Comedy isn't always the domain of comedians or traditional comedy writers.
- 2....the high-serious and the funny were not separate.
3. I think it's the attention that matters.
4. My whole childhood we lived next door to a family I'll call the Smiths.
5. Being funny is about as deep and truthful as I can be.
6. The world is comic.
7. Satire is, I think, a sort of bait-and-switch.
8. I think I've always been a fairly happy person.

Chapter 26 | Quotes From Pages 882-885

1. Go find your clients. Don't count on them coming to you. You'll always be remembered by the ones you tracked down.
2. No one really gives my client Justin Halpern any credit.
3. You are just going to get rejected anyway. Because these days the idea isn't enough.
4. Most humor books are actually not funny. I'd put the



percentage somewhere around 97 percent of books as not having a single laugh.

Chapter 27 | Quotes From Pages 886-891

1. I think the purpose of writing—and, really, with all comedy—is to fully entertain yourself.
2. The more you can remove any stakes or pressure—just write as fast as you can type—it's going to come out better.
3. If you're like, 'Oh, I gotta do this,' that energy and that mental state does not help the situation at all.
4. Do your best to entertain yourself. Or, entertaining the fifteen-year-old in you.
5. I realized the basis of any relationship is way less complicated than it's made out to be.





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Chapter 28 | Quotes From Pages 892-930

1. You can't control where you're going to end up.

You better appreciate the experience; otherwise, you'll never be happy.

2. Everything has worked to my benefit, even the things that felt, at the time, like they were working against me. A problem never comes without a gift in its hand.

3. It's the safest route you can take. Even if someone makes something terrible—like the music the Insane Clown Posse makes—at least they're doing something that speaks to them.

4. You either overcome everything and you do your own thing, or you don't.

5. The easiest thing in the world is to not make stuff. To accomplish anything is never easy.

6. You just have to trust that the humor is bearing fruit. It feels, at times, like I'm on this space walk. There's nothing to grab onto.

7. If you truly want to do it, then you're going to have to



make the necessary choices in order to do it.

Chapter 29 | Quotes From Pages 931-943

- 1.They once did a bit where they had a revolving bowl for fish who were too tired to swim around on their own.
- 2.I guess that's the beauty of radio: You can visualize your own world.
- 3.There was no set 'straight man.' We were both sort of straight men reacting against the other.
- 4.I guess you could say we were fearless, but nobody complained.
- 5.It was mostly characterization. I think that type of comedy always lasts longer.
- 6.Man is not evil. He is simply too hilariously stupid to survive.

Chapter 30 | Quotes From Pages 944-994

- 1.Read your stuff out loud. Sometimes the way it reads in your head sounds different when someone says it.



- 2.Be open to changing all the material you think is really brilliant.
- 3.Fake it till you make it. Put things up. If they're sloppy, keep trying.
- 4.If you stick around, if you're a good collaborator, if you're open to new ideas and you keep trying, then you'll find there's a lot of different ways you can work as a writer.
- 5.It's the only way good comedy works. When did you first make the leap from loving comedy to actually devoting your life to it?
- 6.There's no greater truth detector than comedy. You can tell when someone is full of shit immediately.





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Chapter 31 | Quotes From Pages 995-1023

1. You can dress them up, but you can't take them out.
2. When I was in school, trying to listen to the teacher talk about the French and Indian War, I would be distracted by irrelevant things like the ugly shoes she was wearing.
3. Most people go through life dreading they'll have a traumatic experience. Freaks were born with their trauma. They've already passed their test in life. They're aristocrats.
4. I always feel like that's the end of it—you know—I really have run out of ideas!
5. It can't be just, Here's the writing, here's the illustration. The two have to add something to each other and they have to be intertwined in a deep way.
6. I suppose it's also helpful for a creative person to look where others might not be looking.

Chapter 32 | Quotes From Pages 1024-1032

1. I usually say both.



- 2.The beauty part of embracing facts is that I can get an assignment and I can get a book deal.
- 3.There's a fine line between being funny as a journalist and being overbearing—or even mean-spirited.
- 4.If you're selling me something, or if I've paid you to provide a service, you're fair game.
- 5.What is that line and how is it best avoided?
- 6.As a journalist, you enter and write about other worlds: whether it's the hipster community in Williamsburg, Brooklyn, an a cappella group at Yale, or a cruise sponsored by the liberal magazine The Nation.
- 7.Thus, it's particularly important for me to be generous and kind in my coverage, and also to make myself look as much like an ass as possible.
- 8.Wit is always pretty timeless, so it's harder to see the specific trickle-down of Spy's particular acerbity.
- 9.Don't cook up some hilarious essay and then go to the newsstand thinking, Who can I submit this article to?

Chapter 33 | Quotes From Pages 1036-1073



- 1.If you're drawing a really detailed, tricked-out image, and your only concern is how it looks on the page, then that only goes so far in telling a story in comic form.
- 2.I was always opposed to the whole 'graphic novelist' label. To me, it just seemed like a scam.
- 3.The best advice I ever received was from Robert Crumb. He told me to just get away from cartooning for awhile.
- 4.I can see the crudeness of it, as well as the potential, but I just know that it would not be better—it would only be slicker.
- 5.Every story in Wilson [a graphic novel] is only one page. They remind me, in their rhythm, of syndicated comics or even Mad pieces. But the material is obviously much darker: death, failed hopes and dreams, inability to connect.





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Chapter 34 | Quotes From Pages 1074-1084

- 1.If you are interested in stories with happy endings, you would be better off reading some other book.
In this book, not only is there no happy ending, there is no happy beginning, and very few happy things in the middle.
- 2.The books for kids that have stood the test of time—like Grimm’s Fairy Tales or Alice’s Adventures in Wonderland—have been strange and chaotic and bizarre.
- 3.It’s one thing to forget about your childhood, but don’t transfer your incorrect memories onto kids who are now living through that time.
- 4.I always think of that story when I’m looking at a beautiful chapter I wrote, and I just can’t imagine cutting one word of it. I then think, Actually, yes, you can.
- 5.If you don’t know how to steal enough paper to print out your own stories for free...you’re not an underground writer. More than that, you don’t deserve to be a writer.

Chapter 35 | Quotes From Pages 1085-1091



1. I tell people this all the time, that stand-up, even if you don't want to be a comedian, makes you write, and it forces you to make the material good, because by doing stand-up, you're defending your own jokes.
2. And a lot of times, it might seem to be your dream job, but it might end up being a job job.
3. There's no real shortcut. No one cares how you dress in the interview.
4. So, if you have something to show people, they're gonna be excited by it.

Chapter 36 | Quotes From Pages 1092-1133

1. It was the defining moment of my life—the greatest thing that ever happened to me, and probably the first time I felt like I belonged somewhere.
2. We come from different walks of life, and yet from the moment we met we both realized that we shared the same sensibilities, laughed at the same things, and were tortured



by the same neuroses.

3. There are only a few people who think originally in comedy anymore. Adam has never compromised his comedic point of view, so besides loving the guy, I deeply respect him.
4. I just don't recognize anything particularly relatable or truthful in teen comedies. Actually, *Fast Times at Ridgemont High* did a good job of blending moments of broad comedy with something that felt recognizable.
5. It was a valuable lesson—never do anything just for the opportunity. Always go with your gut—your original instinct.





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Chapter 37 | Quotes From Pages 1134-1152

1. As a writer, all you can really do is to write honest work. You have to really put yourself in the head of your characters, so anything that helps you do that is great.
2. It's incredibly helpful to any writer. I'd recommend any writer do it, only to get his or her thoughts in some semblance of order.
3. You want to get to the point where you're capturing lightning in a bottle. That is the key to comedy as far as I'm concerned: lightning in a bottle.
4. By getting everything down onto paper, and by then organizing this world into a cohesive form, it can only help you if the show is bought and later produced.

Chapter 38 | Quotes From Pages 1153-1157

1. It's about taking pleasure in the process. The fun of it, for me, is the work.
2. You never feel like you've cracked it. It's like a tooth that keeps wiggling.



- 3.You can't sit around going, 'Man, I would be the heavyweight champion of the world, it's just that I never got in the ring...' At some point, you've got to do it.
- 4.What would I want to see? How am I not being catered to? That's the way to do it... rather than something more cynical: 'Let me see if I can find a gap in the market.'
- 5.Even the missteps are productive, because you're getting something out of your system.

Chapter 39 | Quotes From Pages 1158-1183

- 1.When you finally did discover comedy, what became your first love?
- 2.To realize that I could also say something that I believed in, or describe a worldview I shared, or attack a dishonesty that bothered me, through comedy—that changed everything.
- 3.I want to write a joke so good that it somehow rights the rest of my life.
- 4.The interesting thing about comedy writing is that you're doing this very creative, often very personal thing, but



you're expected to produce in this totally noncreative way.

5.I think it's getting better...because it's proof that you don't have to be this writhing, screaming husk of pain to be a comedy writer.

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Chapter 40 | Quotes From Pages 1184-1196

1. You want to win. You want your original script to be bought. But if you're emotionally invested in your work at all, then you're in for a really rough time.
2. If your work is—even to the slightest degree—personal, you'll always take it personally.
3. You're a diagnostician. In the end, the audience is a major factor. They're the final vote.
4. The more personal, the better. The more that it's told from your own personal experience, the better.
5. The moment you start writing things that don't personally make you laugh, you're finished.

Chapter 41 | Quotes From Pages 1197-1200

1. I would say that the best humor comes from things you're passionate about. Write what you're passionate about, and what you know about, and it always translates better.
2. It's good to take a step back and remember that you have



an awesome job where you write jokes for a living.

3. Just write as much as you can. That's the only way you're going to get better at it.

4. If you get any success in comedy, help out your friends who are trying to do the same, but who might not have a job yet.

Chapter 42 | Quotes From Pages 1201-1231

1. It's good to be the king.

2. Don't avoid the flops. The flops teach you what not to do in the future.

3. Whatever you write has to make you laugh. Not just laugh, but really laugh, from your belly.

4. Rewriting is writing. It's everything.

5. If my heart's in the right place, I can go anywhere.





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Chapter 1 | Interview: JAMES DOWNEY (Saturday Night Live)| Q&A

1.Question

What impact did Jim Downey have on Saturday Night Live?

Answer:Jim Downey is recognized as a pivotal force behind SNL, being one of its longest-serving writers and a key contributor to its identity. His influence helped shape the show's comedic direction, particularly in political satire, as he penned sketches that addressed relevant social issues while maintaining humor. Downey's work not only earned him respect from peers but also set the bar for future comedy writers, with many citing him as a mentor.

2.Question

What can we learn from Downey's journey about seizing opportunities?

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Answer:Downey's story teaches that recognizing and seizing opportunities can shape your career. Initially, he could have taken the path of traditional comedy writing right after Harvard, but he chose to travel instead. Upon returning, he encountered SNL and immediately recognized it as a chance to showcase his humor. This illustrates the importance of staying open to different paths in life and ready to act when opportunities arise.

3.Question

How did Jim Downey's writing style contribute to comedy?

Answer:Downey's writing is characterized by a unique blend of originality and sharp wit. He avoided 'claptrap'—a term for audience applause without genuine laughter—by prioritizing humor over political correctness. His sketches often highlighted absurdities in everyday life and politics, showcasing his belief in the importance of being funny above all else. This approach allowed for satire that resonated deeply with audiences, even when it challenged their comfort



zones.

4.Question

Why does Downey consider collaboration important for comedy writers?

Answer:Downey emphasizes collaboration because it fosters creativity and allows writers to take risks. By working with others, they can share ideas, provide feedback, and improve their craft without the fear of being ridiculed. He believes this supportive environment cultivates confidence and leads to more innovative and original comedic pieces, reinforcing the notion that great comedy often emerges from teamwork.

5.Question

What did Downey say about the relationship between comedy and political commentary?

Answer:Downey believes that political satire should stem from authentic observations rather than a specific agenda. He strives to capture the essence of political figures without simply pandering to audience sentiments. This approach not only makes the comedy more layered but also more



impactful, as it invites laughter in situations where audiences might initially resist it.

6.Question

What advice does Downey have for aspiring comedy writers?

Answer:Downey advises aspiring writers to find their unique voice by taking a fresh approach to familiar topics. He emphasizes the necessity of confidence, collaboration with peers, and the courage to share unconventional ideas. Moreover, he urges them to focus on the fundamental goal of being funny rather than conforming to popular trends or audience expectations.

7.Question

How does Jim Downey differentiate between ordinary and extraordinary comedy?

Answer:Downey differentiates ordinary from extraordinary comedy by the degree of originality and the writer's unique perspective. He notes that writers often focus on the originality of situations, while performers bring the character



to life. The combination creates memorable sketches where both aspects shine, offering the audience a delightful surprise that keeps them engaged.

8.Question

What is the significance of Jim Downey's pet peeves regarding comedy?

Answer:Downey's pet peeves highlight his standards for comedy, particularly emphasizing the need for genuine humor over shallow political commentary disguised as bravery. This belief underscores his commitment to crafting material that is both entertaining and thoughtful, advocating for a comedic landscape that pushes boundaries without succumbing to mediocrity.

9.Question

How did Downey respond to being fired from SNL?

Answer:Rather than being disheartened by his firing from SNL due to political jokes, Downey took it in stride, recognizing the support he received from peers afterward as a testament to his influence and contributions. His



light-hearted acceptance revealed his resilience and understanding of the nature of the entertainment industry, emphasizing how such experiences can lead to growth and new opportunities.

Chapter 2 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Monty Python: TERRY JONES| Q&A

1.Question

What early experience influenced your understanding of comedy?

Answer:At a young age, I tried to make my family laugh by handing over my table mat instead of my plate for more custard, resulting in a mess and laughter at my expense. It taught me that comedy is a risky pursuit—if your attempt to create laughter fails, it can lead to frustration or anger from others.

2.Question

When did you realize you wanted to be a writer and what fueled that desire?

Answer:I knew I wanted to write from around the age of seven. I was constantly writing poetry and essays, often



gloomy as they may have been. Encouragement from a teacher, Mr. Martin, who shared my work with the class, instilled confidence in me and confirmed my passion for writing.

3.Question

Is there a connection between poetry and comedy writing?

Answer: Yes, both poetry and comedy can be seen as forms of distillation—taking disparate ideas and boiling them down to create something profound. In poetry, you create a 'star' from three ideas, while in comedy, you combine ideas to evoke laughter.

4.Question

Can you illustrate a moment from Monty Python that exemplified combining different ideas for humor?

Answer: A notable example is Mike Palin's sketch 'The Spanish Inquisition,' which merges the seemingly unrelated ideas of modern life and historical figures, leading to the humor of 'Nobody expects the Spanish Inquisition!' The



surprise and absurdity of the context creates the comedic effect.

5.Question

How did the collaborative environment of Monty Python influence your work?

Answer:The synergy among the six members of Monty Python produced a unique voice that couldn't be replicated individually. We wrote for a 'seventh voice,' creating a harmonious blend of different comedic styles that resonated with audiences.

6.Question

What challenges did Monty Python face with censors?

Answer:The BBC often had strict guidelines. One memorable incident involved a sketch where the word 'masturbation' was cut out, while other equally controversial content was permitted, highlighting the absurdity of censors' decisions.

7.Question

What does your experience with writing and editing sketches tell us about the creative process?

Answer:Our initial drafts were frequently longer and required



significant editing. For instance, 'The Holy Grail' underwent many rewrites before its final form. This illustrates that good writing often demands refinement and the willingness to cut what doesn't serve the story or humor.

8.Question

In what way does history's fragility remind us about the importance of preserving creative works?

Answer:The BBC's near-erasure of original Monty Python tapes emphasizes the precariousness of cultural history; had they been lost, many comedic legacies would have disappeared. It highlights the necessity of preserving creative expressions for future generations.

9.Question

What advice do you give to aspiring comedy writers?

Answer:Aspiring writers should focus on making people laugh; that is the fundamental goal of comedy. If your work doesn't evoke laughter, it's crucial to reassess and refine your approach.

Chapter 3 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DIABLO CODY (Juno, Young Adult, Sweet Valley High)|



Q&A

1.Question

What can one learn from the experience of growing up in a practical and risk-averse environment?

Answer: Growing up in a practical environment, as experienced by Diablo Cody, can teach you to value creativity and imagination. It contrasts the rigid expectations with the vibrant world of Hollywood, where dreamers thrive. Cody's journey emphasizes finding and embracing your unique voice, despite external discouragement.

2.Question

How does one differentiate between writing that feels like work and writing that feels natural and enjoyable?

Answer: Writing that feels enjoyable taps into your passion and creativity, whereas writing that feels like work is burdensome and uninspiring. Cody mentions that her love for writing makes it feel like play rather than a chore, suggesting that true passion can transform your work into something



fulfilling.

3.Question

Why is specificity in personal writing important?

Answer:Specificity anchors your writing in authenticity, as it resonates with readers. Diablo Cody highlights that the personal nature of her stories, such as those from her own life, makes them relatable and impactful, establishing a strong connection with the audience.

4.Question

What advice does Diablo Cody give to aspiring writers about creating their own material?

Answer:Cody advises to always work on your own material and prioritize what you find personally appealing. She insists that writing spec scripts that resonate with your unique perspective can lead to career opportunities, rather than solely working on projects dictated by others.

5.Question

How did Cody's background influence her comedic sensibility?

Answer:Cody's experiences in a conservative, uncreative



environment made her appreciate the eccentricities of Hollywood. Her background fostered a quirky, defiant tone in her work, allowing her to write humor that highlights the absurdity in everyday situations.

6.Question

What role does defiance play in a writer's journey according to Diablo Cody?

Answer:Defiance serves as a crucial motivator that can drive writers to challenge norms and expectations. Cody embodies this spirit, indicating that the impulse to provoke or reject conventional standards has been fundamental in her development as a unique voice in comedy.

7.Question

What is the value of collaborating with talented peers in writing and comedy?

Answer:Collaborating with more talented individuals can elevate your work and inspire growth. Cody emphasizes the importance of surrounding yourself with smart and funny people who can challenge you and help cultivate your skills,



highlighting that collaboration breeds creativity.

8.Question

How does one maintain humor during difficult times, according to Cody's reflections on her work and experiences?

Answer:Cody illustrates that using humor as a coping mechanism allows individuals to face adversity with lightness. Writing about taboo or painful subjects can create a safe space for addressing difficult themes, proving that humor can indeed be a powerful tool for resilience.

9.Question

What steps should new writers take to hone their craft?

Answer:New writers should seek opportunities to write for free, gain experience, and develop their voice separately from prescribed formats. As emphasized by Cody, continuous writing and gaining diverse experiences are essential to evolving as a capable writer.

10.Question

What profound lesson does Gabe Delahaye convey about the journey of writing?



Answer: Delahaye stresses that success in writing is often non-linear and personal. Accepting the reality of being 'not great' initially encourages growth over comparison to others, allowing writers to forge their own unique path toward improvement.

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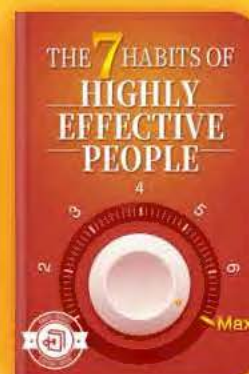
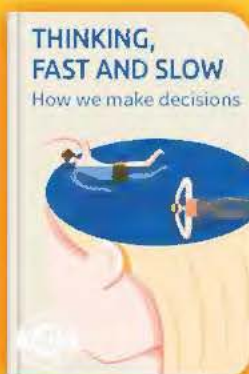


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Chapter 4 | Interview: MIKE SCHUR (Saturday Night Live, The Office, Parks and Recreation| Q&A

1.Question

What key lessons did Mike Schur learn about the importance of collaboration in television writing?

Answer:Mike Schur realized that television writing is a collaborative endeavor where the end result is more important than individual credit. He described it as a team sport, emphasizing that the collective effort of the writers is what ultimately produces a good show. This perspective helped him move past initial feelings of frustration regarding attribution, allowing him to focus on the shared responsibility of writing great material for the audience.

2.Question

How did Mike Schur's childhood influences shape his comedic writing?

Answer:Mike Schur's childhood obsession with comedy, exemplified by his voracious reading of Woody Allen's works, instilled in him a deep appreciation for humor. He



actively wrote sketches and scripts as a practice to hone his craft. This foundation created a lifelong commitment to comedy, leading him to structure sitcoms that blend heartwarming narratives with humorous elements, reflecting his early learnings.

3.Question

What makes character development crucial in Schur's sitcoms?

Answer:For Schur, character development is vital because it drives the storytelling in a way that resonates with audiences. He believes that while jokes can entertain momentarily, well-written, three-dimensional characters allow viewers to connect emotionally and invest in their journeys over time. This approach enhances the comedic impact of the story, as strong characters often lead to more memorable and relevant humor.

4.Question

Why is Mike Schur critical of the television industry's focus on pilot episodes?



Answer:Schur criticizes the tendency to judge shows based on their pilot episodes because it does not reflect the potential character development and narrative depth achievable in subsequent episodes. He believes that characters need time to evolve and that early episodes often lack the richness that comes with fully realizing characters, making it unfair to deem a show successful or unsatisfactory based on its pilot alone.

5.Question

What philosophy does Schur hold about the nature of comedy and sincerity?

Answer:Schur values sincerity in comedy, which he learned from the works of David Foster Wallace. He feels that comedy should address how people navigate life's challenges while maintaining hope and joy. Rather than exploiting tragedy, he prefers to showcase characters who support one another and find happiness, demonstrating that connection and kindness are paramount themes in his storytelling.

6.Question



How does Mike Schur view the role of criticism in the evolution of television?

Answer: Schur sees television as a medium that has evolved into a respected art form deserving of scrutiny. He believes that increased criticism fosters improved quality, pushing writers to refine their work. Despite the challenges of greater expectations, he remains optimistic about the creative process, suggesting that obstacles can lead to innovation and growth for writers and shows.

7.Question

What is Schur's perspective on the atmosphere of a writers' room?

Answer: Schur believes the atmosphere of a writers' room can significantly influence the tone and quality of a show. A positive, supportive environment fosters creativity and humor, while a negative one may lead to a cold, humorless product. He emphasizes the importance of having diverse voices and backgrounds among writers to cultivate an engaging and dynamic creative space.



8.Question

What is the relationship between character growth and effective storytelling according to Schur?

Answer:Schur asserts that effective storytelling involves putting characters in situations that challenge them, facilitating growth that feels both inevitable and surprising. He believes that great storytelling hinges on creating hurdles and successes for characters, thereby defining them and enhancing audience engagement.

9.Question

In what way does Schur's comedic approach differ from typical comedy writing?

Answer:Schur focuses on uplifting themes and character-driven humor, contrasting with more negative or cynical comedy styles. He aims for stories that underscore community and mutual support, believing that the best comedy emerges from characters who care for one another, which creates a warm and inviting atmosphere in his shows.

10.Question

How does Schur feel about the future of TV writing and



changes in the industry?

Answer:Schur remains optimistic about the future of TV writing, recognizing that while challenges exist, they also present opportunities for writers to innovate and push creative boundaries. He embraces the shift towards quality and specificity in television, which he believes will lead to more meaningful and engaging storytelling.

Chapter 5 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a Submission Packet for Late-Night TV: TODD LEVIN| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of understanding a show's comedic voice when crafting a submission packet for late-night television?

Answer:Demonstrating a clear understanding of a show's specific comedic voice can help ensure that your submission catches the attention of the readers. It shows that the writer is attuned to the nuances of the comedy style that resonates with the show's audience, increasing the chances of getting their



packet read beyond the initial ideas.

2.Question

How can a writer effectively incorporate their own voice into their submission?

Answer:A writer can weave their own voice into the submission by ensuring that their ideas reflect their unique comedic perspective while still aligning with the show's established voice. This could involve bringing fresh, unexpected elements that feel familiar yet original to the format and style of the show.

3.Question

What can writers learn from Todd Levin's experience with the character 'Riff' in his submission?

Answer:Writers should be mindful of how their character names and traits are perceived. Using overly cartoonish names can telegraph to the audience that a character is meant to be ridiculous, which could undermine the impact of the humor. It's often more effective to let characters behave in absurd ways without their names being a signal of their traits.



4.Question

Why is it important for comedy characters to inspire audience sympathy?

Answer:In comedy, it's essential for the audience to resonate with the host or primary character; otherwise, they risk feeling alienated. If a character elicits sympathy or is particularly vulnerable, making the audience turn against the host can disrupt the flow of comedy and erode the connection viewers have with the main character.

5.Question

What lessons can be drawn from the 'bootleg' comedy segment in Levin's packet?

Answer:This segment serves as a reminder of the importance of relatable, visual humor that takes everyday experiences and elevates them into absurdity. It exemplifies how content can be both easy to produce and familiar enough for continuous engagement from the audience.

6.Question

What makes a good 'desk piece' in a late-night comedy format?



Answer: A good desk piece should be generic enough to accommodate a range of jokes while being familiar enough to require minimal setup. Additionally, it needs to be fresh—this freshness is what keeps such segments interesting for audiences and prevents them from feeling stale or overdone.

7.Question

How does the concept of originality impact the success of a comedic skit?

Answer: Originality is crucial in comedy because audiences quickly become weary of repetitive themes or similar jokes. Writers should strive to deliver fresh takes on familiar concepts to maintain viewer interest and ensure their material feels engaging and new.

8.Question

What is the role of casting in sketch comedy, according to Todd Levin's insights?

Answer: Casting is vital in sketch comedy as the right performer can elevate a script significantly. A talented actor



can bring a character to life in ways that written dialogue alone cannot, making the overall comedic performance much more effective.

9.Question

What should a writer keep in mind about the expectations of a late-night audience?

Answer:Writers must understand that audiences come with certain expectations about characters and humor. It's essential to create scenarios that either meet or play cleverly against those expectations to keep the audience engaged and surprised.

10.Question

What overall advice does Todd Levin offer to aspiring comedy writers based on his experience?

Answer:Aspiring comedy writers should focus on blending their unique voice with an understanding of the show's comedic style. This balance creates work that is innovative yet familiar, allowing them to stand out while still resonating with the audience of the show.



Chapter 6 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANDRÉS DU BOUCHET (Best Week Ever, Conan)| Q&A

1.Question

What are two major changes in the comedy landscape that Andrés Du Bouchet observes since he started?

Answer:1) The sheer number of people pursuing stand-up comedy and writing has exploded. 2) There are now many more resources like classes, social media platforms, and online video sites that help aspiring comedians create and share their work.

2.Question

What fundamental question does Du Bouchet suggest aspiring comedians ask themselves?

Answer:He advises them to ask, 'Is this really what I want to do?' or, even more importantly, 'Do I need to be doing this?'

3.Question

What does Du Bouchet mean when he says most comedians feel there isn't a choice in pursuing comedy?

Answer:He implies that for many comedians, the drive to perform comedy is deeply personal and essential to their



identity, rather than a casual career choice.

4.Question

How does Du Bouchet recommend aspiring comedians improve their craft?

Answer:He encourages them to write and perform constantly and relentlessly for many years until they achieve a high level of skill.

5.Question

What potential opportunity for comedians does Du Bouchet suggest arises from building relationships in the comedy community?

Answer:He notes that through these friendships, opportunities may come as friends break into 'showbiz' and can help open doors for others.

6.Question

What is Du Bouchet's ultimate advice for anyone considering a career in comedy?

Answer:If you can do something else with your life and still be happy, you should do it, implying that the pursuit of comedy should be a calling, not just a career choice.





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Chapter 7 | Interview: HENRY BEARD (National Lampoon, Bored of the Rings, Latin for All Occasions)| Q&A

1.Question

What does the experience of Henry Beard and Doug Kenney tell us about the role of serendipity in success?

Answer:Henry Beard's journey from a halfhearted application to law school, which led to being rejected, turned fortuitously into founding the influential National Lampoon. Their unexpected beginnings suggest that sometimes, setbacks in our planned paths can lead us to unforeseen, successful opportunities. It emphasizes that openness to change and a bit of luck can carve the way to significant achievements.

2.Question

How did Beard's educational experience shape his writing career?

Answer:Beard's rigorous education at boarding school, which emphasized Latin and essay writing, cultivated his writing



discipline. The intense weekly assignments forced him to develop his writing skills and critical thinking, facilitating his later success in creating dense, witty humor. This shows the importance of a strong educational foundation in achieving one's career aspirations.

3.Question

In what ways can failure or rejection be beneficial in life, as illustrated in Beard's story?

Answer:Beard's rejection from law school and being booted from ROTC can be seen as failures, yet they redirected him toward a flourishing career in comedy. Such experiences highlight that rejection can be a precursor to finding one's true path and purpose, suggesting that enduring disappointments can ultimately lead to greater successes.

4.Question

What does Beard mean when he refers to comedy as a 'different beast' compared to television?

Answer:Beard views print comedy as requiring a certain discipline that is distinct from television. He implies that



print humor necessitates more self-reliance and craft, as it doesn't benefit from visual cues or spontaneous audience reactions like television does. This emphasizes the unique challenges and artistry involved in writing for print.

5.Question

What advice does Beard offer to aspiring humor writers?

Answer:Beard emphasizes the importance of starting early and immersing oneself in writing, suggesting that potential humor writers need to practice diligently. He also implies the merit of networking and finding the right venues, like Hollywood, indicating that context and connections can play crucial roles in a writer's success.

6.Question

How does Beard view the balance between luck and hard work in achieving success?

Answer:Beard suggests that while hard work is essential, luck plays a significant role in success. He argues that many hardworking individuals may never achieve recognition due to circumstances beyond their control, reiterating the idea



that not all outcomes result from effort alone, which underscores the unpredictable nature of success.

7.Question

Why does Beard believe that the National Lampoon's humor remains relevant even decades later?

Answer:Beard attributes the timelessness of National Lampoon's humor to its roots in shared cultural experiences relevant to its audience. The material, while dated in certain contexts, still invokes laughter because of its clever writing and accurate parodies that resonate with the human experience, showcasing the lasting power of well-crafted humor.

8.Question

Can you describe the impact of the National Lampoon on American humor according to Beard?

Answer:Beard believes the National Lampoon ushered in a new era of bold, absurd humor that challenged societal norms and conventions. It blended sophisticated wit with a rebellious spirit, creating a unique humor landscape that



influenced later generations of comedians and writers, which demonstrates the magazine's significant role in shaping modern comedy.

Chapter 8 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Getting the Details Right: JAMES L. BROOKS| Q&A

1.Question

Who has been a significant influence on your writing?

Answer:Paddy Chayefsky, noted for his unique position in screenwriting and the ability to maintain control over his films, is a significant influence.

2.Question

What is remarkable about Chayefsky's writing style, according to your perspective?

Answer:Chayefsky's writing is often criticized for being too 'written,' but I believe great dialogue should be appreciated.

3.Question

How do you view the relationship between writing and personal intensity?

Answer:I consider writing to be a righteous endeavor, akin to



a contact sport; it reflects our obsessions and deep involvement with life.

4.Question

What does research contribute to your screenwriting?

Answer:Research is crucial; it enriches the characters and adds authenticity to the comedy.

5.Question

How do you feel about the process of writing over the years? Has it become easier?

Answer:Writing doesn't necessarily get easier; it demands constant engagement, but being in a genuine process is what matters.

6.Question

What advice would you give to young writers?

Answer:Just write and lose yourself in the process. When you lose track of time, that's where the magic happens.

7.Question

How important is the act of re-evaluating your work over time?

Answer:Re-evaluating work over time allows a writer to gain



fresh perspectives, leading to greater understanding of their own narratives.

8.Question

What role does self-confidence play in your journey as a writer?

Answer:Self-confidence developed through my love for writing, but it took years for me to feel comfortable identifying as a writer.

9.Question

Why do you find it essential to hear something being said multiple times during research?

Answer:If I hear something multiple times, it usually indicates a shared truth that can add depth to my script.

10.Question

What has your experience been with character creation through research?

Answer:Research has led to the creation of unforgettable characters, like Louie De Palma, who were inspired by real-life encounters.

11.Question



What does it mean to you to 'be in a genuine process'?

Answer: It means being mentally engaged in your work, where even perceived inaction contributes to progress.

Chapter 9 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MEGAN AMRAM (Parks and Recreation)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of genuinely enjoying the act of writing, according to Megan Amram?

Answer: Megan emphasizes that if you don't genuinely enjoy writing for hours each day, then pursuing a career in writing might not be the right choice for you. She reflects on her own journey, noting that many people seek fame or cool jobs without appreciating the foundational joy of writing itself.

2.Question

How did Megan Amram's use of Twitter contribute to her career in comedy writing?

Answer: Megan started tweeting jokes to improve her writing skills, initially just sharing with friends. Over time, her



content caught the attention of influential figures in comedy, including assistants from 'Family Guy' and comedian Rob Delaney, leading to wider recognition and opportunities in the industry.

3.Question

What significant step did Megan take when she received an email from writer Jordan Rubin?

Answer:Megan received an email from Jordan Rubin, who was head writer for the Oscars, offering her a position to write for the Academy Awards. This moment was a turning point in her career, marking her first professional writing job, which she described as an incredible stroke of luck.

4.Question

What overarching lesson does Megan Amram convey about pursuing a career in writing?

Answer:Megan advises that enjoyment of the craft is crucial, and one must continually put themselves out there. She underscores the importance of being a positive, authentic person, while also ensuring that one's primary focus is



always on the work at hand.

5.Question

Why does Megan prefer to tweet less now that she has a job in writing?

Answer: While Megan loves Twitter for connecting with people and receiving validation through her followers, she prioritizes her job as a writer, placing it above her social media presence. She limits her tweeting to ensure her work responsibilities remain her top focus.



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Chapter 10 | Interview: PEG LYNCH (Ethel and Albert)| Q&A

1.Question

What was the significance of Margaret ‘Peg’ Lynch’s work in radio and television during the 1940s and 1950s?

Answer:Peg Lynch’s work with 'Ethel and Albert'

redefined sitcoms by focusing on the humor found in everyday life and domestic situations, laying the groundwork for future television comedies. Her perspective on humor was more mature, relying on character development and real-life scenarios rather than just punchlines, which influenced shows like 'Seinfeld'.

2.Question

How did Peg Lynch’s personal life influence her writing?

Answer:Peg Lynch drew from her own experiences, using domestic life and relatable situations to inspire her comedy.

For example, her disputes and interactions in her relationships were directly reflected in the dialogues and situations presented in 'Ethel and Albert', emphasizing the



humor found in the minutiae of everyday life.

3.Question

What could the phrase 'life is funny' convey in the context of writing comedy?

Answer:The phrase suggests that genuine humor arises from ordinary experiences and human interactions rather than contrived jokes. Lynch realized that authentic moments, miscommunication, or trivial arguments could lead to laughter, allowing writers to capture the essence of life's humor naturally without force.

4.Question

Why was 'Ethel and Albert' considered a precursor to modern sitcoms?

Answer:'Ethel and Albert' was pioneering in its approach to character-driven stories and conversational humor rather than relying on typical sitcom tropes of the time. Its success in focusing on mundane life events and natural dialogue set a standard for future sitcoms that continued to explore everyday relationships and scenarios.



5.Question

How did Peg Lynch feel about the process of continuously writing for her show?

Answer:Peg Lynch found writing to be both a daunting and freeing process. Despite the pressure to produce scripts daily—often over twenty thousand—she relished the creative freedom it provided. She was attuned to the humor of daily life, feeling that inspiration was all around her, and she enjoyed transforming these observations into comedic scripts.

6.Question

What advice did Dr. Charlie Mayo give Peg Lynch that resonated throughout her career?

Answer:Dr. Charlie Mayo told Peg, 'Doors are going to open for you when you grow up, be sure that you walk through them.' This advice highlighted the importance of seizing opportunities and was a guiding principle for Lynch throughout her career as she broke into the male-dominated field of comedy in radio and television.



7.Question

What does Peg Lynch's story tell us about perseverance in the creative industry?

Answer:Peg Lynch's trajectory showcases the necessity of perseverance and authenticity in the creative industry.

Despite early struggles and the competitive landscape, she continued writing and producing work that reflected her unique voice and comedic style, ultimately leading to her recognition as a groundbreaking writer.

8.Question

In what ways did Peg Lynch redefine the standard for comedy writing?

Answer:Peg Lynch redefined comedy writing by emphasizing realistic dialogue, relatable character dynamics, and focusing on life's subtleties. Rather than relying on elaborate gags, her writing allowed humor to emerge organically from characters' interactions and everyday situations, marking a significant departure from the formulas used in prior sitcoms.



9.Question

How did Peg Lynch's work impact future generations of comedians and writers?

Answer:Peg Lynch's innovative approach influenced generations of comedians and writers by demonstrating that comedy could stem from authenticity and observation rather than solely punchlines. Her show's format and style paved the way for narrative-driven sitcoms that prioritize character development and relational dynamics.

10.Question

What does Peg Lynch's legacy in comedy highlight about the industry as a whole?

Answer:Peg Lynch's legacy in comedy underscores the importance of diverse voices and perspectives in the industry. Her success as a female writer in a predominantly male field exemplifies how original and honest storytelling can shape cultural narratives, encouraging future creators to share their unique viewpoints.

**Chapter 11 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge:
Writing for Seinfeld: PETER MEHLMAN| Q&A**



1.Question

What does Peter Mehlman reveal about the process of writing catchphrases in 'Seinfeld'?

Answer:Peter Mehlman explains that catchphrases like 'yada yada yada' were not specifically intended to become popular upon writing. Instead, they developed organically from the context of the episodes. For example, in the 'Yada Yada' episode, he thought the phrase 'antidentite' would be a hit, but it was the simpler 'yada yada yada' that resonated with the audience. This reflects the unpredictability of what will connect with the public.

2.Question

How did Peter Mehlman's real-life experiences influence his writing for 'Seinfeld'?

Answer:Mehlman draws inspiration from real-life situations. The concept of 'double-dipping' in 'The Implant' came from an incident he witnessed at a party where someone reacted



dramatically to another person double-dipping a chip. This shows how everyday experiences can provide a goldmine of material for comedy writers.

3.Question

What challenges did Mehlman and his colleagues face while writing scripts for 'Seinfeld'?

Answer:One major challenge was balancing multiple storylines within a single episode, ensuring each of the four main characters had a significant role. Scripts often ran too long, necessitating tight edits to keep them concise and engaging. Additionally, they faced a high volume of unsolicited scripts from aspiring writers, many of which were poorly conceived.

4.Question

In what ways did the absence of modern technology impact the storytelling in 'Seinfeld'?

Answer:Without cell phones and the Internet, characters in 'Seinfeld' had to engage in more physically comedic situations. For instance, without the ease of communication,



plot points relied on characters being in the same place at the right time, which created tension and humor. For instance, in classic episodes, characters are often stuck in awkward situations because they can't just text each other.

5.Question

What can we learn about creativity from Peter Mehlman's experience with writing?

Answer:Mehlman's narrative illustrates that creativity often emerges from observing everyday life rather than forcing it. His recollections demonstrate the importance of being open to ideas from various sources—friends, personal experiences, and even moments during unexpected activities. Creativity thrives on observation and spontaneity.

6.Question

How did Mehlman transition from magazine writing to writing for television?

Answer:Peter Mehlman made the leap to television writing after running into Larry David, who invited him to pitch ideas for 'Seinfeld.' His background in magazine



writing—particularly his humorous article for 'The New York Times'—impressed the creators, leading to his assignment to write an episode. This emphasizes the value of networking and showcasing one's work to pursue new opportunities.

Chapter 12 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: PAUL F. TOMPKINS (Mr. Show, Best Week Ever, Bob's Burger)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the main message about teamwork in artistic expression according to Paul F. Tompkins?

Answer:The main message is that respect for all artistic roles is essential, as great creations are always the result of team effort. Writers, actors, and every crew member, no matter how small their role, are equally important in the process.

2.Question

How does Paul F. Tompkins redefine networking in the context of creativity?

Answer:Tompkins redefines networking from being a crass, opportunistic act into a genuine effort to socialize and engage



with like-minded creative individuals, focusing on building relationships rather than directly seeking jobs.

3.Question

What is Tompkins' perspective on selling out in the creative industry?

Answer:Tompkins believes that selling out occurs when someone with financial security chooses to take work purely for money, not when a struggling artist takes available projects to pay the bills. The latter is just a part of life.

4.Question

What is the significance of respect in the creative process as emphasized by Tompkins?

Answer:Respect for all individuals in the creative process, regardless of their role, is crucial as it fosters collaboration and enhances the quality of the work produced.

5.Question

According to Tompkins, how does age change one's perception of artistic work and priorities?

Answer:As one gets older, the focus shifts from worrying about appearances and being perceived as "cool" to enjoying



the work itself. It becomes about the love of the art and how it evolves over time.

6.Question

What does Bruce Jay Friedman say about the essence of humor in writing?

Answer:Friedman emphasizes that humor shouldn't be forced; rather, it should arise naturally from the narrative.

The best humor is often unintentional and based on genuine observations.

7.Question

What is the advice from Kay Cannon about being in a writer's room?

Answer:Cannon advises writers to be self-aware, knowing their role in the dynamic of the group, and emphasizes the importance of listening and learning from more experienced writers.

8.Question

What does Dave Hill identify as crucial for a writer's success?

Answer:Hill stresses that the purpose of writing is to



entertain oneself and that writers should aim to create freely without the pressure of commercial success or external validation.

9.Question

What insight does George Saunders share about humor and personal experience in writing?

Answer:Saunders points out that comedy can emerge from real-life experiences where the serious and the funny coexist, and that humor often stems from observing the absurdities within our own life contexts.

10.Question

What is the overall takeaway regarding the personal journey of writers and the nature of their craft?

Answer:The overall takeaway is that the journey in writing is deeply personal and often involves grappling with one's own insecurities, and that genuine talent and hard work can eventually lead to success, regardless of the initial circumstances.





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Chapter 13 | Interview: ADAM McKAY (Saturday Night Live, Anchorman, Talladega Nights, Step Brothers)| Q&A

1.Question

What inspired Adam McKay to transition from traditional comedy to political satire?

Answer:Adam McKay was originally drawn to mainstream comedy, idolizing figures like Jay Leno and Jerry Seinfeld. However, upon moving to Chicago and immersing himself in the vibrant improv scene, he was captivated by the idea of pushing boundaries and exploring dark, political humor. His experience at Second City with 'Piñata Full of Bees', which tackled serious societal issues through comedy, marked a turning point in his career, leading him to embrace satire as a tool for social commentary.

2.Question

What role did Del Close play in shaping Adam McKay's comedy style?



Answer:Del Close emphasized the importance of 'slow thinking' in improv, encouraging his students to explore deeper creative avenues beyond their initial instincts. McKay credits Close with nurturing his comedic voice, pushing him to develop layered characters and narratives, which ultimately influenced his writing and directing style in films.

3.Question

What does McKay believe is essential for a successful career in comedy?

Answer:According to McKay, the key to success in comedy lies in passion rather than the pursuit of fame. He emphasizes the importance of genuinely loving the craft, engaging actively in writing and creating, and not getting derailed by the business aspects of entertainment.

4.Question

How does McKay view the evolution of American comedy?

Answer:McKay observes a shift in American comedy from mocking established powers to celebrating characters who



embody a cocky, unearned confidence. He sees this as both a reflection of and a comment on current American attitudes, specifically relating to entitlement and a disconnect from reality.

5.Question

Despite his success, how does McKay maintain the edge in his comedy?

Answer:McKay believes that his core identity as a subversive comedy writer is still intact, as demonstrated by his willingness to tackle controversial subjects and give voice to flawed characters. He embraces the idea of pushing boundaries and using humor as a means to provoke thought and challenge the status quo.

6.Question

What significance does McKay place on the audience's intelligence in his writing?

Answer:McKay champions the idea of treating audiences as intelligent beings. He believes that when comedians recognize the audience's capacity for deeper understanding,



they elevate the humor and enable a more engaging dialogue, which ultimately makes the laughter richer.

7.Question

What advice does McKay give to aspiring comedy writers?

Answer:McKay advises new writers to dive headfirst into their work and create without waiting for permission. He believes that success is built on persistence, exploration of creative ideas, and a genuine love for comedy, rather than simply networking or seeking fame.

8.Question

What was the impact of technology on comedy filmmaking, according to McKay?

Answer:McKay asserts that advancements like digital editing software (Avid) have revolutionized comedy filmmaking, allowing for precise timing and audience feedback integration that enhances comedic delivery. This has led to a boom in comedy, enabling writers to craft sharper and more engaging narratives.



9.Question

How does Adam McKay want his movies to be remembered by future audiences?

Answer:He hopes that his films resonate with the same anarchic spirit and joy he found in classic comedies like those of the Marx Brothers, invoking a sense of surprise and wonder in viewers long after they are made.

10.Question

In just a few words, what is the heart of comedic writing, according to McKay?

Answer:Surprise and shock.

Chapter 14 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Two Hundred Essential Movies Every Comedy Writer Should See: A List by BILL HADER| Q&A

1.Question

What impact do films have on comedy writing according to Bill Hader?

Answer:Bill Hader suggests that films are crucial for comedy writers, serving as sources of inspiration and learning. He learned both writing and acting



skills through watching these influential movies.

2.Question

Why does Bill Hader recommend watching a variety of films for comedy writing?

Answer:Hader emphasizes the importance of diverse influences in comedy writing. By watching a wide range of films from different eras and styles, writers can broaden their understanding of comedic techniques and storytelling.

3.Question

What can be inferred about Hader's personal taste in movies based on his list?

Answer:Hader's list reveals a personal and eclectic taste in films which blends classic comedies with lesser-known gems, indicating that he values originality and different comedic styles.

4.Question

How does the author's approach to selecting films reflect his beliefs about comedy writing?

Answer:The inclusion of both obvious classics and curious choices reflects Hader's belief that comedy writing is



enriched by exposure to a broad spectrum of humor, encouraging writers to think outside conventional norms.

5.Question

In what ways might studying the films recommended by Hader enhance a comedy writer's craft?

Answer: Studying the recommended films can enhance a comedy writer's craft by providing lessons in timing, character development, absurdity, and the ability to blend humor with serious themes, among other techniques.

6.Question

What themes do you notice in Hader's selection of films?

Answer: Common themes in Hader's list include the importance of satire, character-driven humor, and the blending of comedic and dramatic elements, showing that effective comedy often arises from complex narratives.

7.Question

What is the significance of the film 'Airplane!' being listed among essential movies for comedy writers?

Answer: 'Airplane!' is a quintessential example of successful parody and absurd humor, showcasing elements like



fast-paced jokes and visual gags that are fundamental for comedy writers to learn and master.

8.Question

How does Hader's recommendation connect comedy writing to culture?

Answer:Hader's list connects comedy writing to culture by suggesting that understanding various comedic films helps writers grasp societal norms, humor trends, and character archetypes, which can inform and enhance their own work.

9.Question

Why might Hader have included films like 'Eyes Wide Shut' in his comedy recommendations?

Answer:Including 'Eyes Wide Shut' suggests that Hader believes comedy can thrive within unexpected contexts, demonstrating that unconventional films can offer unique perspectives and insights that inform comedic sensibilities.

10.Question

What role does nostalgia play in Hader's selection of films?

Answer:Nostalgia likely plays a significant role, as many of



the films on the list are classics that evoke memories and emotions, which can inspire writers to tap into their own experiences and sentiments in their comedic work.

Chapter 15 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: SCOTT JACOBSON (The Daily Show, Bob's Burgers)| Q&A

1.Question

What does the hierarchy of television comedy writing reveal about the industry?

Answer: The hierarchy in television comedy writing highlights a competitive landscape, where the prestige associated with jobs varies dramatically based on the type of show. Late-night shows are seen as stepping stones to sitcoms, which are perceived as offering more professional growth and financial rewards. This reflects a broader attitude that not all comedy writing jobs are viewed equally, and writers often feel pressured to move up the ladder.

2.Question

Why might sitcom jobs be considered more desirable than



late-night writing positions?

Answer: Sitcom jobs are often perceived as more desirable due to their potential for professional growth and the possibility of earning lucrative royalty checks. Unlike late-night shows, which demand a fast-paced and stressful work environment with material being produced on a daily basis, sitcoms can allow for more leisurely creative development times, even if they come with their own challenges.

3.Question

What insights does the author provide about the writing process in sitcoms versus late-night shows?

Answer: The author contrasts the fast-paced joke-writing sessions of late-night shows with the more methodical and intellectually demanding process of breaking stories in sitcoms. While writing jokes can feel mechanically easy and quick, crafting a satisfying story that develops characters and adheres to narrative structure is painstaking work that requires deep thought and creativity.



4.Question

How can one adequately prepare for a writing job in sitcoms according to the author's experiences?

Answer:The author reflects on inadequate preparation for sitcom writing, emphasizing the importance of understanding story structure and character development beyond just having watched comedies. Successful sitcom writing involves deep analysis and practice, along with mastery of intricate storytelling elements, rather than relying solely on one's observational skills as a viewer.

5.Question

What is the author's ultimate perspective on the challenges of writing for sitcoms versus late-night shows?

Answer:The author concludes that both sitcoms and late-night shows present unique challenges and rewards, and while writers may have preferences for one type over the other, each offers valuable experience and a significantly better pay rate compared to more traditional jobs like substitute teaching. In essence, both paths are integral to

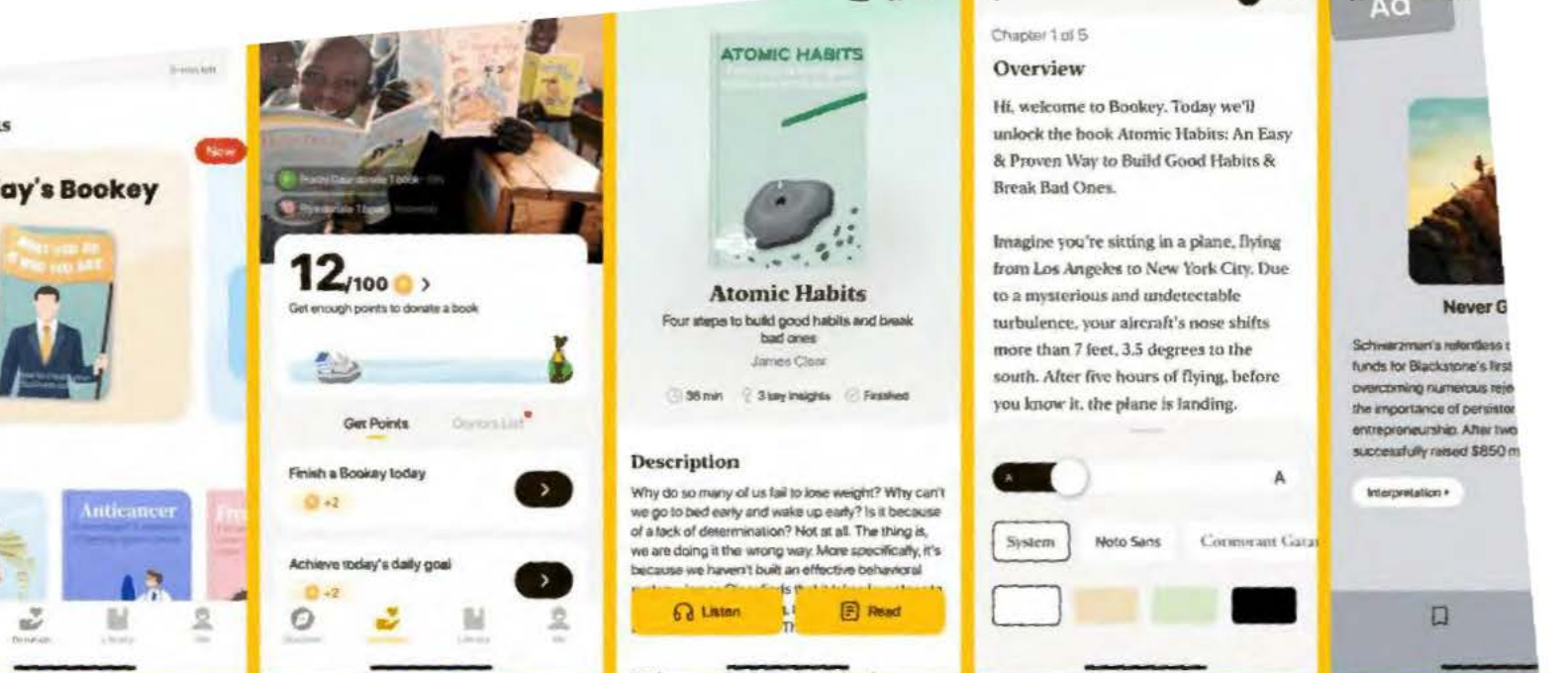


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Chapter 16 | Interview: BRUCE JAY FRIEDMAN (Stern, The Heartbreak Kid, Stir Crazy, Splash)| Q&A

1.Question

What inspires Bruce Jay Friedman to write, and how does he view the process of writing humor?

Answer: Bruce Jay Friedman emphasizes that he does not write to make people laugh, but his work often elicits humor as a byproduct. He believes his writing is serious in nature, and any comedic elements are unforced. Friedman believes that humor isn't the goal but can be a means to explore deeper themes and human experiences.

2.Question

What advice does Friedman give aspiring writers about writing humor?

Answer: Friedman advises against trying too hard to be funny. He suggests that intrinsic humor in a story will naturally resonate with readers. He warns that irony or satire often falls flat and encourages writers to focus on clear truths



and interesting story premises.

3.Question

Why does Friedman feel a connection to 'dark comedy'?

Answer:Friedman describes his works as darkly humorous, highlighting a balance between bleakness and humor. He believes that exploring the darker aspects of humanity doesn't exclude laughter but rather adds depth to the understanding of life's absurdities.

4.Question

What can we learn from Bruce Jay Friedman's approach to character creation?

Answer:Friedman's characters, such as Harry Towns, are relatable even in their flaws. He successfully infuses a sense of humanity into characters by making them deeply honest, complex, and recognizably flawed, allowing readers to identify with their struggles.

5.Question

How does Bruce Jay Friedman define success as a writer, particularly in relation to the impact his works have on readers?



Answer:For Friedman, success is not measured by commercial accolades but by the emotional and intellectual resonance his stories create in the minds of readers. He values the admiration of peers and the influence his work has had on later writers.

6.Question

What does Friedman say about the challenges of writing throughout a career?

Answer:Friedman maintains that writing remains a difficult process, no matter how long one has been practicing. He emphasizes the constant need for improvement, creativity, and the challenge of facing a blank page.

7.Question

What does Friedman think about the evolution of humor in the literary landscape since the 1960s?

Answer:He reflects on how societal changes, including the political and cultural upheavals of the 60s, necessitated a new approach to comedy, leading to the emergence of darker themes and more complex characters in comedic writing.



8.Question

What elements contribute to Friedman's distinctive voice in storytelling?

Answer:Friedman's voice is marked by a blend of irony, emotional depth, and a realistic portrayal of flawed human nature. His stories often balance humor with significant life lessons, challenging readers while creating a connection.

9.Question

What personal elements does Friedman incorporate into his novels, particularly in relation to his experiences in the suburbs?

Answer:Friedman infuses autobiographical elements into his novels, using his feelings of isolation and experiences in suburban life to craft narratives that reflect broader societal themes, especially the disillusionment with suburban ideals.

10.Question

How does Friedman's relationship with other writers shape his perspective on writing and humor?

Answer:His friendships with contemporaries, including Mario Puzo and Terry Southern, influence his appreciation



for storytelling's nuances. Their appreciation of shared struggles as writers enriches his own approach and understanding of humor in literature.

Chapter 17 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Jokes for Awards Shows: BRUCE VILANCH| Q&A

1.Question

What is the biggest challenge faced when writing comedic material for an awards show like the Oscars?

Answer:The biggest challenge is creating material that resonates with a diverse audience while also ensuring it remains appropriate. Writers must navigate what might cross the line and how to react in real-time to unscripted moments.

2.Question

How much preparation goes into the script for a televised awards show?

Answer:It involves a tremendous amount of preparation, often starting two months prior to the event, with writers creating a three hundred-page script filled with jokes and



improvisational notes based on potential situations during the broadcast.

3.Question

Why are some jokes not used despite the amount of effort put into writing them?

Answer:Typically, only one or two out of hundreds of jokes written end up being used during the show. This is partly due to the unpredictability of live performances and the need for flexibility in responding to spontaneous moments.

4.Question

What do writers rely on when unexpected moments happen during the show?

Answer:Writers must be agile, ready to develop new material on the spot based on what is occurring live. For example, if a presenter does something surprising, the writers can quickly craft a reaction joke.

5.Question

How does the atmosphere change during a long awards show, and how does it affect comedic writing?

Answer:As the show progresses, the audience can become



chilly and distracted as nominees start to realize they may not win, making it harder for comedians to engage them and maintain energy.

6.Question

What distinguishes a successful awards show host from an unsuccessful one?

Answer:A successful host brings unique personality and fresh humor while connecting with the live audience. In contrast, a host who tries to force ideas that don't align with the event's vibe can fail to connect.

7.Question

What insights does Bruce Vilanch offer about writing jokes for different hosts like Letterman versus Ellen?

Answer:Different hosts require different approaches; Letterman had a more late-night persona, which didn't translate as well to the Oscars, while Ellen's daytime style didn't convey the occasion's gravity, showing how vital a host's personal style is to comedy writing.

8.Question

What is the impact of an audience member's reaction on



the effectiveness of jokes during an awards show?

Answer: The immediate reaction from the live audience is crucial, as their laughter sets the tone for the viewers at home. A lukewarm audience can lead to a less engaging performance overall.

9.Question

How do the personalities of the presenters affect the writing of jokes for award presentations?

Answer: Writers must often negotiate with presenters, who may come with their own stylistic wants and fears. If a presenter is anxious, it can stifle humor and spontaneity, making it challenging to craft truly funny moments.

10.Question

How does the backstage atmosphere during the show influence the writing process?

Answer: Backstage is chaotic and intense, with a quick pace dictating that writers must be ready to adapt and create in real-time, fostering an environment where quick wit and creativity are essential.



Chapter 18 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: KAY CANNON (30 Rock, New Girl, Pitch Perfect)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of self-awareness in a writers' room according to Kay Cannon?

Answer:Self-awareness is crucial in a writers' room because it helps each writer understand their role within the team dynamics. Cannon emphasizes that being aware of when to lead the room or when to take a backseat as a listener is vital to achieving success and maintaining good relationships with colleagues. Without this self-awareness, writers may struggle and 'crash and burn' due to misunderstanding their contribution and interactions.

2.Question

How does Kay Cannon suggest writers should approach feedback from networks or studios?

Answer:Writers are encouraged to reflect on whether their resistance to feedback stems from laziness or thoughtful



consideration. Cannon points out the importance of critically evaluating notes and trusting one's gut, balancing the need for thoughtful changes against the temptation to resist work that feels challenging.

3.Question

What does Kay Cannon mean by the 'fine line' between being thoughtful and lazy in regard to writing?

Answer:The 'fine line' refers to the careful consideration a writer must make when confronted with notes from producers or studios. Cannon highlights that there's a difference between being lazy and avoiding work that's necessary to improve a script versus being thoughtful and standing by an idea that may truly be better than the suggestions made.

4.Question

Why does Kay Cannon emphasize the necessity of watching television or movies for aspiring writers?

Answer:Cannon stresses that in-depth knowledge of the medium—whether television or film—is essential for



aspiring writers. This knowledge helps them to understand the nuances of storytelling and character development, thus preparing them adequately when applying for jobs or creating their own works.

5.Question

How does Kay Cannon deal with the challenge of writing for multiple projects concurrently?

Answer:She shares her method of writing constantly during the week—during weekends, subway rides, and lunch hours—showing her commitment and passion for writing. This practical scheduling reflects her belief that true dedication to the craft requires continuous effort and a proactive approach.

6.Question

What mindset does Kay Cannon suggest writers should adopt towards writing?

Answer:Cannon encourages writers to adopt a mindset of gratitude and determination, recognizing that despite any frustrations or challenges, writing is a privilege and an



opportunity to create. She suggests that writers remind themselves of their passion for storytelling, fueling their desire to engage with their craft.

7.Question

What humorous method does Kay Cannon use to balance her writing and leisure time?

Answer:Cannon humorously describes her strategy of pausing a show on Bravo, writing until the show unpauses, then watching until it catches up, and repeating this cycle. This light-hearted method illustrates her approach to integrating leisure with productivity in a manageable way.

8.Question

How does Kay Cannon perceive her relationship with writing?

Answer:She admits to having a love-hate relationship with writing, suggesting that while it can be tedious and frustrating, she recognizes it as something essential that she must engage in. This candidness reflects the complexities many writers feel about their craft.



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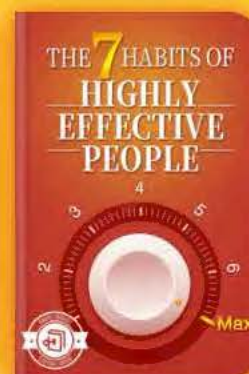
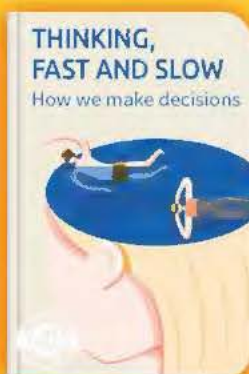


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Chapter 19 | Interview: CAROL KOLB (The Onion, Community)| Q&A

1.Question

What does Carol Kolb's experience with humor and adversity teach about finding joy in difficult situations?

Answer:Carol Kolb's journey underscores that humor can be a powerful coping mechanism during adversity. Growing up in a challenging environment with a tumultuous family life, Kolb used her experiences to craft comedy that reflects the absurdities and pains of life. This illustrates that embracing and satirizing our struggles can lead to not only personal resilience but also communal laughter.

2.Question

How did Kolb's childhood shape her perspective as a comedy writer?

Answer:Kolb's experience growing up in a small town, grappling with shyness and a tough family dynamic, led her to develop a unique perspective on life, which she translated



into her writing. She derived humor from sadness and mundanity, allowing her to connect with others who felt similarly out of place, thus using her childhood challenges as fodder for comedic storytelling.

3.Question

What is the significance of the Madison Museum of Bathroom Tissue in Kolb's journey?

Answer:The Madison Museum of Bathroom Tissue represents Kolb's creative spirit and her ability to find joy and purpose in unusual hobbies. This quirky endeavor brought her national attention and ultimately led to her joining The Onion, highlighting how unexpected passions can open doors to new opportunities.

4.Question

How did Kolb's early work at The Onion influence her comedic style?

Answer:Kolb's tenure at The Onion, especially during its formative years, shaped her comedic sensibility by immersing her in an environment that valued unique



perspectives on everyday life. The collaborative and underground nature of The Onion during its early days allowed her to hone her voice, focusing on humor that highlights the struggles of the common person.

5.Question

In what ways did Kolb's work at a psychiatric hospital inform her comedic writing?

Answer:Working at a psychiatric hospital exposed Kolb to a range of human behaviors and emotions, allowing her to develop a thick skin and a nuanced understanding of taboo subjects. This experience enabled her to make light of difficult topics with sensitivity and humor, contributing to her ability to tackle controversial themes in her writing.

6.Question

What advice does Kolb offer to aspiring comedy writers?

Answer:Kolb advises aspiring writers to write without restrictions by engaging in free, unfiltered creation, and to seek opportunities to write for others. She emphasizes the importance of developing a unique voice while also



participating in collaborative projects to become a better writer.

7.Question

What role does humor play in Kolb's sense of identity and career satisfaction?

Answer:For Kolb, humor is intricately connected to her identity; it allows her to critique societal norms and express feelings of outsider-ness. While she finds fulfillment in her career, she believes that a level of discontent fuels the creative process, driving her to create meaningful, witty content.

8.Question

How does Kolb view the relationship between comedy and current societal issues?

Answer:Kolb views comedy as an essential tool for navigating and commenting on societal issues. She believes that comedy not only provides relief but also encourages dialogue about serious topics, making it a vital part of contemporary culture.



9.Question

What reflections does Kolb have about the evolution of comedy since her beginnings?

Answer:Kolb notes that comedy has shifted from being a fringe or underground pursuit to a recognized career path for many, with younger generations approaching it with more strategies and goals in mind. She emphasizes the need to keep an original voice amid the saturation of ideas in the comedy landscape.

Chapter 20 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge:: Choosing Headlines at The Onion: WILL TRACY| Q&A

1.Question

What does the process of choosing headlines at The Onion reveal about the nature of creativity and humor?

Answer:The selection process at The Onion illustrates that creativity often involves rigorous filtering. With an overwhelming number of submitted jokes, only a few can be chosen, demonstrating that quality matters significantly in



comedy writing. It highlights the struggle between coming up with fresh material while avoiding redundancy, emphasizing that even the best ideas must meet specific standards to resonate. This reflects a broader theme in creative fields: the necessity of rejection and refinement in the pursuit of excellence.

2.Question

Why are some jokes rejected due to their similarity to previously published work?

Answer: Jokes are often rejected for being similar to existing material because originality is vital in comedy. The Onion aims to provide fresh perspectives rather than recycling familiar jokes. This insistence on originality fosters a unique voice that distinguishes The Onion from other comedic outlets, like The Simpsons or McSweeney's. It underscores the importance of innovation in humor to keep the content engaging and relevant to audiences.

3.Question



How do the accepted headlines differ from the rejected ones in terms of structure and creativity?

Answer: Accepted headlines often present a clever twist on familiar themes or draw on timely cultural references that resonate with current events. For instance, a headline reflecting on the humorous absurdity of a child wishing their father could attend Little League games captures relatable human experiences, making it both poignant and funny. In contrast, rejected headlines often feel forced, too obvious, or lack the necessary depth, failing to offer a unique comedic perspective or fresh narrative.

4.Question

What can be learned from the balance of smart and silly in satirical writing?

Answer: Effective satire often strikes a balance between intelligence and silliness, where smart jokes provoke thought while humorous elements keep the reader engaged. The Onion's practice of interspersing clever observations about societal issues in a playful manner demonstrates that such a



blend can lead to richer comedic content. This teaches aspiring writers that a well-rounded approach—combining wit with light-heartedness—can enhance the impact and appeal of their work.

5.Question

How does the Onion's reputation influence joke selection and headline crafting?

Answer:The Onion's reputation for sharp satire and unique comedic insights drives its commitment to producing original content that challenges norms rather than following trends. Understanding their brand identity, the staff carefully curates material that aligns with their established voice, striving for wit that sets them apart from others in the field. This commitment ensures that they maintain their credibility and engage their audience effectively.

6.Question

What impact does the rejection of ideas have on the mental state of writers?

Answer:Repeated rejections can lead to frustration and



self-doubt among writers, testing their resilience and creative mindset. As joke writers constantly critique their work and the work of others, they may feel the pressure of high standards, which can be mentally taxing. However, this process can also foster growth and improvement, as it encourages writers to refine their craft and develop a thicker skin in the competitive realm of comedy.

7.Question

What themes emerge from the Onion's selected headlines related to societal observations?

Answer: The selected headlines often reveal underlying societal critiques, touching on themes such as cultural absurdity, the disillusionment with media portrayals, and commentary on education systems. These observations resonate with readers, illustrating how satire can serve as a mirror reflecting the complexities of modern life while simultaneously engaging them with humor.

8.Question

What lessons can writers take away from The Onion's editorial selection process?



Answer:Writers can learn the importance of originality, the value of thoughtful critique, and the need for adaptability in their creative process. They should remember that quality over quantity matters, embrace the iterative nature of writing, and continuously refine their ideas to create impactful humor. Emphasizing authenticity while remaining receptive to feedback can enhance their writing's effectiveness and appeal.

Chapter 21 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: GABE DELAHAYE (Videogum, This American Life, Funny or Die)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of self-acceptance in writing according to Gabe Delahaye?

Answer:Delahaye stresses the importance of accepting that you might not be a great writer initially. He suggests that if you can get over the idea of being bad at writing, you can begin the journey towards improving and perhaps becoming okay at it. It's a gradual process that requires time and



effort.

2.Question

According to Mike Schur, how should a writer view the creative process?

Answer:Mike Schur emphasizes that the creative process is collaborative and that no single person should take sole credit for the success of a show. He believes that the experience should be seen as a collective effort where everyone's contributions are valuable.

3.Question

What does Todd Levin highlight as essential for writing late-night TV?

Answer:Levin points out that writing for late-night shows is meticulous, requiring extensive preparation. Writers must anticipate events that could happen during a live broadcast and prepare pertinent jokes in advance, but there's also room for improvisation based on unexpected live moments.

4.Question

In what way does Paul F. Tompkins define 'networking' in the context of creativity?



Answer:Tompkins redefines networking as building genuine relationships with like-minded individuals rather than merely seeking work opportunities. He suggests that when approached from a creative angle, it leads to more authentic collaborations and opportunities.

5.Question

What lesson does Kay Cannon highlight about self-awareness in a writers' room?

Answer:Cannon states that self-awareness is crucial in a writers' room; understanding your role and when to lead or listen is key to a successful collaborative environment. A lack of this awareness can lead to conflict and hinder success.

6.Question

How important is research in screenwriting according to James L. Brooks?

Answer:James L. Brooks finds research to be extremely important in scriptwriting, especially in comedy. He believes that thorough research enriches the writing and makes the characters more believable.



7.Question

What advice does Megan Amram give regarding the enjoyment of writing?

Answer:Amram stresses the need for writers to genuinely enjoy the act of writing itself. She warns that if writing feels like a chore rather than a passion, it may not be the right career choice for them.

8.Question

What perspective does Bruce Jay Friedman offer about being labeled as a humorist?

Answer:Friedman expresses discomfort with being labeled a humorist, indicating that while humor may emerge in his writing, he aims for a more serious expression of themes, contrasting with traditional humor writing.

9.Question

What is the underlying theme of Bruce Vilanch's advice on writing jokes for award shows?

Answer:Vilanch highlights the unpredictability of live events, emphasizing that while preparation is crucial, flexibility and the ability to respond to spontaneous moments



are equally important for effective comedy during award shows.

10.Question

What does Gabe Delahaye mean by "paying your dues" in writing?

Answer:Delahaye mentions that aspiring writers should be prepared to work for free initially, as this experience is essential for growth and getting noticed in the industry. He implies that this is an integral part of building a career in writing.





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Chapter 22 | Interview: GLEN CHARLES (Taxi, Cheers)| Q&A

1.Question

What does the story of Glen and Les Charles teach us about perseverance in creative fields?

Answer:The Charles brothers faced rejection and struggling times, even living out of a Volkswagen bus, before finally achieving success with their writing. This journey illustrates the importance of perseverance, showcasing how success often comes after numerous failures and the need to be unwavering in one's passion, even when faced with challenges.

2.Question

How did the creative environment of the MTM production company contribute to the success of shows like Cheers?

Answer:MTM provided a nurturing creative environment that emphasized collaboration among writers, leading to the production of several high-quality comedies. The sense of



community facilitated creativity and inspired writers like Glen and Les, highlighting that a supportive network can be pivotal for success in a competition-driven industry.

3.Question

What role does humor play in coping with difficult life experiences according to the content of this chapter?

Answer:Humor serves as a vital coping mechanism, allowing individuals to navigate the complexities of life, including trauma and adversity. The comedic approach taken by the Charles brothers, as well as the characters in their shows, illustrates how laughter can provide relief, connection, and understanding in otherwise bleak situations.

4.Question

What is the significance of the final scene's metaphor in Cheers as interpreted by fans?

Answer:The final scene of Cheers, where Sam declines service to a customer, has been interpreted by some fans as a metaphor for death. This interpretation suggests a deeper understanding of what it means to let go and the acceptance



of endings, reinforcing the emotional weight comedy can carry beneath its surface.

5.Question

What advice does Jimmy Burrows impart about the nature of comedy writing?

Answer:Burrows emphasizes that comedy writing involves continuous learning and adaptation. He suggests that there are no absolute rules in comedy and encourages writers to engage with their craft actively and to have an ever-evolving approach based on audience reactions and the dynamic nature of humor.

6.Question

Why did the creative process behind Cheers differ from that of Taxi?

Answer:While both shows explored deep character dynamics, Cheers sought to create a more inviting and warm atmosphere, contrasted with the darker, more melancholic tones of Taxi. The Charles brothers aimed for Cheers to be a character-driven show filled with warmth and camaraderie,



reflecting a shift in comedic tone that welcomed audiences into a comforting space.

7.Question

How did the early influences of radio shape the writing style of Glen and Les Charles?

Answer: Growing up with radio's emphasis on dialogue, Glen and Les developed a proficiency in creating strong, character-driven narratives with witty dialogue. This background taught them that good writing is about hearing the characters speak, which reflected in their successful sitcoms that prioritized dialogues over flashy visuals.

8.Question

What remains significant about Cheers as a cultural touchstone for television comedy?

Answer: Cheers transcended simple sitcom tropes by integrating intelligent humor with relatability, tackling serious themes while maintaining a comedic tone. Its influence on subsequent sitcoms, like Friends and Seinfeld, underscores its role as a cultural touchstone, setting a



standard for character development and narrative arcs in comedic storytelling.

9.Question

What does the experience of Glen and Les Charles suggest about the importance of collaboration in creative endeavors?

Answer:The collaborative dynamic between Glen and Les, as well as with other creatives at MTM, shows that shared ideas lead to richer storytelling and humor. This underscores the value of teamwork and the fusion of diverse perspectives in enhancing creativity in any artistic field.

10.Question

In what ways did the pressure to maintain a hit show like Cheers affect its writing team?

Answer:The pressure to maintain Cheers as a hit led to intense creative discussions and sometimes conflicts about joke quality and character arcs. This environment fostered growth and adaptation among the writers, but also highlighted the difficulties inherent in sustaining a long-running series amidst ever-changing audience



expectations.

Chapter 23 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding an Agent for a TV-Writing Job: JOEL BEGLEITER| Q&A

1.Question

How can a young writer acquire an agent for writing comedy for television?

Answer:A young writer can acquire an agent by: 1)

Graduating from a writing program offered by studios like Warner Brothers, Fox, or CBS, which

can lead to a stamp of approval and referrals; 2)

Getting a referral from an already signed writer; or

3) Submitting material blindly, although this is the most difficult route and requires exceptionally high-quality work.

2.Question

What is the difference in the process of getting a job writing for a sitcom versus late-night shows?

Answer:The process for sitcoms usually involves referrals and connections, whereas for late-night shows, it primarily



relies on submissions of joke packets with specific guidelines, as head writers typically hire based on merit.

3.Question

Is having an agent necessary for late-night writing?

Answer:While not strictly necessary, having an agent can be beneficial as they can provide information about job openings and help navigate the hiring landscape.

4.Question

What are common mistakes made by writers who submit material?

Answer:Common mistakes include having typos in their scripts, showing a lack of effort, not submitting polished material, or not having their work vetted by others before submission.

5.Question

How important is a cover letter when submitting material?

Answer:A cover letter is largely irrelevant; agents often do not read them, especially when receiving referrals from clients.



6.Question

Do you prefer original material or scripts based on existing shows?

Answer:Original material is preferred, as the industry has shifted towards valuing new ideas due to increased competition among writers.

7.Question

How can writers differentiate themselves in a competitive market?

Answer:Writers can differentiate themselves by showcasing their unique voice and original material to stand out from the hundreds of submissions received.

8.Question

How many scripts does a writer need to submit to land a job?

Answer:At least one great sample script is essential, and while having a second piece is good, writers should continuously produce new material.

9.Question

What type of writing can be submitted to showrunners?



Answer: It depends on the showrunner, but alternatives such as funny print pieces or short films can pique interest. However, most showrunners prefer structured narrative submissions.

10. Question

What is the difference between an agent and a manager?

Answer: Agents can negotiate contracts and secure work for clients, while managers typically help clients develop their material and long-term career goals without negotiating employment.

11. Question

Is it impossible to get hired without an agent?

Answer: It is not impossible, but rare. The path typically involves finding connections and working your way up within the industry.

Chapter 24 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MARC MARON (WTF with Marc Maron, Maron, Conan, Late Show with David Letterman)| Q&A

1. Question

What does Marc Maron suggest is an important quality



for success in comedy?

Answer: Awareness of one's talent and limitations is crucial. Recognizing how to adapt and finding your place in the industry is necessary for a sustainable career.

2.Question

How does Marc Maron describe his creative process?

Answer: He describes it as impulsive and filled with anxiety, highlighting that he struggles with planning and compartmentalizing.

3.Question

What is the relationship between hard work and finding success in comedy, according to Maron?

Answer: Maron emphasizes that while many factors can influence success, those who work hard and find their groove ultimately achieve something meaningful.

4.Question

What is the risk involved in pursuing a career in comedy, according to Maron's experiences?

Answer: The risk includes fading into obscurity or becoming



tragic, as many people do not succeed despite their efforts.

5.Question

How does Maron view the barriers to breaking into the comedy scene?

Answer:He suggests that entering the industry isn't a choice; it's often driven by an intrinsic desire to perform, which can seem irrational at times.

6.Question

What does Maron say about the nature of success in show business?

Answer:He points out that success is largely unpredictable and often depends on factors beyond one's control, rather than just talent or hard work alone.

7.Question

What advice does Maron give about handling failure in comedy?

Answer:He advises that comics must be prepared for both failure and success, and emphasizes the importance of getting back on stage regardless of the outcome.

8.Question

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How can relationships formed in the early days of struggling in show business affect a comedian's career?

Answer: These early relationships can provide critical support throughout a comedian's career, helping to navigate the ups and downs.

9.Question

What does Maron mean by saying "you have to find your consistency and your groove"?

Answer: This means that comedians need to establish their unique style and rhythm in performing to build a successful career.

10.Question

What underlying motivation does Maron suggest drives many people to pursue a career in comedy?

Answer: He mentions rebellion, a sense of entitlement, or even grandiosity as motivations that often propel individuals into the chaotic life of comedy.



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Chapter 25 | Interview: GEORGE SAUNDERS (Pastoralia, In Persuasion Nation, Tenth of December)| Q&A

1.Question

How did George Saunders' upbringing influence his approach to writing humor?

Answer: Growing up in South Chicago, Saunders was educated by nuns who emphasized grammar, syntax, and spelling, which equipped him with linguistic tools crucial for writing. This education instilled in him an appreciation for language and a sense of discernment, similar to how a chef might train their children in culinary arts. Moreover, his environment taught him that humor and profound truths often coexist, leading him to blend the serious and the funny seamlessly in his writing.

2.Question

What role does compassion play in Saunders' writing?

Answer: Saunders views writing as an exercise in compassion, where the objective is to engage deeply with



characters and their experiences. He believes that even the harsh truths in his satire can be compassionate because they encourage confronting falsehoods. This openness and willingness to explore different perspectives make his characters relatable, showcasing the complexity of humanity rather than adhering to simple labels of good or evil.

3.Question

In what ways does humor intersect with serious themes in Saunders' work?

Answer:Saunders emphasizes that humor and serious themes are not mutually exclusive. He believes that life's absurdities often highlight deeper truths, leading to moments of comedy that resonate on a more significant emotional level. His stories often present characters facing profound challenges while also infusing humor, allowing readers to appreciate the lighter side of difficult circumstances.

4.Question

How does Saunders discuss the importance of revision in writing?



Answer:Saunders explains that revision is fundamental to honing one's voice and improving the narrative. Initial drafts may be overly clever or convoluted, lacking the clarity and intent that comes from deeper engagement with the material. Through revision, stories can evolve to feel more true to the author's voice and the narrative's structure, securing a more authentic connection with readers.

5.Question

What insights does Saunders offer about the nature of storytelling?

Answer:He sees storytelling as a dynamic process, akin to a journey with a close friend. Each story has its unique path, and finding the right ending involves understanding the narrative's emotional flow and cadence. Recognizing when to conclude a story requires a gut feeling, often developed through a deep connection to the story's characters and events, leading to an intuitive sense of closure.

6.Question

How does George Saunders define satire?



Answer:Saunders describes satire as a reflection of love for a culture, suggesting that to satirize effectively, one must engage deeply with the subject matter. Instead of simply mocking, satire requires understanding and critiquing from within the framework of that culture, allowing for humor that is insightful rather than purely cynical.

7.Question

What does Saunders imply about the relationship between humor and truth?

Answer:He suggests that humor often emerges from truths about life that are complex and sometimes uncomfortable. The comic arises from the disparity between our perceptions and realities, illustrating that while life can be grave, it is also inherently comic, revealing the rich tapestry of human experience through laughter and absurdity.

Chapter 26 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding a Literary Agent for Your Humor Book: BYRD LEAVELL| Q&A

1.Question

What should aspiring humor writers focus on to attract



literary agents and publishers?

Answer: Aspiring humor writers should focus on building their platform and creating content that resonates with audiences. They need to engage with readers on social media and other online platforms, developing their comedic voice and honing their craft through consistent practice. Instead of relying solely on submissions, they should work on getting noticed through viral content and audience interaction.

2.Question

How can past experiences benefit writers in their journey?

Answer: Past experiences, even those that seem trivial or unrecognized, like Justin Halpern's early efforts on various sites, help writers develop their voice and learn what works comedically. Each failed attempt or minor success contributes to a writer's growth, leading to eventual breakthroughs.



3.Question

Why is it not enough for writers to simply have a great idea for a humor book?

Answer: Having a great idea is not sufficient because publishers are primarily interested in an author's marketability. They seek evidence of an author's ability to engage readers and generate buzz before the book is even published. Writers need to demonstrate a proven track record of producing hilarious content that connects with an audience.

4.Question

What is the common misconception about the luck involved in getting a book deal?

Answer: The common misconception is that a writer like Justin Halpern was merely lucky to get his book deal. In reality, his years of hard work and commitment to crafting humor through engaging content laid the groundwork for his success. Luck often overlooks the effort and persistence that goes into achieving recognition.



5.Question

What percentage of humor books are considered truly funny, according to Byrd Leavell?

Answer:Byrd Leavell suggests that about 97 percent of humor books are not funny, meaning only about 3 percent succeed in eliciting genuine laughter from readers. This highlights the competitive nature of humor writing and the high standards that aspiring authors must meet to stand out.

Chapter 27 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DAVE HILL (The New York Times, This American Life, Tasteful Nudes)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the main purpose of writing according to Dave Hill?

Answer:The main purpose of writing, and comedy in general, is to fully entertain yourself. Hill suggests that the more natural and uninhibited your output is, the better it will turn out.

2.Question

How does pressure affect creativity, based on Hill's



experience?

Answer: Pressure can cause tension and prevent creativity.

Hill emphasizes that when he feels pressured to do a good job, his work often suffers, whereas writing without that pressure allows for better, more enjoyable results.

3.Question

What realization did Dave Hill come to regarding his initial rejections in comedy?

Answer: Hill realized that being rejected by the comedy establishment didn't matter in the long run. Once he stopped trying to get attention and focused on doing his own thing, opportunities began to come his way.

4.Question

What advice does Hill give about failure in the creative process?

Answer: Hill advises that being okay with failing and embracing foolishness can actually be liberating. A lack of concern about potential embarrassment enables creativity to flourish.



5.Question

How did Hill feel about making his mother proud, and what did he discover over time?

Answer:Initially, Hill felt he needed to do something to make his mother proud. However, he eventually realized that she was proud of him all along, regardless of his career choices, highlighting the simplicity of relationships over complex pressures.

6.Question

What analogy does Hill use to describe life and its complications?

Answer:Hill suggests that life is much simpler than it seems; it can be likened to making spaghetti and sharing it with someone. This analogy conveys that the basics of life revolve around simple pleasures and connections rather than complex achievements.

7.Question

What does Hill emphasize about creating for oneself?

Answer:Hill emphasizes the importance of creating work that entertains you, suggesting that if you create something you



enjoy, it has a better chance of resonating with others.

8.Question

What insight did Hill gain about his writing process over the years?

Answer:Hill learned that allowing himself to have fun while writing leads to better outcomes. The more he can remove anxiety and focus on enjoyment, the higher the quality and enjoyment of his work becomes.

9.Question

What does Hill's experience tell us about the relationship between self-validation and external validation?

Answer:Hill's experience suggests that self-validation is crucial. When he focused on entertaining himself rather than seeking approval from others, he achieved greater success and fulfillment.

10.Question

Why is it beneficial to not care too much about the outcome of creative endeavors, according to Hill?

Answer:Not caring too much about the outcome reduces pressure and anxiety, freeing individuals to create more



authentically and enjoy the process, which can ultimately lead to better results.

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Chapter 28 | Interview: TOM SCHARPLING (The Best Show on WFMU, Monk)| Q&A

1.Question

What inspired you to start working in comedy and music at such a young age?

Answer:I started running errands at a music store when I was around ten years old. It wasn't just the money; it was my passion for music that drove me. I wanted to hang out in a place filled with records, sheet music, and everything related to music. This initial exposure fueled my obsession with music and comedy over the years, pushing me to combine them in my writing and performances.

2.Question

How did your formative experiences shape your view of success in the creative industry?

Answer:My experiences in various low-paying jobs taught me resilience and the value of hard work. I didn't have much guidance, which meant I had to teach myself the rules of the industry. Though it felt frustrating at times, I now appreciate



that journey, as it has made me who I am today and has allowed me to approach my work with a unique perspective.

3.Question

Can you describe the moment when you realized you wanted to pursue comedy as a career?

Answer:It was a gradual realization, but a key moment was during high school when I created an absurd story for a class project. Instead of writing a typical historical narrative, I wrote a hyper-violent, cartoon-like script. The delight of my classmates showed me that there was a place for humor in storytelling, and from that point onward, I recognized that I wanted to create humorous content.

4.Question

How important is it to take creative risks in your work?

Answer:Taking risks is essential; the easiest thing to do is not to create anything at all. When you put yourself out there, whether in writing, comedy, or music, you may face failure, but that effort is what matters. It's about trusting your instincts and connecting with your audience, even if the work



isn't perfect. It's that drive to create that ultimately defines your path.

5.Question

What advice do you have for aspiring comedians or writers looking to break into the industry?

Answer: Stay true to yourself and your unique voice. Don't get discouraged if it takes time to find your audience. Many successful artists faced years of struggle. Embrace the failures; they are part of the journey. Create what you love and believe in, regardless of whether it fits current trends. Authenticity will shine through, and eventually, you will connect with others.

6.Question

In what ways do you think your background in music influenced your comedic style?

Answer: My background in music has strongly influenced my timing and rhythm in comedy. Both require a sense of flow, setup, and punchlines. Just as music has structure and dynamics, so does comedy—with setups leading to



punchlines and moments of silence enhancing the impact.

This interplay gives my comedy a distinctive edge, allowing it to resonate with audiences.

7.Question

How do you balance your creative freedom with the economic realities of your career?

Answer:It's a constant struggle. I have the freedom to create what I want, which is invaluable, but I also have to find ways to support myself financially. This duality means I often need to engage in side jobs while pursuing my passion projects. However, I've learned to appreciate the hustle; it keeps me grounded and motivated to succeed in my creative endeavors.

8.Question

Why do you believe it's important to connect with your audience through your work?

Answer:Connecting with my audience is what makes my work meaningful. I create not just for myself but to share experiences and evoke emotions. When people relate to my content, it signifies my efforts resonate beyond mere



entertainment. It transforms the work from something personal into a shared experience, which is profoundly fulfilling.

9.Question

Do you think success in the creative field is a matter of luck or skill?

Answer:It's a combination of both. Luck plays a significant role, but skill and hard work are crucial in preparing for those serendipitous moments. When opportunity knocks, your readiness and ability to take advantage of that moment determine how far you will go. Being persistent and honing your craft is just as important as being in the right place at the right time.

Chapter 29 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Radio: BOB ELLIOTT| Q&A

1.Question

Who were the comedic influences for Bob and Ray as they grew up?

Answer:Bob and Ray were influenced by early radio comedians such as Stoopnagle and Budd, who were



recognized as the first radio satirists. They appreciated clever humor and inventive sketches that allowed them to visualize characters through audio.

2.Question

What aspects of radio comedy do Bob and Ray feel have changed over time?

Answer:Bob and Ray lament that today's comedy lacks the mystery and imagination that radio once offered. They believe that modern comedy often explicitly explains the jokes, diminishing the audience's ability to envision their own humorous interpretations.

3.Question

How did Bob and Ray differ from other comedic acts on radio at their time?

Answer:Bob and Ray diverged from conventional performances by not having a fixed 'straight man.' Instead, they both played off each other's reactions, fostering a dynamic where both characters contributed equally to the



humor.

4.Question

What was the significance of Tom Koch in Bob and Ray's career?

Answer:Tom Koch was a pivotal writer for Bob and Ray, creating several iconic sketches and parodies that became staples of their shows. His material was so well-crafted that it often required no revisions, enhancing the quality and immediacy of their performances.

5.Question

In what ways did Bob and Ray challenge social norms through their comedy?

Answer:Bob and Ray used humor to critique societal figures like Senator McCarthy during a time when few dared to do so. Their satire not only mocked public figures but also questioned the absurdity of political machinations.

6.Question

What does Bob believe was the secret to their long-lasting appeal in comedy?

Answer:Bob suggests that the essence of their humor was



character-based rather than simply joke-driven. This focus on relatable, sincere characters gave their comedy a timeless quality that resonates even today.

7.Question

Why do Bob and Ray believe their style of humor might not succeed in today's market?

Answer:They feel that their style requires a level of patience and longer formats that are no longer favored in fast-paced modern entertainment, where audiences and executives expect shorter, more immediate gratification in comedy.

8.Question

How did Bob and Ray's backgrounds influence their comedic styles?

Answer:Bob and Ray came from non-theatrical backgrounds, which allowed them to create comedy that felt authentic and relatable, stemming from real-life observations and experiences rather than theatrical tropes.

9.Question

What does Kurt Vonnegut say about Bob and Ray's humor?



Answer: Kurt Vonnegut described Bob and Ray's humor as embodying a 'beautiful innocence' and expressed that their comedy reflected a view of humanity's folly, suggesting that while humans can be hilariously stupid, they are not inherently evil.

10.Question

How did Bob and Ray's process of collaboration contribute to their comedic material?

Answer: Their collaborative process involved constant improvisation and exchange of ideas, which encouraged spontaneity and creativity, resulting in uniquely crafted sketches that felt fresh and engaging.

Chapter 30 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: AMY POEHLER (Saturday Night Live, Parks and Recreation)| Q&A

1.Question

What does Amy Poehler suggest is a key to improving your writing?

Answer: Read your stuff out loud. This helps you understand how it translates outside your head,



revealing any awkwardness or flow issues.

2.Question

How should one handle material you think is brilliant according to Amy Poehler?

Answer:Be open to changing it. Even the most talented people don't fight for every joke; you might find better ideas through collaboration.

3.Question

What sentiment does Ira Glass convey that Poehler reflects on?

Answer:Keep creating even if your work is generally bad; don't be discouraged by imperfections and embrace what's halfway good.

4.Question

What advice does Adam McKay give about fighting for your creative ideas?

Answer:He suggests you fight less for what you believe in and be more open to others' ideas which might be better.

5.Question

What is a common trait of successful collaborators



according to Poehler?

Answer: Being flexible and open to new ideas makes people want to work with you.

6.Question

What does McKay mention as essential for lasting in the comedy writing career?

Answer: Being persistent, a good collaborator, and being open to different styles of writing can lead to success.

7.Question

How does McKay view the path to creating original comedy material?

Answer: It's about time and persistence; everyone struggles and goes through half-measures to achieve originality.

8.Question

What lesson did Adam McKay learn from his improv teacher about creativity?

Answer: Always go to your third thought. The first thought is reactive, the second is fine, but the third thought is where originality lies.

9.Question

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What does McKay say about modern characters in his films?

Answer: They often embody unearned confidence and a disconnect from reality, reflecting a broader commentary on American culture.

10.Question

What is a significant piece of advice Adam McKay has for aspiring writers?

Answer: Don't approach comedy for fame or money; genuine love for the craft and persistence is what leads to success.

11.Question

What could comedians learn from the changes in the comedy landscape according to Scott Jacobson?

Answer: The landscape is competitive but evolving; adapting to new opportunities and platforms is crucial for growth.

12.Question

What should comedy writers focus on instead of networking, as per the advice in this chapter?

Answer: Jump in and do it! Start creating sketches and putting them online, as consistent effort is more important than who



you know.

13.Question

How might the rise of digital editing technology affect comedy writing?

Answer:It allows for more precise editing, enabling writers to sync comedic timing with audience reactions, and craft better-paced jokes.

14.Question

What error do many aspiring comedy writers make regarding their motivations?

Answer:They often aim for superstardom without passion for comedy itself, which usually leads to burnout and failure in the industry.

15.Question

In what way do McKay and Ferrell's films reflect the current American psyche?

Answer:Their films often showcase characters with unfounded confidence, illustrating a disconnect from realism, which critiques contemporary culture.

16.Question

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What does McKay believe about the role of comedy in discussing serious issues?

Answer: Comedy is a powerful tool for revealing truths and can travel across political lines, making it an effective medium for change.

17.Question

How does the comedy genre's growth connect to societal developments according to Adam McKay?

Answer: Comedy often spikes in response to political extremism, providing both an outlet and a means to process social turbulence.

18.Question

What technique does Scott Jacobson highlight as necessary for understanding sitcom writing?

Answer: Sitcom writing involves complex story structures that necessitate thoughtful planning, not just quick joke generation.

19.Question

What underlying message about identity does McKay express through his comedy characters?



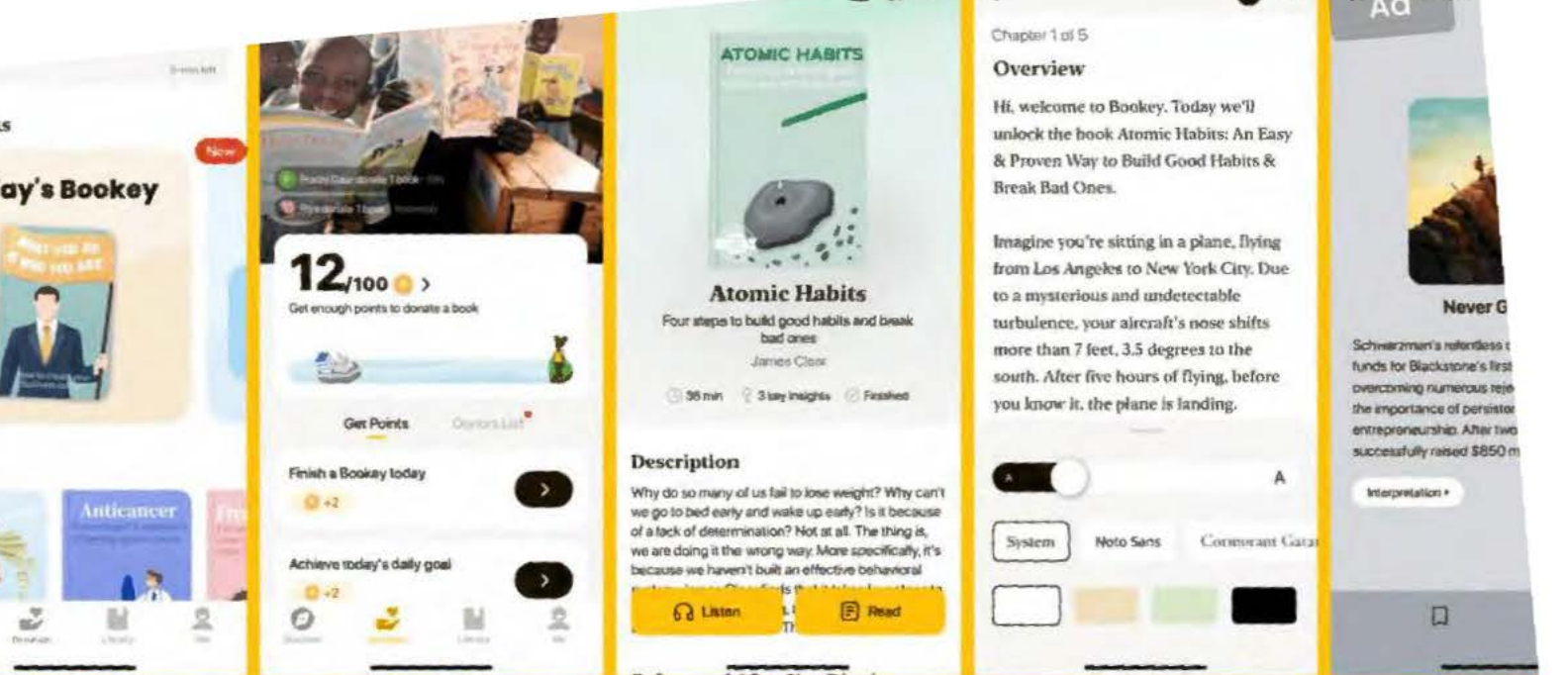
Answer:His characters often reflect the absurdity of American identity, caught in a cycle of ignorance and entitlement.

20.Question

What kind of comedy does McKay suggest is most valuable for audiences?

Answer:Anarchic, unpredictable comedy that breaks the conventional rules and challenges societal norms is the most impactful.





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makes me feel, it's like
It has to match my life.
happening around me
. That's where it comes
from.

- Boots Riley



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Chapter 31 | Interview: ROZ CHAST (The New Yorker)| Q&A

1.Question

What lesson can be learned from Roz Chast's approach to cartooning?

Answer:Roz Chast demonstrates the importance of merging visual art with words to create impactful humor, suggesting that creativity can thrive by finding a unique balance between different mediums. She shows that even ordinary objects or concepts can have humor by examining their 'inner voice,' thus encouraging artists to find humor in the mundane and to observe the world with a keen eye.

2.Question

How did growing up in Brooklyn influence Roz Chast's artistic style?

Answer:Growing up in Brooklyn during the mid-20th century exposed Roz to a diverse array of cultural influences, shaping her perspective on humor and art. It allowed her to view the world with curiosity and a bit of darkness, reflected



in her fascination with the bizarre and seemingly insignificant details of life, which resonate deeply in her cartoons.

3.Question

What does Roz Chast's success signify about individual perspectives in creativity?

Answer:Her success underscores that a distinct point of view, informed by personal experiences and cultural background, can lead to unique contributions in art and humor. It highlights that authenticity in one's voice can connect with others, making the ordinary extraordinary through creative expression.

4.Question

What role does self-doubt play in the life of a cartoonist according to Roz Chast?

Answer:Roz Chast acknowledges that self-doubt is a prevalent aspect of being a cartoonist, sharing that even after years of success, one can still feel insecure about their work. This reflects the broader human experience of fear of



rejection and the pressure to continuously produce quality work, revealing that overcoming this is part of the creative journey.

5.Question

How does Roz Chast find inspiration for her cartoons?

Answer:Chast finds inspiration in everyday situations and inconspicuous details that others might overlook, often through doodling or simple observations in her surroundings. This approach emphasizes the value of curiosity and attentiveness in fostering creativity.

6.Question

What is Chast's perspective on the future of cartooning?

Answer:Despite uncertainties about the future of traditional cartooning in print media, Chast believes that if someone is dedicated, they will find outlets for their creativity. Her perspective suggests optimism for creativity's adaptability in evolving formats, highlighting the resilience of artistic expression.

7.Question

What can new cartoonists learn from Roz Chast's advice

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about honing their craft?

Answer:Roz Chast highlights the importance of life-drawing and understanding the fundamentals of body movement and composition, stressing that mastering these skills is essential for cartoonists to develop their own unique style. It reinforces the idea that technical understanding can inform creative expression.

8.Question

What is one of Roz Chast's greatest challenges as a cartoonist?

Answer:Chast finds that dealing with the cycle of acceptance and rejection in the cartooning market can be a significant challenge, often leading to periods of self-doubt. She equates the unpredictability of sales and acceptance to a psychological experiment with rats, demonstrating that creativity often involves vulnerability to external judgment and the ongoing quest for approval.

9.Question

How does Chast perceive her identity as a female



cartoonist in a traditionally male-dominated field?

Answer: While aware of the gender dynamics, Roz does not overtly focus on her identity as a female cartoonist. Instead, she emphasizes the importance of her unique artistic voice, suggesting that talent transcends gender barriers in the creative realm.

10.Question

What does Chast mean when she speaks about writing and drawing in her cartoons?

Answer: Chast explains that in cartooning, writing and drawing are inherently intertwined, and each element amplifies the other. This speaks to the idea that successful cartoons require both components to work together harmoniously, creating a cohesive narrative that resonates with audiences.

Chapter 32 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: How to Be Funny as a Journalist: HENRY ALFORD| Q&A

1.Question

How would you define yourself in your writing career: as



a journalist, a humorist, or both?

Answer:I usually say both. My work is a hybrid, known for first-person, fish-out-of-water, investigative, humor-type pieces. I liken it to being 'George Plimpton, but with more leotards.'

2.Question

How important are labels in the writing industry, particularly for magazine and book editors?

Answer:Labels matter significantly since they determine how editors assign articles or choose book manuscripts. Being factual allows me to secure assignments and book deals, as pure humor without fact is rarely marketable unless you are a big name.

3.Question

What line exists between being funny in journalism and being mean-spirited or overbearing?

Answer:The line is subtle. To avoid crossing it, I focus on being fair in my representations and avoid unkind humor about individuals unless there's a defined professional



relationship. I self-sabotage by making fun of myself, which lowers the chances of offending others.

4.Question

What happens if you think you have crossed the line into meanness?

Answer:I reflect on past instances and recognize that while I may have been mean at times, I work to maintain a polite demeanor and respect others in my writing, even though the temptation to be critical exists.

5.Question

How do you approach writing about communities or subjects as an outsider?

Answer:I consciously avoid appearing condescending.

Acknowledging my outsider status, I aim to be generous and kind in my coverage, amplifying my own flaws to balance the narrative.

6.Question

What percentage of jokes are written beforehand?

Answer:Maybe 10 percent. The main goal is to calm my nerves and guide my focus before reporting, helping me to



deliver in real-time.

7.Question

What is the legacy of Spy magazine on current journalism?

Answer:Spy's influence can be seen in today's humorous journalism—especially in formats like charticles. However, its acerbic edge can lead to unfortunate outcomes in less skilled hands.

8.Question

What career advice would you offer those wanting to combine journalism with humor?

Answer:Start by closely studying publications that land humor pieces, then tailor your writing to fit that format instead of randomly submitting already written humorous essays.

Chapter 33 | Interview: DANIEL CLOWES (Ghost World, David Boring, Eightball, Wilson)| Q&A

1.Question

What does Daniel Clowes's work reveal about the struggles of individuals in modern society?



Answer:Clowes's comics explore the lives of not-so-lovable losers, highlighting themes of nihilism and existential despair in urban and suburban landscapes. Characters like Enid and Rebecca from 'Ghost World' represent a search for meaning in a disconnected world, emphasizing the struggles of youth in the face of monotonous, commercialized environments.

2.Question

How did Clowes's early influences shape his perspective on comic art?

Answer:Clowes was deeply influenced by earlier comic artists like Robert Crumb and the Hernandez brothers. This exposure led him to see comics as a medium to express darker, more complex narratives, contrasting with the traditional superhero genre that dominated the landscape, pushing him to explore themes of alienation and disconnection.

3.Question



What challenges did Clowes face when submitting his work to different publications?

Answer: Clowes's journey included facing skepticism from traditional comics audiences and markets who often viewed comics as children's entertainment. His decision to break away from conventional styles and themes paved the way for acceptance of comics as a serious art form.

4.Question

In what ways did Clowes adapt his style when moving from comics to screenwriting for 'Ghost World'?

Answer: Clowes retained his core themes of alienation and the absurdity of life in 'Ghost World', adapting the dialogue to fit a cinematic format, allowing for a deeper exploration of characters' inner lives. This transition showed his ability to navigate different narrative forms while maintaining the essence of his storytelling.

5.Question

How does Clowes reflect on his own childhood and its impact on his work?



Answer:Clowes recalls a vivid childhood filled with interactions with intellectual mentors, which influenced his comedic and artistic development. His fascination with the complexities of adolescence, reflected in his characters' journeys, symbolizes a longing for connection and understanding in a confusing world.

6.Question

What does Clowes say about the future of comics and graphic novels?

Answer:Clowes believes that the graphic novel continues to thrive in its current form, highlighting the importance of narrative and aesthetic quality. He discourages aspiring artists from entering the field for the sake of careerism, advocating for a genuine passion for storytelling as the true motivation for success.

7.Question

Why does Clowes prefer to label himself simply as a cartoonist instead of using the term 'graphic novelist'?

Answer:Clowes finds the term 'graphic novelist' to be



pretentious and feels it diminishes the art form by trying to elevate comics to a 'serious' status. He embraces the simplicity of being a cartoonist, which encompasses his unique style and approach to storytelling.

8.Question

What lessons does Clowes draw from his experience at Cracked magazine?

Answer:Clowes reflects on the creative freedom he had at Cracked, despite the lowbrow nature of the publication. He learned valuable lessons about audience engagement and the comic creation process, which informed his later, more refined works.

9.Question

How does Clowes view the commercialization of teen culture as portrayed in his work?

Answer:Clowes expresses disdain for the commercialization that targets teenagers, believing it creates a sterile and unfulfilling environment. He portrays characters who strive for authenticity and depth in an age obsessed with



surface-level consumerism.

10.Question

What is Clowes's perspective on the isolation often experienced by artists?

Answer:He acknowledges the solitude that comes with being a cartoonist, recognizing the mental toll it can take. Yet, he appreciates the importance of creative independence, valuing the ability to work alone to maintain the authenticity of his voice in his art.



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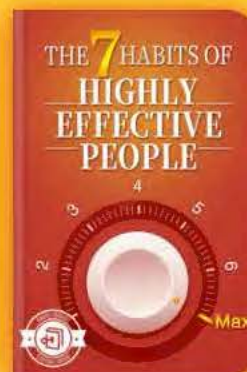
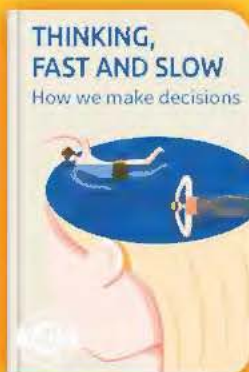


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Chapter 34 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Humor for Children: DANIEL HANDLER, aka “Lemony Snicket”| Q&A

1.Question

Why did Daniel Handler switch from writing for adults to writing children's books?

Answer:His editor believed he could write children's literature despite his doubts. She saw potential in his work, particularly because it was narrated by a teenager, suggesting it could resonate with younger audiences.

2.Question

What does Daniel Handler think about the evolution of children's books since the publication of his own series?

Answer:Handler notes that while there are still many syrupy kids' books, the good ones are receiving more attention than before, indicating a possible evolution in how children's literature is perceived.

3.Question

What influence did Roald Dahl have on Daniel Handler's



writing?

Answer:Handler admires Dahl for his dark humor and chaos in storytelling. He appreciates that Dahl's books, while fantastical, address serious themes without overly moralistic arcs.

4.Question

How should parents approach the anti-Semitism and 'nastiness' found in some classic children's authors?

Answer:Handler suggests it would affect social interactions more than reading their work. He argues for separating an author's character from their literature, recognizing that many beloved books come from flawed individuals.

5.Question

What does Daniel Handler mean by the 'tyranny of nice' in children's literature?

Answer:He criticizes the trend of sanitizing children's stories, arguing that authors often present unrealistic, overly positive portrayals of the world that do not reflect children's experiences.



6.Question

How does Handler view children's capacity to understand difficult realities?

Answer:According to Handler, children are already aware of life's chaos and heartbreak. He believes that they are equipped to handle truths about the world, often better than adults realize.

7.Question

What advice does Handler offer to aspiring children's writers?

Answer:He emphasizes the importance of rewriting and being willing to cut unnecessary words to improve clarity and impact, citing his own experience of drastically reducing the length of first drafts.

8.Question

What is Handler's perspective on humor in children's literature?

Answer:He believes that humor can coexist with tragedy and chaos, portraying life's absurdities in a way that resonates deeply with young readers.



9.Question

How does Handler address concerns about graphic scenes in his books?

Answer:Interestingly, he found that the tragic elements of his stories appealed to many children, suggesting they can navigate complex themes and appreciate humor intertwined with darker issues.

10.Question

What lessons does Handler believe writers can learn from real-life experiences?

Answer:He shares a witty anecdote about the necessity of resourcefulness, urging aspiring writers to embrace creativity in acquiring the materials they need to write.

Chapter 35 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANTHONY JESELNİK (Late Night with Jimmy Fallon, The Jeselnik Offensive)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the main reason Anthony Jeselnik chose stand-up comedy over traditional writing methods?

Answer:Anthony Jeselnik realized that stand-up



comedy allowed for more immediate interaction and refinement of his material, as it forces you to defend and perform your own jokes, which he found attractive. He didn't want to be isolated like a novelist, and found joy in being around funny people.

2.Question

How did Jeselnik view his journey through stand-up comedy in relation to other careers?

Answer:Jeselnik compares stand-up comedy to obtaining a law degree, stating that it provides transferable skills. You don't have to continue as a comic; the experience equips you for various roles such as a producer, actor, or writer.

3.Question

What key piece of advice does Jeselnik give to aspiring writers?

Answer:Jeselnik emphasizes the importance of hard work and perseverance, insisting that there's no shortcut to success in comedy or writing. Aspiring writers should start a blog



and produce quality material consistently.

4.Question

What does Jeselnik say about the quality of submitted jokes for writing jobs?

Answer:Jeselnik warns against submitting mediocre work, stating that bad submissions can harm one's chances of being hired. He stresses the significance of only submitting well-crafted, thoughtful jokes.

5.Question

What does Jeselnik mean by saying there's no real structure to the comedy world?

Answer:He points out that unlike formal education, where there is a clear path and structure, the comedy industry lacks defined methods for success, making it more challenging for newcomers to navigate.

6.Question

What does Jeselnik suggest about being pleasant in the workplace?

Answer:He shares a quote from Tina Fey about hiring writers who are enjoyable to be around, stressing that being nice and



pleasant can significantly impact your relationships and opportunities in the industry.

7.Question

How does Jeselnik suggest maintaining motivation in one's career?

Answer:He advises thinking of yourself as a train that needs to keep moving forward, consistently putting in the work ('throwing coal in the train') to keep progressing down the right path.

Chapter 36 | Interview: ADAM RESNICK (Late Night with David Letterman, Get a Life, Cabin Boy)| Q&A

1.Question

What defining moment changed Adam Resnick's life?

Answer:The defining moment of Adam Resnick's life was when he dropped out of NYU's film school to start working as an intern and then as a writer for 'Late Night with David Letterman.' He describes it as the greatest thing that ever happened to him and the first time he felt he belonged somewhere.



2.Question

How did Adam Resnick and Chris Elliott's friendship impact their careers?

Answer: Their friendship was crucial as it led to a partnership that resulted in several influential comedy works. Elliott credited Resnick with being a significant reason for his career's survival, suggesting that much of what was funny in Elliott's comedy originated from Resnick's ideas.

3.Question

What can be learned from Resnick's experience with 'Cabin Boy' and its initial failure?

Answer: Resnick's experience with 'Cabin Boy,' which was initially poorly received, illustrates that sometimes creative endeavors are ahead of their time. Over the years, the film developed a cult following, showing that even works criticized at release can resonate later with audiences.

4.Question

In what ways did comedy evolve during the time of Resnick's early career?

Answer: Resnick observed that comedy became increasingly



focused on relatable, trendy topics, often catering to younger audiences. He noted that modern comedies often revolve around male bonding and experiences like weddings or breakups, a stark contrast to the more surreal and darkly humorous narratives he favored.

5.Question

How did Resnick's family background shape his writing?

Answer: Growing up in a dysfunctional household led Resnick to feel isolated, encouraging him to spend time alone with books and records. This self-imposed isolation fostered a unique comedic voice that often drew from his experiences of observing the absurdities of life rather than participating in traditional social dynamics.

6.Question

What does Resnick say about the importance of originality in comedy?

Answer: Resnick emphasizes that true originality in comedy is rare and valuable. He reflects on how the comedic landscape has been populated with derivative works and



laments the lack of unique voices, suggesting that original thinkers in comedy are becoming increasingly scarce.

7.Question

What is Resnick's stance on compromising creativity?

Answer:He believes that while some compromises are necessary in the entertainment industry, the ideal scenario for a writer is to create what they truly want. Compromising creativity often leads to dissatisfaction, but there remains the hope that a project will ultimately connect on a creative level.

8.Question

In your opinion, what is the essence of Resnick's comedic style?

Answer:The essence of Resnick's comedic style lies in its surreal and subversive nature, often blending dark humor with absurdity. His work reflects a deep understanding of life's complexities and an ability to generate comedy from these nuances, rather than relying on simple, relatable scenarios.

9.Question

Why does Resnick express mixed feelings about 'Get a



Life'?

Answer: While he acknowledges the cult status of 'Get a Life' and appreciates the creative work put into it, Resnick expresses disappointment over the challenges faced during production, including disconnection from the network executives. He feels that the show could have been smarter and more aligned with his original vision.

10.Question

What does Resnick imply about the future of comedy?

Answer: Resnick implies that the future of comedy will continue to be about innovation and pushing boundaries, despite the current trends leaning toward safe and relatable material. He believes in the potential for new comedic voices that can resonate deeply with audiences once again.





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Chapter 37 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a TV-Series Bible: PAUL FEIG| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of writing a series bible for a TV show like 'Freaks and Geeks'?

Answer:The series bible serves as a personal reference guide for the creator, helping them organize their thoughts and clarify the show's vision. It includes detailed character insights, plot points, and the overall feel of the show, allowing everyone involved in the production to understand its essence. By creating this detailed document, Paul Feig was able to communicate his vision for the 1970s setting and the authentic experiences of teenagers, ensuring that the representation was accurate and relatable.

2.Question

How did Paul Feig differentiate between 'freaks' and 'geeks' in his show?

Answer:In 'Freaks and Geeks', Feig defined 'freaks' as



individuals who were more rebellious and into rock and roll—like those who listened to Rush—while 'geeks' were portrayed as more academically inclined and into pop culture, enjoying bands like Electric Light Orchestra. This distinction allowed for a nuanced portrayal of teenage life, demonstrating different social dynamics and personal interests that had not been extensively explored in previous media.

3.Question

Why does Feig believe it's important for teen characters to talk like real teens?

Answer:Feig emphasized that teen characters should reflect the authentic language and behavior of real teenagers, avoiding overly clever or adult-like dialogue. This grounding in realism fosters relatability and resonates more deeply with the audience, capturing the essence of teenage struggles and interactions. By avoiding 'teenage Neil Simons', he aimed to create characters that felt genuine and recognizable.

4.Question



What role does improvisation play in Paul Feig's approach to comedy?

Answer:Paul Feig allows for improvisation to maintain a sense of naturalism and freshness in comedic scenes. He believes that while scripts are important, the best moments often arise from actors' spontaneous responses, capturing the 'lightning in a bottle' effect. This method brings life to the dialogue and helps actors stay engaged, enhancing the overall comedic quality of the show.

5.Question

How does Paul Feig tackle the challenges of shooting comedy?

Answer:Feig finds shooting comedy exhausting due to the need for precision and spontaneity—capturing genuine moments while ensuring all technical elements are in place. He acknowledges that every moment on film is permanent, which creates pressure to maximize the humor and authenticity in each scene. Adjusting to the unique abilities and rhythms of different actors is crucial to delivering the



best comedic performance.

6.Question

What advice does Paul Feig give to aspiring writers about the importance of a series bible?

Answer:Feig strongly recommends that aspiring writers create a series bible as it helps in organizing ideas and establishing a solid foundation for the show. He believes that it's essential to have a thorough understanding of the characters and the world they inhabit, as this groundwork can prevent the show from collapsing under its structure once it progresses.

7.Question

How did Feig's personal childhood experiences influence 'Freaks and Geeks'?

Answer:Feig drew heavily from his own experiences as a teenager in the 1970s, using a series bible to recount his memories with great specificity. This personal connection to the material allowed him to craft authentic characters and scenarios that mirrored true teenage life, rather than relying



on outdated stereotypes or exaggerated portrayals.

8.Question

What challenges did Paul Feig face when pitching his show to executives?

Answer:Feig experienced significant apprehension while pitching to executives due to the fear of being unprepared or lacking confident responses to their questions. He felt the need to establish a robust narrative and character foundation through his series bible to defend his vision against prevailing industry trends and demands that often expected adherence to clichés.

Chapter 38 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: STEPHEN MERCHANT (The Office, Extras, An Idiot Abroad, Hello Ladies)| Q&A

1.Question

What motivates Stephen Merchant to pursue comedy and writing despite feeling guilty about laziness?

Answer:Stephen Merchant finds motivation in the process of creating comedy and writing, viewing it as a vital path to improvement. He admires his



heroes and recognizes that success in comedy requires persistent effort, akin to Woody Allen's belief that 'Eighty percent of success is showing up.' For him, the act of trying and exploring different avenues—despite the fear of failure—is more fulfilling than idle dreams of success.

2.Question

How does Merchant differentiate between stand-up comedy and sitcom writing?

Answer: Merchant highlights that stand-up comedy and sitcom writing require different skill sets. Stand-up is often based on personal observations delivered as solo performance, whereas sitcom writing must integrate narratives and character development. He warns against simply translating stand-up material into dialogue, pointing out that successful shows like 'Seinfeld' thrive by embedding humor within the characters' real experiences rather than relying solely on observational comedy.

3.Question



What are Merchant's views on originality in comedy?

Answer: Merchant believes that all ideas are essentially variations on existing themes, suggesting that true creativity doesn't demand absolute novelty but rather a personal and unique perspective. He criticizes the industry's obsession with market-tested content, arguing that while humor may generate laughs, it often lacks authenticity. Instead, he advocates for crafting comedy that feels genuine and satisfying to the creator, resonating more with audiences.

4.Question

What lesson does Merchant take from pursuing projects that eventually do not succeed?

Answer: Merchant sees value in the journey of pursuing various creative projects even if they do not succeed. He emphasizes that every attempt, even missteps, provides learning experiences and helps alleviate the frustration of untried possibilities. This perspective ensures he remains engaged with his artistry rather than settling for success that compromises his happiness.



5.Question

What should creators prioritize according to Merchant's philosophy on comedy?

Answer:According to Merchant, creators should prioritize personal satisfaction and joy in their work rather than chasing market trends or popularity. He argues that engaging in projects that resonate with them personally, even if they are unconventional, leads to more meaningful and unique contributions in comedy.

Chapter 39 | Interview: DAN GUTERMAN (The Onion, The Colbert Report, Community)| Q&A

1.Question

What inspired Dan Guterma to pursue a career in comedy despite his unconventional background?

Answer:Dan Guterma grew up in Brazil, where the style of comedy he was exposed to was notably different from the satire and sarcasm of North American comedy. It wasn't until he discovered the National Lampoon at age sixteen that he realized comedy could be more than just jokes—it could



serve to expose truths and articulate a worldview.

This revelation ignited his passion for writing comedy.

2.Question

How did Guterman's childhood experiences shape his perspective on humor and comedy writing?

Answer:Guterman's childhood was marked by fear and unsettling encounters with animals, which imprinted on him a sense of discomfort that influenced his comedic style. He recalls being terrified as a child, particularly by dark humor, which he later incorporated into his writing. This connection to fear is reflected in the darker themes he often explores in his work.

3.Question

What role did validation play in Guterman's journey as a comedy writer?

Answer:Validation was crucial in Guterman's development as a comedy writer. He described keeping track of how many times he made peers laugh in school, equating those



moments to self-worth. His compulsion to write jokes stemmed from a desire for approval, which fueled his need to develop his craft relentlessly.

4.Question

How does Guterman differentiate between writing for print (like The Onion) and writing for television (like Colbert)?

Answer:Writing for print, such as The Onion, involves crafting comedy that reads as fact, where the delivery is understated. In contrast, writing for television necessitates a more immediate, punchy approach aimed at evoking live audience laughter, where timing, economy of language, and direct engagement with the audience become key.

5.Question

What changes has Guterman experienced in his emotional health and creative process over the years?

Answer:Over the years, Guterman's emotional health has improved as he began working with more balanced individuals in comedy, showing him that one can create satisfying work without being tortured by personal struggles.



He's learning that he does not need to conflate his self-worth with his success, and he's recognizing that a healthier approach to writing can still yield great comedy.

6.Question

What does Guterman believe about the future of comedy, and how does he see his personal role in it?

Answer:Guterman is uncertain about where comedy will be in the future, fearing it might become unrecognizable.

However, he firmly believes that as long as the human condition exists, he will continue writing because it gives him the best way to confront personal issues and find relief. He values expressing inner truths through comedic storytelling.

7.Question

How does Guterman's sense of humor evolve with changing trends in comedy, particularly with young audiences?

Answer:Guterman expresses concern that today's younger audiences may prefer humor that lacks depth compared to the subversive comedy he appreciates. He observes a shift in



comedic preferences and wonders if the absurdist humor that resonated with him may no longer hold the same appeal.

8.Question

In what ways does Guterman describe the pressures of being a comedy writer?

Answer:Guterman describes the pressure of being expected to produce comedy consistently, often despite personal emotional states. The relentless demands to deliver material can be draining, as he must find humor even on challenging days, illustrating the intense mental and emotional toll the profession can take.

9.Question

What does Guterman hope to achieve as a writer in relation to his emotional health?

Answer:Guterman hopes to reconcile his writing career with a healthier emotional existence. He desires to produce comedy that reflects personal growth rather than turmoil, indicating a shift towards valuing balance in life while still pursuing his passion for humor.



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Chapter 40 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Working as a Hollywood Script Doctor: ALAN SPENCER| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary role of a script doctor in Hollywood?

Answer:A script doctor primarily works to improve existing scripts, providing feedback and edits to enhance the material for production. They are like utility players in the writing game, stepping in to address specific issues and make the work better, often without the emotional baggage of the original writer.

2.Question

Why might experienced comedy writers choose to work as script doctors rather than sell their own scripts?

Answer:Experienced comedy writers may choose to work as script doctors due to the risks and disappointments associated with personal projects. The rejection and emotional investment can deter them, leading to a preference for the structured, detached role of a script doctor where they can



still make impactful contributions without the same level of personal attachment.

3.Question

What is a key quality that script doctors should possess according to Alan Spencer?

Answer:Alan Spencer emphasizes the importance of having an individual voice that reflects personal experience and opinions, even when working on others' scripts. This uniqueness ensures that their contributions resonate and stand out, making the work better and more authentic.

4.Question

What does Alan Spencer suggest about the relationship between comedy writers and executives in Hollywood?

Answer:Spencer notes that the relationship between comedy writers and executives is often fraught with tension, stemming from differing priorities—creativity versus profitability. Writers need to navigate this dynamic with pragmatism and diplomacy to successfully collaborate.

5.Question

How does the audience impact the script-doctoring



process?

Answer: The audience plays a crucial role as their reactions ultimately determine the success of a project. Script doctors must keep audience preferences in mind while enhancing the script, as their approval is seen as the final verdict on its quality.

6.Question

What does the example of W.C. Fields portray about the struggles of creatives in Hollywood?

Answer: The example of W.C. Fields illustrates that the challenges faced by comedians and writers in dealing with executives have remained consistent over time, highlighting an enduring struggle between artistic integrity and commercial demand.

7.Question

How should a writer approach the writing process to avoid mediocrity?

Answer: Writers should approach their work with the intention of creating something authentically funny and



personally engaging, rather than playing it safe. If they start writing material that doesn't genuinely make them laugh, they risk becoming unoriginal and irrelevant.

8.Question

What does Alan Spencer suggest as a crucial element in writing scripts today?

Answer:A crucial element in writing scripts today is the necessity for powerful and satisfying endings. Spencer argues that audiences walk away happiest from a film with an emotionally fulfilling conclusion, reinforcing the idea that endings matter significantly in storytelling.

9.Question

What can we learn from the story of the writer who sold a bogus show to a network?

Answer:The story reveals that charisma and excellent presentation can sometimes overshadow content quality in Hollywood. It underscores the importance of having solid backing and verification for claims in an industry that increasingly prioritizes marketing strategies over creative



originality.

Chapter 41 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MIKE DICENZO (The Onion, The Tonight SHow Starring Jimmy Fallon)| Q&A

1.Question

What is the key to writing genuine and effective humor according to Mike DiCenzo?

Answer:The best humor comes from writing about things you're passionate about and knowledgeable about, as it translates better and feels more genuine.

2.Question

Why is it important for writers to maintain excitement about their work?

Answer:Maintaining excitement about writing helps keep your sensibility intact and prevents you from feeling like writing is just a job, which can lead to burnout.

3.Question

How should aspiring comedy writers approach their craft?

Answer:Aspiring comedy writers should write as much as



they can, using any platform available to them, such as Twitter or web series, since producing funny writing is crucial for improvement and getting noticed.

4.Question

What does Mike DiCenzo suggest about helping friends in the comedy business?

Answer:If you achieve success in comedy, it's important to help your friends who are also trying to succeed, as this creates a supportive community where everyone can win.

Chapter 42 | Interview: MEL BROOKS (The Producers, Blazing Saddles, Young Frankenstein)| Q&A

1.Question

What key lesson did you learn from your failures, especially regarding writing?

Answer:Failures teach you essential lessons about understanding your audience. I learned that sometimes my jokes were too personal or obscure, which limited their reach. It's crucial to connect with audiences, ensuring the humor resonates with



broader experiences.

2.Question

How did your early influences shape your comedy writing style?

Answer:My upbringing in Brooklyn and the comedic themes from street corner comics influenced the 'streetwise' aspect of my humor. These experiences encouraged a comedic style that appeals to the human condition mixed with absurdity, a reflection of my childhood environment.

3.Question

You mentioned the importance of rewriting. Can you elaborate on that process in your writing?

Answer:Rewriting is the essence of writing. The initial draft is merely a rough outline full of unpolished material.

Through thorough revisions, characters and stories mature into memorable pieces. Each rewrite hones the essence of the message, making the humor deeper and more effective.

4.Question

What role do characters play in your comedy writing?

Answer:Characters are fundamental; they drive the story. I



always start with developing them, understanding their desires and needs, which then shapes the humor around their journey. A good idea follows naturally when the characters are strong enough.

5.Question

How do you feel about the relationship between humor and mortality?

Answer:Humor serves as a defense against the fear of death. It's a way to protest against the inevitability of life's end. When engaging in laughter, thoughts of mortality tend to fade, offering a moment of escape and joy.

6.Question

What advice would you give to aspiring comedy writers?

Answer:Always ensure your writing makes you laugh from the gut. Never shy away from extensive rewriting, and persist despite setbacks. Comedy is a journey of exploration, trial, and revision—embracing failures allows growth.

7.Question

Can you explain why the audience's understanding is vital in comedy?



Answer: Understanding the audience shapes the effectiveness of comedy. If they can't relate or grasp the humor, the joke falls flat. Balancing highbrow references with accessible humor is essential for engagement.

8.Question

What does it mean to you to leave a lasting mark through your work?

Answer: Creating work that endures allows me to leave a piece of myself behind—like carving my name in a tree. It's a way to say, 'I was here,' ensuring that my contributions are recognized even after I'm gone.

9.Question

How do you balance highbrow and lowbrow humor in your writing?

Answer: Finding a balance is crucial. I blend intelligent satire with accessible humor to ensure a broad audience can engage with both layers of comedy. This duality allows for humor that's both entertaining and thought-provoking.





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Chapter 1 | Interview: JAMES DOWNEY (Saturday Night Live)| Quiz and Test

1. James Downey was the president of the Harvard Lampoon before joining Saturday Night Live.
2. Downey believed that 'claptrap' is an effective form of political comedy.
3. Downey retired from SNL after thirty seasons in 2013.

Chapter 2 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Monty Python: TERRY JONES| Quiz and Test

1. Terry Jones believes that comedy elicits stronger reactions than tragedy when done poorly.
2. Jones claims that there is no connection between poetry and comedy.
3. The preservation of Monty Python's original material was secure and faced no threats from the BBC.

Chapter 3 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DIABLO CODY (Juno, Young Adult, Sweet Valley High)|

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Quiz and Test

1. Diablo Cody grew up in a conservative Polish-Catholic community disconnected from Hollywood, which shaped her views on the entertainment industry.
2. Carol Kolb's unconventional path to becoming a writer for The Onion was influenced by her experiences from a toilet paper museum in Wisconsin.
3. Gabe Delahaye advises aspiring writers to avoid working for free and to only write what they think others will like.



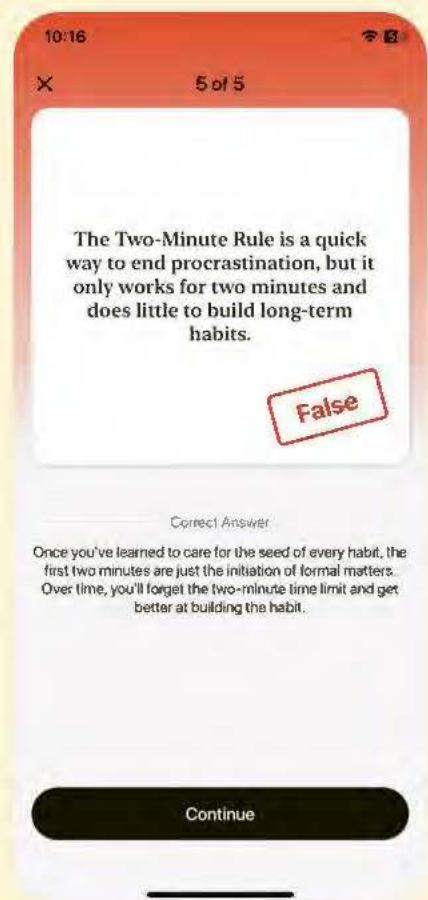


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Chapter 4 | Interview: MIKE SCHUR (Saturday Night Live, The Office, Parks and Recreation| Quiz and Test

1. Mike Schur was born in 1975 in Ann Arbor, Michigan.
2. Mike Schur prefers to work alone in the television writing process.
3. Schur advocates for the development of one-dimensional characters to ensure immediate comedic effects.

Chapter 5 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a Submission Packet for Late-Night TV: TODD LEVIN| Quiz and Test

1. Todd Levin believes that the skit "Riff, the Late Night Bully" is likely to air on Late Night with Conan O'Brien.
2. The 'Bootleg Round-Up Segment' is considered to have good comedic potential and a chance of making it to air.
3. Levin suggested that the 'New Character Parade' includes characters with distinctive and universally relatable traits.

Chapter 6 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANDRÉS DU



BOUCHET (Best Week Ever, Conan)| Quiz and Test

- 1.Andrés Du Bouchet believes that pursuing comedy is mainly a career choice rather than a means of self-discovery.
- 2.There are significantly more individuals pursuing comedy today compared to Andrés Du Bouchet's early days in the field.
- 3.Du Bouchet suggests that aspiring comedians should only focus on their craft for a short period before seeking success.



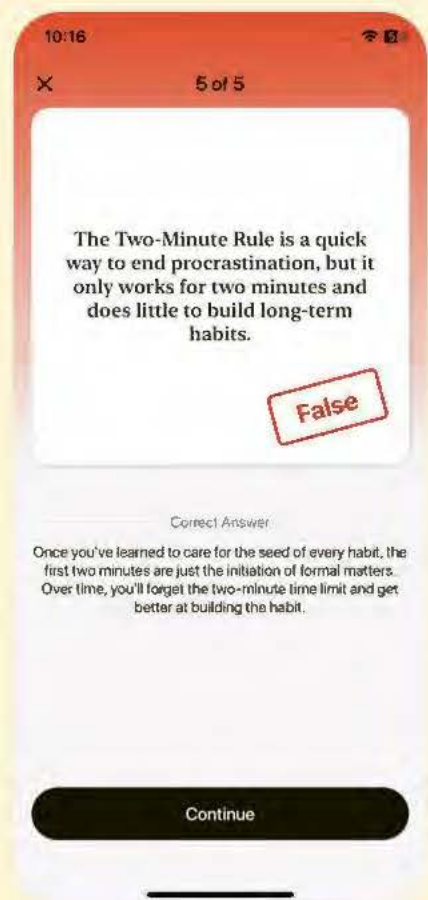


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Chapter 7 | Interview: HENRY BEARD (National Lampoon, Bored of the Rings, Latin for All Occasions)| Quiz and Test

1. Henry Beard co-authored 'Bored of the Rings,' which has been in print for over 45 years.
2. Beard transitioned to television and film shortly after his time at National Lampoon.
3. Beard advises young humor writers to write consistently and notes the importance of creativity not being affected by Hollywood.

Chapter 8 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Getting the Details Right: JAMES L. BROOKS| Quiz and Test

1. James L. Brooks considers Paddy Chayefsky's dialogue as overly polished and less relatable.
2. Brooks believes that research is essential in enriching scripts and characters.
3. Brooks feels that writing is easy and comes without challenges, even for experienced writers.

Chapter 9 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MEGAN



AMRAM (Parks and Recreation)| Quiz and Test

1. Writing comedy requires both playfulness and discipline.
2. Megan Amram gained notoriety on Twitter after being inspired to tweet jokes by a family member.
3. Megan emphasizes the importance of prioritizing social media over her writing job.



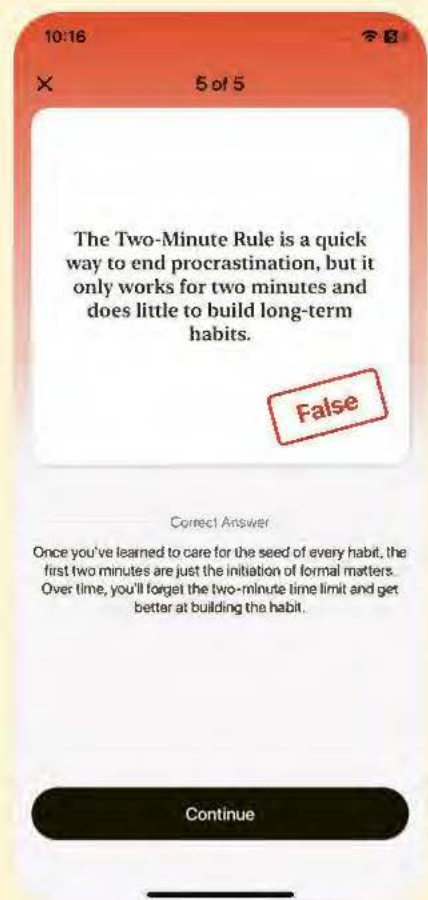


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Chapter 10 | Interview: PEG LYNCH (Ethel and Albert)| Quiz and Test

1. Peg Lynch was a graduate of the University of Minnesota and started her career as a copywriter before creating 'Ethel and Albert'.
2. 'Ethel and Albert' relied heavily on typical gag humor and did not explore life's minutiae.
3. Peg Lynch wrote over twenty thousand scripts for 'Ethel and Albert' without ever repeating any storylines.

Chapter 11 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Seinfeld: PETER MEHLMAN| Quiz and Test

1. Peter Mehlman wrote twenty-two episodes of *Seinfeld*, including famous lines such as 'yada yada yada'.
2. The term 'double-dipping' originated from a fictional incident created by Peter Mehlman.
3. Mehlman found that most ideas suggested by friends and family easily translated into *Seinfeld* scripts.

Chapter 12 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: PAUL F.



TOMPKINS (Mr. Show, Best Week Ever, Bob's Burger)| Quiz and Test

1. Collaboration in the arts is deemed unimportant according to Paul F. Tompkins.
2. Networking is primarily about seeking job opportunities rather than forming genuine relationships.
3. Dave Hill believes that writers should focus on seeking external validation instead of writing for fun.





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Chapter 13 | Interview: ADAM McKAY (Saturday Night Live, Anchorman, Talladega Nights, Step Brothers)| Quiz and Test

1. Adam McKay began his comedy career in Chicago at a venue called Second City.
2. Adam McKay's breakthrough in film came with the release of "Anchorman," which was the first film he directed.
3. McKay believes that passion is more important than fame for success in comedy.

Chapter 14 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Two Hundred Essential Movies Every Comedy Writer Should See: A List by BILL HADER| Quiz and Test

1. Bill Hader's list includes only well-known movies, such as 'Airplane!'.
2. The purpose of Hader's compilation is to serve as a guide for aspiring comedy writers.
3. All movies on Bill Hader's list are from the 21st century.

Chapter 15 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: SCOTT JACOBSON (The Daily Show, Bob's Burgers)| Quiz and Test

1. Jobs in multi-camera sitcoms are often considered



more desirable due to better professional growth opportunities.

2.It is easier to write for late-night shows than for sitcoms due to their slow-paced nature.

3.Scott Jacobson believes that the fast-paced nature of late-night comedy writing is more effortless compared to sitcom writing.



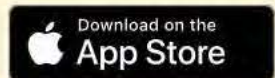


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Chapter 16 | Interview: BRUCE JAY FRIEDMAN (Stern, The Heartbreak Kid, Stir Crazy, Splash)| Quiz and Test

1. Bruce Jay Friedman is known for his role as a pioneer of traditional humor.
2. Friedman's novel 'Stern' is regarded as a masterpiece focusing on themes such as anxiety and anti-Semitism.
3. Friedman encourages aspiring writers to focus heavily on humor in their writing.

Chapter 17 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Jokes for Awards Shows: BRUCE VILANCH| Quiz and Test

1. Writing jokes for prestigious events like the Oscars involves little preparation and spontaneous creativity only.
2. The atmosphere during the Oscars writing process is calm and organized, allowing for thorough joke development.
3. The choice of host does not significantly affect the show's tone or audience reception.

Chapter 18 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: KAY



CANNON (30 Rock, New Girl, Pitch Perfect)| Quiz and Test

1. According to Kay Cannon, self-awareness is not important for success in a writer's room.
2. Kay Cannon emphasizes that writers should be vocal at all times, regardless of their experience level.
3. To be successful in writing for television or film, writers do not need to immerse themselves in the medium.





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Chapter 19 | Interview: CAROL KOLB (The Onion, Community)| Quiz and Test

1. Carol Kolb started her comedy career with a project that involved the Madison Museum of Bathroom Tissue.
2. Kolb's writing often explores themes of happiness and light-heartedness.
3. The Onion evolved from a major publication to a niche underground satire outlet under Kolb's leadership.

Chapter 20 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge:: Choosing Headlines at The Onion: WILL TRACY| Quiz and Test

1. The Onion receives approximately 1,500 headlines every week from comedy writers.
2. Rejected jokes at The Onion are often discarded due to a lack of originality or because they are previously published elsewhere.
3. All jokes submitted to The Onion are published regardless of their quality or originality.

Chapter 21 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: GABE



DELAHAYE (Videogum, This American Life, Funny or Die)| Quiz and Test

1. Gabe Delahaye emphasizes that aspiring writers should accept their initial inadequacies to improve.
2. Mike Schur believes that over-relying on irony is crucial for effective storytelling in comedy.
3. Andrés Du Bouchet suggests that aspiring comedians should ignore their genuine desire to write and perform comedy.



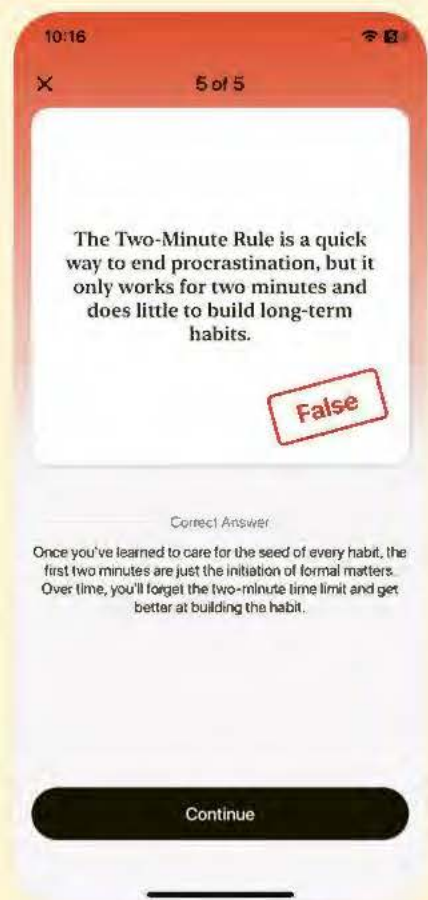


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Chapter 22 | Interview: GLEN CHARLES (Taxi, Cheers)| Quiz and Test

1. James Burrows directed the TV show 'Taxi'.
2. The Charles brothers, Glen and Les, grew up in a Catholic family.
3. The finale of 'Cheers' was significant and marked the end of a beloved series.

Chapter 23 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding an Agent for a TV-Writing Job: JOEL BEGLEITER| Quiz and Test

1. Graduate from Internal Writing Programs is the most effective way to secure an agent for a TV-writing job.
2. Cover letters play a crucial role in the submission process.
3. Agents are essential for securing all types of comedy writing jobs, including late-night gigs.

Chapter 24 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MARC MARON (WTF with Marc Maron, Maron, Conan, Late Show with David Letterman)| Quiz and Test

1. Marc Maron reflects on his career as a comedian with a structured plan that provided him with



direction.

2. Maron emphasizes the significance of building relationships within the comedy community for career support.

3. According to Maron, success in show business is solely based on merit and talent.



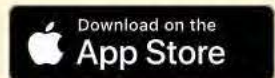


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Chapter 25 | Interview: GEORGE SAUNDERS (Pastoralia, In Persuasion Nation, Tenth of December)| Quiz and Test

1. George Saunders was born in Chicago and raised in Texas.
2. Saunders believes that humor can coexist with serious content in storytelling.
3. His writing style is based solely on intellectual concepts rather than intuition.

Chapter 26 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Finding a Literary Agent for Your Humor Book: BYRD LEAVELL| Quiz and Test

1. Literary agents are encouraged to wait for submissions from authors rather than actively seeking out talent.
2. Aspiring humor writers need to focus on building an audience to be taken seriously by publishers.
3. Byrd Leavell estimates that about 50% of humor books successfully deliver laughs.

Chapter 27 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: DAVE HILL



(The New York Times, This American Life, Tasteful Nudes)| Quiz and Test

- 1.Dave Hill believes that the primary aim of writing and comedy is to entertain oneself.
- 2.Dave Hill achieved success by primarily focusing on seeking validation from industry figures after facing rejection.
- 3.Dave Hill suggests that embracing failure can liberate creativity in the writing process.



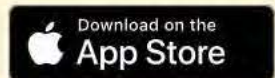


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Chapter 28 | Interview: TOM SCHARPLING (The Best Show on WFMU, Monk)| Quiz and Test

1. Tom Scharpling and Jon Wurster are considered a leading comedy duo for rock musicians, continuing a tradition started by Derek and Clive.
2. Scharpling's show, The Best Show, exclusively focuses on music and has no elements of comedy.
3. Scharpling believes that real-world experiences are unnecessary in comedy writing.

Chapter 29 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing for Radio: BOB ELLIOTT| Quiz and Test

1. Bob Elliott and Ray Goulding were part of a popular television comedy duo.
2. Elliott believes the unique appeal of radio comedy is that it engages the audience's imagination.
3. Bob Elliott feels that the comedy landscape today prioritizes subtlety over immediacy.

Chapter 30 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: AMY POEHLER (Saturday Night Live, Parks and Recreation)| Quiz and Test



1. Amy Poehler emphasizes the importance of reading aloud to recognize how material sounds.
2. Adam McKay began his career at the highest levels of Hollywood without any prior experience in comedy.
3. Bill Hader believes that writing for late-night shows and sitcoms requires the same set of skills.



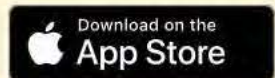


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Chapter 31 | Interview: ROZ CHAST (The New Yorker)| Quiz and Test

1. Roz Chast's cartoons rely solely on visual elements to convey humor.
2. Chast's upbringing in a Brooklyn household influenced her artistic perspective and style.
3. Chast believes that the future of cartooning in print form is very secure and has no uncertainties.

Chapter 32 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: How to Be Funny as a Journalist: HENRY ALFORD| Quiz and Test

1. Henry Alford has been a writer for over thirty years, focusing solely on humorous fiction.
2. Alford believes that successful humorists must incorporate factual elements into their writing.
3. Alford suggests that aspiring humorists should create content without a clear publication outlet in mind.

Chapter 33 | Interview: DANIEL CLOWES (Ghost World, David Boring, Eightball, Wilson)| Quiz and Test

1. Daniel Clowes was born in Chicago in 1961 and



initially studied illustration at the Pratt Institute.

2.Clowes prefers the term 'graphic novelist' over 'cartoonist' and embraces the commercialization of comics.

3.His significant breakthrough work 'Ghost World' tells the story of two teenage girls dealing with the realities of adulthood.



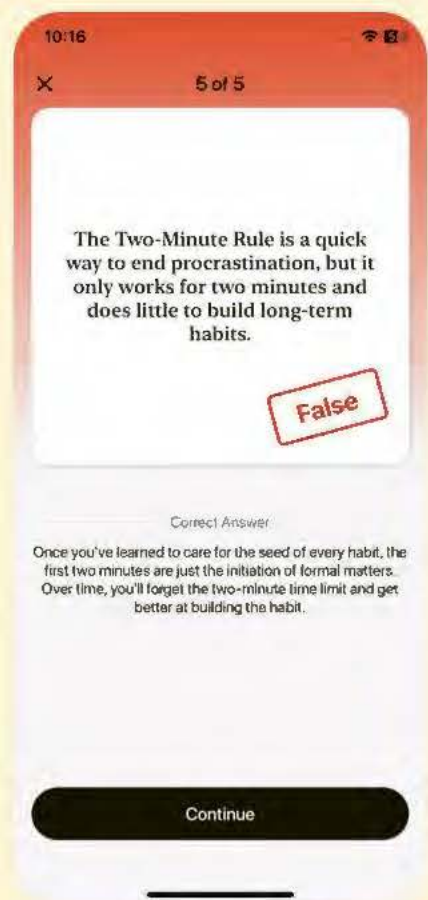
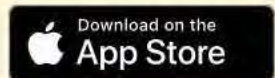


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Chapter 34 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing Humor for Children: DANIEL HANDLER, aka “Lemony Snicket”| Quiz and Test

1. Daniel Handler, known as 'Lemony Snicket', initially wrote novels for adults before transitioning to children's literature.
2. Handler believes that children's literature has drastically changed since 1999, with a significant decline in quality compared to earlier works.
3. Handler suggests that children should be sheltered from the darker themes present in literature.

Chapter 35 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: ANTHONY JESELNİK (Late Night with Jimmy Fallon, The Jeselnik Offensive)| Quiz and Test

1. Anthony Jeselnik initially aspired to be a screenwriter rather than a writer of books.
2. Jeselnik believes stand-up comedy is not crucial for developing writing skills and engagement with an audience.
3. Jeselnik advises aspiring writers to submit as many jokes as



possible, regardless of their quality, to increase their chances of success.

Chapter 36 | Interview: ADAM RESNICK (Late Night with David Letterman, Get a Life, Cabin Boy)| Quiz and Test

1. Adam Resnick was born in Harrisburg, Pennsylvania.
2. Resnick achieved mainstream success upon the release of *Cabin Boy* in its initial run.
3. Resnick prefers character-driven humor over formulaic comedies that target youth.



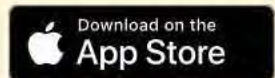


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Chapter 37 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Writing a TV-Series Bible: PAUL FEIG| Quiz and Test

1. Paul Feig wrote the series bible for 'Freaks and Geeks' to provide a reference guide for the show's characters, settings, and plot points.
2. Feig believes that the series bible is not necessary for organizing thoughts about the show and prefers to wing it during the writing process.
3. When hiring writers for 'Freaks and Geeks', Feig emphasized looking for spec scripts over original works.

Chapter 38 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: STEPHEN MERCHANT (The Office, Extras, An Idiot Abroad, Hello Ladies)| Quiz and Test

1. Stephen Merchant believes that all comedic material is essentially a variation on familiar themes.
2. Merchant suggests that writing sitcoms and stand-up comedy require the same skill set.
3. According to Merchant, personal satisfaction is less



important than achieving fame and monetary success.

Chapter 39 | Interview: DAN GUTERMAN (The Onion, The Colbert Report, Community)| Quiz and Test

1. Dan Guterma n has worked for *The Onion*, *The Colbert Report*, and *Community* throughout his career.
2. Guterma n believes that comedy only serves as a source of jokes and does not expose deeper truths.
3. Guterma n emphasizes that writing for television allows for more understated humor compared to writing for *The Onion*.



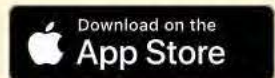


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Chapter 40 | Ultraspecific Comedic Knowledge: Working as a Hollywood Script Doctor: ALAN SPENCER| Quiz and Test

1. Alan Spencer believes that script doctors often receive appropriate credit for their work in films.
2. Spencer thinks that comedy in scripts should always be validated through test screenings to ensure success.
3. Spencer argues that strong third acts are typically a common strength in modern screenwriting.

Chapter 41 | Pure, Hard-Core Advice: MIKE DICENZO (The Onion, The Tonight Show Starring Jimmy Fallon)| Quiz and Test

1. Mike DiCenzo believes that the best humor comes from topics one is genuinely interested in.
2. DiCenzo suggests that losing enthusiasm leads to better creativity.
3. He advises writers to practice through various mediums to improve their skills.

Chapter 42 | Interview: MEL BROOKS (The Producers, Blazing Saddles, Young Frankenstein)| Quiz and Test



- 1.Mel Brooks won an Academy Award for Best Original Screenplay for *The Producers* in April 1969.
- 2.Brooks developed his comedic voice through formal theoretical study rather than life experiences.
- 3.Mel Brooks' films use humor to address serious themes, such as social commentary.





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